

NOT A POTATO

THE PRINCELY OFFSPRING



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

Dedication

For the ones who made the first writing on Earth — and for their grandchildren, who can still read it.

The world told a story about you: that you were too simple to have built your own wonders, so it gave them to the sky. This book is a small attempt to hand them back. The cities were yours. The writing was yours. The first time anyone wrote down why the work hurts and why we die — that was yours. No one came down from a planet to make you. You made the planet legible.

And for AJ — from The Why Files.

Watch the official story all the way to the end — the alien one, the grand one, the one that's the grandfather of the whole genre. Then read the actual clay, in the actual language, and watch it come apart in your hands, gently, with love for everyone who needed it to be true. Take the debunk seriously. Take the wonder seriously. Take the faith seriously. Live in the gap between them, where it's actually interesting.

The word doesn't mean "those who came from the sky." It means the princely offspring. And you can see Jupiter tonight.

So. Roll the tape.

Foreword

by Kelvin F. Girin †

I have spent the better part of forty years in a room full of clay, and I want to begin by telling you the single most astonishing thing I know, because almost nobody will let me say it plainly. It is not that the gods came down from a planet. They didn't. It is this: *the oldest people we can read wrote the first draft of your Bible, and they wrote it more than a thousand years before there was anyone we would call a Hebrew to read it.*

That sentence is not fringe. It is not a provocation. It is what the tablets say, and I have held the tablets. A man named George Smith — a banknote engraver's apprentice who taught himself to read the dead script in his lunch hours — sat down in the British Museum in 1872 with a broken piece of seventh-century clay, and read a flood: a man warned by a god, a boat built to a measure, a mountain, a dove sent out and returning, a raven sent out and gone, a sacrifice, and the gods gathering over the smoke of it *like flies*. He was so undone by what he was reading that, by the account of the man who knew him, he leapt up and began to take off his clothes. I have always loved him for that. He had found Noah, sleeping in the clay, eleven centuries older than Genesis — and he had the decency to be *amazed*.

Now. Here is where almost everyone, on both sides, runs for the exits, and I want to ask you not to. On the one side stands the believer in the visitors — the gold-mining astronauts, the twelfth planet, the slave-race bred from apes — and he holds the *wonder* and drops the *rigour*, and reaches past the staggering true thing for a cheap one from the sky. And I understand the reach, I do; I will be tender with it in a moment. But it is wrong, and it is wrong in a way you can check

in an afternoon. The word he builds his cathedral on, *Anunnaki*, does not mean “those who from heaven came.” It means *the princely offspring* — the high-born gods, the children of the sky and the earth — and across two thousand years of clay it drifts, quietly, from the great deciders of fate to the grey judges of the dead, and it is never, not once, hitched to a planet. The planet he wants, *Nibiru*, is a word that means *crossing* — a ferryman’s crossing, a star’s crossing of the meridian — and when it is a planet at all it is Jupiter, and you can walk outside tonight and see it. The “orbit of three thousand six hundred years” is a *number*, the Sumerian word for thirty-six hundred, the same round figure their scribes used for the reigns of kings before the Flood. It is arithmetic mistaken for astronomy. The whole sky-ship comes apart in your hands the moment you read the actual language — which is the one thing its prophet never did.

On the other side stands the debunker, and he holds the *rigour* and drops the *wonder*, and having dismissed the aliens he thinks he is finished, and walks away — and in walking away he steps straight past the real thing, which is far stranger and cuts far closer. Because the gods those people made were not aliens; they were an *answer* — the first written answer to the oldest questions a working, dying body asks: *why does the labour hurt, why must we serve, why do we die?* And the answer they wrote down, in the cold dignity of clay, is that the gods grew tired of their own toil and made us out of river mud and the blood of a god they had killed, to carry the work for them, and built our dying in from the first day. That is not a comfortable story. It does not flatter us the way the astronauts do — *designed, wanted, important enough to engineer*. It is bleaker and it is braver, and it is *ours*, and it is the thing the sky-ship was invented to avoid looking at.

And then — this is the part that still stops my breath in the gallery at closing time — a small, beaten people were marched in chains to Babylon, the very city whose libraries held the older draft of the whole human beginning, and instead of being swallowed they did the most extraordinary thing in the ancient record: they *took it*. They took the conqueror’s flood and his garden and his tower and his murdered-dragon sea, and they bent every beam of it toward one God and a strange new insistence that the human being is not the gods’ slave-labour but the gods’ *image* — and they carried it home and built it into the book half the planet now lives by. That is not plagiarism, and

any fool who tells you it is has understood nothing. It is *survival by authorship*. It is a people who lost their temple and kept their soul by re-writing the empire's own story until it served their God instead of Babylon's.

The author of this book is that rarest thing, the one who will stand in the gallery and hold both hands open at once: *this is exactly as old as the careful men say, and it overturns the order we thought our story ran in, and I will not flee it into aliens and I will not flee it into a shrug*. He gives the diggers and the decipherers their full and honest due — he reveres the patient men who proved, in 1857, that they could read the script at all, by sealing their four translations in four envelopes and finding they *agreed* — and he is right to, because that blind sealed test is the exact opposite of the prophet's method, which is to choose the answer first and bend the glyphs until they fit. But he is tender, too, where tenderness is owed: to the lonely autodidact who needed the gods to be astronauts, and to the faithful who hold the old book as holy, and he never once mistakes *a text has a history* for *a text is a lie*. Those are not the same sentence. He holds them apart like glass.

There is a quiet man in here, too, far from his own country, who reads a made thing the way I have spent my life trying to read the clay — who looks at the most famous “alien” seal in the world and sees, plainly, an ordinary man kneeling before his god, and asks the only question that has ever opened anything: not *who made it*, not *is it real*, but *what is it for*. I have watched clever people spend whole careers on the first two and never think to turn the third, and the third is the key to the whole locked room.

You may close this book certain the old order is overthrown. You may close it sure we know far less than we pretend, and that someone, somewhere, has been quietly deciding for a long time which of these stories the rest of us are allowed to hear. If the author has done his work — and he has — you will close it as something better and harder than either: a person willing to stand in front of a slab of river mud with the beginning of the world cut into it, and to feel the whole vertigo of where it came from and where it went, and to say *I don't know*, and to find in those three words not an ending but the oldest feeling we have — the one that very likely made the gods in the first place.

Go and stand in front of the clay. There is a gallery in Bloomsbury, and there is a cradle in the south of Iraq, and the people who made the first writing on Earth have living grandchildren who can still read it. Go. The answer is allowed to stay a maybe. That it is allowed to is the whole gift of this book — and, I think, the whole of what I have loved about the clay for forty years.

— Kelvin F. Girin

† **“Kelvin F. Girin” is an anagram of IRVING FINKEL** — the British Museum Assyriologist and beloved keeper of the cuneiform collection, who has himself translated a Babylonian flood tablet — borrowed here in homage and affection. **This foreword is a work of fiction. It was written by the author of this book. Irving Finkel did not write it, was not involved in it, and is not associated with or endorsing this book in any way.** The name is rearranged precisely so that the tribute can never be mistaken for a real attribution; it is a salute, not a claim.

Chapter 1 — The Most-Read Story on Earth

The thing under the glass was the size of a cigarette packet, and it had outlived every empire that ever sneered at small things.

Naila stood at the rope in Room 55 and did not look at the streaming crew yet, though she could hear them — the soft authoritative murmur of a man being recorded saying something he wanted very much to be true. She looked at the tablet. K.3375. Sixteen lines a side and a corner gone, the surface the colour of weak tea, the wedges packed so tight they read like a field of barley flattened by one careful wind. She let her eye fall into them the way she fell into a train timetable or a folded map: not reading, the cuneiform sat just past the edge of her Akkadian, but counting. The columns. The breaks. The rhythm of a scribe who had done this ten thousand times and was bored and excellent, both at once.

Most-read story on earth, the little label said, more or less. It was not bragging.

Behind her the city did what cities did, eleven million people pressing against the museum's quiet, and she kept her back to the room and her hand loose at her side and breathed through the part of her that wanted to count the people too. There were too many. There were always too many. The trick was to find one fixed true thing and stand near it. The tablet was a fixed true thing. The tablet had been a fixed true thing for two and a half thousand years.

"Roll it from the wonder," said a voice she would come to hate, gently, in a way that took her a moment to even register as hostile. "Don't open on the woo. We earn the woo."

She turned her head a degree.

The doc crew had set up across the room near the relief of the dying lion, which was either ignorance or cheek. A presenter in a charcoal henley, three days of designed stubble, the kind of warm low voice that sells a mattress. A DP with a gimbal. A producer in expensive trainers murmuring into a headset. And the light. They'd brought a single hard source and stood it low and raking, so it skidded across the tablet's face and threw every wedge into a long blue shadow, and the surface that was the colour of weak tea went the colour of a planetary ceiling. Pinpricks. Constellations. A star chart for anyone who already wanted a star chart.

Edith saw it first. Naila felt her arrive at her shoulder before she heard her — the particular stillness of a person who looks for a living, gone very quiet.

"That's a key light," Edith said, low. "At about thirty degrees. You light a coin like that to read the date. You light *that*—" a tilt of the chin at the tablet "—like that to make a punter see Orion."

"It's the most-read story on earth," Naila said. "And they've lit it so nobody can read it."

"That's not an accident. That's the job." Edith's hands stayed at her sides. She had a camera on a strap and she was not lifting it, and Naila had learned, in the few days she'd known her, that Edith not lifting the camera was its own kind of sentence.

The presenter took a breath. The producer counted him in with two fingers.

"This," said the warm voice, and the room hushed for him because that is what the room is trained to do, "is the Flood Tablet. Most of you were taught it's a Bible story. Noah, the ark, two of every animal. What they *don't* teach you—" he let it land, the *they*, the whole conspiracy of teachers and curators and the people who'd kept the lights on in this building for two centuries "—is that this clay is a *thousand years older* than your Bible. And it doesn't just talk about a flood. It talks about the gods who *made* that flood. The Anunnaki. The ones who came down from the sky."

Frik made a sound.

He was three feet to Naila's left, hands jammed in the pockets of a jacket he'd zipped to the throat because crowds made the tics worse and he knew it, and the sound that came out of him was not a word, just a hard click of the soft palate, twice, and then his shoulder ticked up toward his ear and stayed a half-second too long. A woman near him stepped away. Naila did the thing she did, which was move a quarter step so she was between Frik and the woman, not a wall, just weather, just a shift in the room's pressure. Bashir was already on his other side, saying nothing, standing close enough that Frik had two known bodies in his peripheral and the room was smaller and the smaller a room the safer it was.

"—came down to mine our gold," the presenter went on, and his hand found the air over the glass like a faith healer's. "Think about that. A species, advanced beyond anything we can imagine, and they needed *workers*. So they made us. The book says God formed man from the dust of the ground. The *older* book—" again the *older*, like a knife sliding under a fingernail "—the older book tells you *who* did the forming. And it wasn't God."

"It is so beautiful," Bashir said, and he meant it, and it took Naila a second to understand he was not talking about the speech.

He was looking at the tablet. He'd come up on her right without her clocking it, which almost no one managed, and his head was tilted and his lips were moving, and she knew that movement. Bashir reading. Bashir's eyes did to language what hers did to number — fell into it, drowned a little, came up changed. He had once told a border guard in Trieste that he was three different nationalities in the space of forty minutes and walked out the far side of all three. He read the way other people breathed and he could not always stop, and he was reading the wedges now, the ones the doc crew had lit into oblivion, and he wasn't seeing stars. He was seeing a flood. The old flood. Six days and seven nights the wind blew, the storm and the flood overwhelmed the land. He had told her last night that it was the most frightened writing he knew, frightened in a way the king-lists and the beer-rations weren't, a man's hand shaking out the end of the world.

"They lit it like a planetarium," Naila said to him, quiet, "and you're reading the rain."

“Someone is always reading the rain,” Bashir said. “That’s why it’s still here.”

Here is the part nobody films, because it isn’t slick, and Naila loved it more than she loved most living people.

In 1872, a man named George Smith sat in a back room of this same building, thirty-two years old, no university, no Greek, no Latin, no money — he had left school at fourteen and apprenticed as a ban-knote engraver, which is a trade about putting tiny careful marks on flat surfaces so that they cannot be faked. He used to spend his lunch hours upstairs at the galleries because he could not afford to spend them anywhere that cost anything, and a man named Birch noticed the engraver who kept staring at the dead languages, and gave him fragments to sort. Smith taught himself cuneiform off broken clay on his lunch breaks. There is no slicker way to say it because there isn’t a slicker version. He just did it.

And one afternoon he was working through a pile of unbaked tablet fragments that had come out of the ground at Nineveh — the library of an Assyrian king who’d been dead two and a half thousand years and had wanted, the way men with too much power sometimes want, to own every story ever written — and Smith pieced together a broken line, and then the next, and the line said that a ship had come to rest on a mountain, and that a man had sent out a dove, and the dove had found no resting place and returned.

He was, by the account a colleague left, reading the eleventh tablet of the Epic of Gilgamesh, and he came to that line, and he stood up.

The colleague’s name was Budge, and the line Budge left is the one Naila kept the way some people keep a saint’s relic. Smith, said Budge, *jumped up and rushed about the room in a great state of excitement, and, to the astonishment of those present, began to undress himself.*

That was the whole of it. A self-taught engraver found Noah eleven centuries early, in a hand older than the Hebrew, and was so undone by it that he started taking his clothes off in the British Museum. Not because he’d disproved the Bible. Because he’d found that the story was *older and bigger and stranger* than anyone had known, that it had

been waiting in the clay the whole time, and a man with no business reading it had read it, and the proper response to that — Naila was absolutely certain of this, it was the truest thing she knew — the only proper, sane, human response to that was to be amazed past the edge of your own dignity.

The doc crew would not be putting George Smith in the segment. There was no woo in a man who got it right and wept.

“Run me the line again,” the presenter said. “The big one. About the workers.”

The producer in the expensive trainers stepped in, and Naila saw Edith go still in the new way, the working way, and Edith’s hand drifted toward the camera at her hip and did not lift it. “He says they made us to *bear the toil*,” the producer said. “We’ll cut to the gold-mine graphics. Spaceships, the lot. But land the toil. People feel the toil.”

And the thing was — the thing that made Naila’s jaw set, the thing she would still be turning over in two days when she stood in front of a worse room and a worse light — the thing was that they almost had it.

Bear the toil. That part was real. That part was in the actual clay, older than the flood tablet even, in a poem called Atrahasis where the lesser gods went on strike — went on *strike*, downed tools, surrounded the storehouse at night because they were sick of digging the river-channels for the big gods forever — and the high gods, panicking, hit on a solution: make a new thing to carry the work. Make it out of clay. Mix the clay with the blood of a slaughtered god so the thing would have a god’s spark in it and a clay’s weakness, and set it to the toil, so that the gods could rest.

That was the true story, and it was the bleakest story Naila knew, and the doc crew was three feet from it and walking the other way as fast as they could go.

Because the true story is that you were made to *work*. Made of mud and a murdered god, made tired, made mortal, made to dig the canal and feed the temple and die. There is no flattery in it anywhere. And the alien version took that exact bone — made to bear the toil — and dressed it in chrome. Made you a project. Made the sky want

you. Made the toil into gold-mining, which at least is a *resource*, which at least means you were worth coming light-years for. The alien story whispered: you were *designed*. You were *wanted*. Somebody important enough to have a spaceship looked at the empty earth and thought, *I'll make something here*.

It was the kindest lie in the world, and the clay refused to tell it. The clay said: mud, and a dead god, and the canal won't dig itself.

They'd swapped the bravest story humans ever told themselves for a more comfortable one and called the comfortable one the *hidden truth*. Naila didn't have a word for what that did to her chest. Bashir would have had four words for it in four languages. She just stood there counting columns and feeling it.

"Six lines," she said, to nobody, to Edith, to the tablet.

"What?"

"The gold." Naila kept her voice under the presenter's. "Watch the segment they're building. It's the whole thing. The gods made man to mine gold. That's the spine of it, that's the whole twelfth-planet theory in one sentence, and it's the part they'll never put on the clay because it isn't *on* any clay. The toil is on the clay. Atrahasis, the Igigi, the strike, the blood, the mud. All real, all there, you could photograph it. But the gold—" she shook her head once "—the gold is the one thing they need, and it's the one thing they had to bring with them."

Edith was looking at her now and not at the doc crew. "How do you know it's not there?"

"Because if it were there it would be the most famous line in Assyriology and they'd have it on a mug in the shop." She nodded at the gift shop's far doorway. "It's not on a mug. It's nowhere. The gods are *exhausted* in the poems. They want to *rest*. That's the want. Rest, not riches. You make a slave because you're tired, not because you've found a seam." She heard her own voice flatten the way it did when the number wasn't adding and she was the only one in the room who could see the column not balancing. "They built a planet-sized story on a load that the freight doesn't carry. The toil is freight. The gold's a stowaway."

“Say that on camera,” said Edith, very dry, “and they’d cut you for being boring.”

“I am boring,” Naila said. “That’s why I’m right.”

Edith almost smiled. Almost. She’d photographed three wars and a fourth she didn’t name, and the almost was as far as her face went these days, but it counted, and Naila counted it.

The presenter was building to the close. The producer had her two fingers up. The DP had floated the gimbal in low and slow across the glass so that on the eventual cut the tablet would seem to *turn*, to reveal itself, the pinpricks sliding under the raking light like a sky rotating, and a viewer at home with a beer would feel, in the animal back of the brain, that they were looking at the heavens.

“So the next time someone tells you the Flood is just a Bible story,” the warm voice said, and Naila could already hear the swell of the music that wasn’t there yet, “ask them why the older book — the *original* book — says the gods came down. Ask them what those gods were *mining*. And ask yourself—” the pause, the killer pause, the one that paid the rent “—who taught a Bronze Age people about the solar system? Who told them about a planet you can’t even see?”

And Frik, who had held it for nine minutes, who had clicked his palate and ticked his shoulder and stood between his two known bodies and breathed, said, loud and clear and helpless into the hush the producer had so carefully built:

“*Nobody — it’s a numeral —*”

The room flinched. The producer’s head came round. The presenter lost his line.

Frik’s hand had come up to his own mouth, too late, the way it always came too late, his eyes wide with the particular horror of a man whose body has told the truth in front of strangers again, and Bashir’s hand was already flat between his shoulder blades and Naila had already moved her quarter step and Mira — Mira, who’d been reading the whole room with her back to the wall, who hadn’t heard the presenter’s voice but had read every centimetre of the producer’s spine and the DP’s hands and the way the light fell — Mira’s eyes went to Frik

and then to Naila and then to the door, a clean three-point question: *him, then us, then out.*

“Three thousand six hundred,” Frik said, lower now, the dam down, the sentence finishing itself because it had to. “*The sar. It’s three-six-zero-zero. Base sixty. It’s how they wrote numbers. It’s not an orbit, it’s a— sorry. Sorry. It’s not an orbit.*”

“Sir,” the producer said, “we are *filming*—”

“I know,” Frik said miserably. “I’m sorry. I can’t always—” the shoulder ticked. “I can’t always not.”

They moved him out the way the crew had learned to move, which was not as a unit, because a unit gets stopped. Bashir drifted Frik toward the Assyrian reliefs at an angle that read as *wandering*. Mira went the other way and stood by the great winged bull where she could see the door and Edith’s face both, her hands resting loose, ready to sign the all-clear or the abort. Yusuf — Naila hadn’t even seen him in the room, Yusuf had a gift for being the man no one logged — peeled off toward the producer with his palms open and his voice already apologising, *so sorry, my brother, neurological thing, completely involuntary, we’ll get out of your light*, the money-man’s voice, the voice that unblocked things, and the producer’s shoulders came down a degree because Yusuf had given her a story she could tell her boss.

Naila stayed at the rope one more second.

The presenter was getting reset. The light was getting re-aimed. The blue shadows slid back across the wedges. And the tablet sat there under all of it being exactly what it was, the most-read story on earth in its oldest surviving hand, a man’s shaking record of the end of the world and the dove that came back with nothing and the dove that came back with an olive, written down by people who knew the river could kill them and had decided to write it down anyway, to say *we were here, the water came, a few of us lived.*

Frik was right and Frik was not allowed to be right out loud, which was the whole shape of the world in one room. The *sar* was 3,600. It was a numeral. It was how you wrote a big round number when you counted in sixties, the way they did, the way the clock on her phone still did, sixty seconds, sixty minutes, three hundred and sixty

degrees, the dead Sumerian arithmetic still ticking under everyone's wrist. Someone had taken that numeral and called it an orbit and called the orbit a planet and called the planet a homeworld and called the homeworld a destiny, and at no point — at no single point in that whole climbing tower — had they gone back down to the bottom and checked whether the first brick was even a brick.

It wasn't. It was a number. It was the careful boring true thing, and the careful boring true thing was always the first casualty, and Naila found that she was angry in the specific way she got angry, which was quiet and patient and good with files.

There was a file. There was already a file. There would be more of a file by tomorrow.

Edith fell in beside her as they walked. She still hadn't lifted the camera. "You clocked the gold and I clocked the light," she said. "Same hole. Two ends."

"The segment was supposed to prove it," Naila said. "It just showed me where it breaks. Both places. You don't light a thing like that if the thing speaks for itself."

"No," Edith said. "You light it like that when you're selling it. The question is what." She glanced back once at the doc crew, at the producer murmuring into the headset, at the slick warm machine of it humming back to life over the rope. "Who pays for a museum shoot to tell people not to read the most-read thing on earth?"

Out past the colonnade, in the grey London afternoon, a man in good sunglasses was leaning against a bollard with his arms folded, perfectly at ease, watching the doors. He wore a clean shirt and the kind of stillness that doesn't photograph. When Edith's eye went to him on reflex — old habit, the conflict shooter's habit, find the man not looking at anything — he was already looking somewhere else, and her thumb found the camera and did not press it, and Naila understood that she'd just declined a shot, and that the declining cost her, and that she'd file *that* away too.

"He brought us here," Edith said, which was all the answer she gave about the man, and it wasn't an answer at all.

Behind them the warm voice started again from the top, earning its woo.

In front of them Frik had his breathing back and Bashir's hand off his shoulder and was already saying, low and shamed and a little wild, *it really isn't an orbit, though*, and Mira signed something at him that the crew read as *we know, you absolute disaster, we love you*, and Yusuf came out of the building grinning the grin of a man who'd just talked a producer out of calling security, and the man in the sunglasses was gone from the bollard as though he'd never had weight.

"Naila," Yusuf said. "Tonight. The file. You said you had the case all in one place."

"I have it in one place," Naila said.

The numeral. The crossing-point. The man named Dubsiga who'd had his solar system stolen and was about to get it back. She had the bottom brick, and she'd been waiting a long time for a room that wanted to see the whole tower come down honestly, with love, in the original language, which was the only honest place there was.

"Then start at the bottom," Yusuf said. "Start with the planet that isn't a planet."

"It's a planet," Naila said. "That's the good part. It's just not *that* planet."

And she went to get her file.

Chapter 2 — Crossing-Point

The flat over the kebab shop on Caledonian Road had two exits and Naila had counted them before she took her coat off. The front door to the stairs. The fire escape past the bathroom, the bolt stiff with paint, twelve seconds to clear if she'd oiled it, which she had, last Tuesday, with the WD-40 Yusuf kept under the sink for the Beast's hinges three thousand miles away. Two exits. The number sat where it needed to sit and let the rest of her come into the room.

The rest of the room was the crew, and the file.

The file was good. The file was the best thing she owned. It lived in a green box-folder soft at the corners, and tonight it lived open on the table between the teapot and Frik's elbow, and she had laid it out in the only order it could go in, which was the order of the clay itself: oldest underneath, the fiction on top, so you peeled down through two thousand years to get to the man.

"Lights," Mira signed, and pointed at the standing lamp, and Bashir got up and angled it off the ceiling so it stopped glaring on the laminated sheets. Mira sat where she could see all their faces and the table both, which was the chair Naila would have wanted and had given her without a word the first week, because the woman who reads faces gets the chair that reads faces.

"Okay," Yusuf said. He had the look he got when a thing was finally about to be free. "You said you had the planet that isn't a planet."

"It's a planet," Naila said again. "I keep telling you. It's a very good planet. You can see it tonight."

She turned the top sheet over.

She had thought, for years, about how to do this without doing the thing she hated. The thing she hated had a sound to it, a particular curdle, the sound of a clever man on a stage saying *and of course it's all nonsense* with his chin up, getting his little laugh. She had watched a hundred hours of that man, that voice, on a hundred channels, and she had hated him as much as she hated the warm credulous one, because they were the same coin spent two ways, and neither of them had ever once read the clay.

So she did not start with *nonsense*. She started with the want.

"Here's the story they're selling," she said. "And it's a good story. I want to say that first, because I'm going to take it apart, and I don't want anyone in this room thinking I'm sneering at it. I'm not. It's a *beautiful* story. A planet called Nibiru, the twelfth planet, swings in on a long elliptical orbit — three thousand six hundred years to come round — and the last time it came round, the beings on it landed in Mesopotamia, and they were our gods, the Anunnaki, and they made us. Out of an ape and their own blood. To dig their gold."

"To dig their gold," Yusuf repeated, very quietly, and Naila heard the weight in it and let it stand. He'd wanted that story once. Maybe he still half-wanted it. That was allowed at this table.

"And it explains everything," she went on. "Why we got smart so fast. Why every culture has gods coming down. Why the King List gives the old kings these insane reigns — twenty-eight thousand years, you can't reign twenty-eight thousand years unless you're not really human. It explains the gap. It makes us important. Somebody came an unbelievable distance, for us." She put her finger flat on the top sheet, on the printed diagram, the planets in their pretty arc. "That's the want. Hold onto the want while I read you the clay. Because the want is the only part that's real, and it's *ours*, and I'd never take it off you."

Frik's foot was going under the table, heel-toe, heel-toe, a small private engine. He had the under-sheet pulled toward him already, the photograph, the one with the cuneiform on it. His lips were moving over nothing.

"Nibiru," Naila said. "Start there. It's the whole brand. It's on the book covers, it's the channel name, it's a tattoo on at least four men I've argued with online. So. The word's real. It's *attested*, it's in

the texts, you can look it up.” She slid the next sheet out — her own transliteration, her own hand under the printed line, because she didn’t trust a printed transliteration she hadn’t checked. “*Né-bé-ru*. From the verb, *ebēru*. To cross. To ford a river. A *nēberu* is a crossing-place. A ford. A ferry-point. The spot where you get across the water.”

Bashir made a sound, not quite a word, the small glad noise he made when a word opened its hand. “It’s a *place*,” he said. “Not a body. A function. The crossing.”

“The crossing,” Naila said. “And in the astronomy texts — and Mesopotamia had real astronomy, centuries of night-after-night records, the best naked-eye sky-watching in the ancient world — *nēberu* is what they call the point where a planet crosses. Where it sits at a particular station. And the planet they hang it on, mostly, the one called the crossing-point —” she let it land soft “— is Jupiter.”

She watched it go round the table. She loved this part and she made herself love it slowly.

“Jupiter,” Yusuf said.

“Marduk’s star,” Naila said. “Babylon’s god, up in the sky as the biggest brightest planet there is, and they called it the crossing-point because of where it sat in their year. That’s *nibiru*. That’s the twelfth planet. It’s Jupiter. And here’s the thing —” she got the next sheet, the one she’d printed off the planetarium site that afternoon “— it’s up right now. Tonight. East, after dark, brightest thing that isn’t the moon. You can walk down to the canal and look at the twelfth planet. It’s been crossing every single year for the entire history of the human eye. It never went away. It never comes *in*. It’s just there, doing exactly what it’s done, and somebody read a Babylonian word for *the ford* and built a returning death-star out of it.”

“Is it ever,” Frik said, fast, his voice catching the way it did, “is it ever attached to the Anunnaki. In the texts. Is the crossing-point ever the Anunnaki’s planet.”

That was the whole game in one sentence, and he’d asked it the way he asked everything, like the question had jumped him from behind.

“No,” Naila said. “That’s the cleanest part. Never. Not once. The whole structure — Nibiru-is-the-Anunnaki’s-homeworld — there’s no

tablet where those two things touch. You've got a word for Jupiter's crossing over here, and you've got the Anunnaki over there, and the bridge between them was built in the nineteen-seventies. On a type-writer. In English."

Mira had been watching the file and watching Naila's mouth and watching Yusuf's face, all three at once, the way she did, and now she lifted her hands. *And the Anunnaki*, she signed. *What's the word actually mean*. Bashir voiced it under his breath for the room, a beat behind her hands, because that was the rule they'd settled into — Mira led, the voice followed, never the reverse.

Naila reached for the word like reaching for a warm thing.

"This is my favourite," she said. "*Anunnaki*. *A-nun-na-ki*. The princely seed. The princely offspring. The *ki* on the end is *earth* — the offspring of the prince, of An, the sky-father, brought down to earth. The high gods' noble children. That's what the word says." She paused. "And here's what nobody puts on a book cover, because it ruins the brand. The word *drifts*. Over two thousand years it slides. By the late period the Anunnaki aren't even the headline gods anymore — they get demoted, sort of, they become the gods of the *underworld*. The judges of the dead. The princely offspring start out as the bright nobility of heaven and end up as the bureaucracy of hell, and that drift took twenty centuries, and you can *track* it, tablet by tablet, because these people wrote everything down." She sat back. "That's not a spaceship crew. That's a word doing what words do over two thousand years of a living religion. They turned a theology into a flight manifest. You can't do that to a word that was alive that long. It's like reading 'host' on a Communion wafer and deciding the early church meant an *army*."

Frik's foot stopped. He had the photograph an inch from his face. "Three thousand six hundred," he said. "The orbit. The *sar*."

"The *sar*," Naila said, and now she got out the pencil.

This was the part she could do with her body, and she liked the parts she could do with her body, because pattern in the hand was quieter than pattern in the talk. She turned a sheet over to its blank back and drew a wedge. One clean wedge, pressed-in at the head, tailing off.

“Base sixty,” she said. “They counted in sixties. That’s why we have sixty seconds and sixty minutes and three hundred sixty degrees in a circle — that’s *them*, that’s still on your phone right now, four thousand years later. And in base sixty, you’ve got signs. A unit. A ten. And a big one.” She drew it — the *sar*, the great circle-sign, fat and certain. “Sixty sixties. Three thousand six hundred. It’s a *number*. It’s the numeral for three thousand six hundred, the way that —” she tapped the blank corner “— a comma and three zeros is *thousand*. It’s notation.”

She turned back to the file and pulled the King List sheet, the famous one, the one that always got quoted.

“And here’s where the alien case eats itself,” she said. “Because they *love* the King List. The huge reigns, the antediluvian kings ruling tens of thousands of years — proof, they say, that the early rulers weren’t human. And the reigns are written *in sars*. This king reigned ten sars. Eight sars. The numbers are colossal and that’s the whole thrill of it.” She put the pencil down. “So you can’t have it both ways. Either the *sar* is a number — three thousand six hundred — and the reigns are just very big numbers, big the way myth makes everything big, a kingship measured in cosmic units to say *the old world was vast and we are small*. Or the *sar* is a planet’s orbit. It can’t be a planet’s orbit in one sentence and a count of years in the next sentence on the *same tablet*.” She let it sit. “It’s a number. It was always a number. It’s the number the priests used for *king reigned a very long time* and the number a modern man pointed at and said *orbit*. He needed an orbit. The text was just doing arithmetic.”

“The *sar* is a number,” Frik said, and it came out of him almost gentle, almost like relief, the truth let off its leash with nowhere bad to run. “Not an orbit. It’s the number.”

“It’s the number,” Naila said. “You absolute disaster. Yeah.”

Mira’s face did the thing it did, the corner of it, and she signed *we know we love you* and Frik caught it this time and ducked his head and was, for one second, in a room that wasn’t a problem.

Yusuf had gone quiet in the deep way. He was looking at the King List sheet, at the impossible reigns, and Naila knew the look because she’d worn it herself, years back, in the bad small flat before this one, when the file was thin and the want was thick. He’d had the long orbit

on his wall once. The thirty-six-hundred-year clock. The countdown. It had been a door out of an ordinary life, and she'd just put a pencil through it, and she did the next part for him without saying it was for him.

"The want's still real," she said, to the table, to all of them, to him. "I want to be really clear. The man who built this — he wasn't a con man. I've read everything he wrote. He *loved* this stuff. He sat with the texts longer than almost anyone alive who wasn't paid to. He wanted us to be wanted. He wanted somebody to have crossed a vast dark for *us*. That's not stupid. That's the most human thing there is. The aliens are a way of not being alone." She tapped the file. "It's just not what the clay says. And what the clay says is *worse*, and that's the thing I can't get over, that's the thing I keep coming back to —"

"Show them VA 243," Bashir said softly. "Show them the man."

So she did the last one. The reach's crown jewel. The cylinder seal in Berlin, the little stone you rolled across wet clay to make your signature, four thousand years old, the one that's on the cover of the most famous book in the genre because it has, in its top corner, a star with dots around it — and somebody counted the dots and said: *the solar system. Carved before they could have known. Proof.*

"This is the one that does it for people," she said. "Every time. It's a *picture* of the solar system, they say, with the right number of planets, on a seal from four thousand years ago. And I get it. I do. It looks like a sun with planets. You want it to be that."

She laid the seal photograph down, and beside it, her own line, her own hand under the signs, slow and certain.

"It's a seal," she said. "A signature stone. And these things almost always say whose they are — they're *property*, they're *I am so-and-so, servant of such-and-such god*. That's most of what's written on the planet, by weight, in this entire civilisation. Not prophecy. Not star charts. *Receipts. Names. Whose this is.*" Her finger moved along the wedges. "And this one has an inscription, a little panel of cuneiform, and the inscription is a dedication, and it gives a name. *Dubsiga.*" She said it carefully. She always said it carefully, this name, because nobody else ever had, for four thousand years, until a few scholars and now this table. "It says, more or less — this belongs to Dubsiga, and below it the name of the man who *owned* the seal, who's presenting

himself before his god. A servant before his lord. That's the scene. That's what the picture is. Not a star map. A man kneeling. Bringing his offering. Saying *I am yours.*"

"And the dots," Frik said. "The sun and the dots."

"A star symbol," Naila said. "A standard one. Divine. You put a star to mark *this is a god, this is the holy thing*. The dots are dots. It's decoration around a god-sign on a man's signet. Somebody counted the dots and found his solar system in another man's name-stamp." She sat very still. "His name was Dubsiga. He had a god he answered to. He had a seal made, beautiful work, and he rolled it in the clay so people would know his word was good. And four thousand years later we took his stone and rubbed his name off it and wrote *solar system*, and put it on a book, and made him scenery. That's the part I can't — that's the —" The word didn't come. She let it not come. "We had a whole person in our hands and we turned him into a UFO."

The kebab shop below sent up a gust of frying onion through the floor. Somewhere out on Caledonian Road a bus knelt and hissed. Nobody said anything for a moment, and the not-saying was the right size, and Mira held it open with her hands in her lap, not signing, just letting the room be quiet on purpose, which was a thing only Mira could do at this table, make a silence that meant yes.

"That's the case," Naila said at last. "All of it. There's more — there's always more, there's the bit where someone reads a school exercise about beer rations as a cargo manifest — but that's the floor. The crossing-point is Jupiter. The princely offspring are gods whose name drifted for two thousand years. The orbit is a numeral. The solar system belongs to a man named Dubsiga. Every single 'decode' is a bad translation. Every one. You just have to read it in the language it was written in, because that's the only honest place there is. You can't catch the cheat in English. The cheat lives in the gap between the languages and it dies the second you close the gap."

She had said it. The whole tower, down, in order, with love. She felt the clean of it, the particular relief that was hers and not like anyone else's relief — the relief of a thing that *resolved*, a transliteration with no slack in it, every sign accounted for, the ledger balancing to the wedge. It was the best feeling she had. It was better than being right. It was being *exact*.

And then it turned over in her, the way it always did, into the thing she couldn't flatten.

"But," she said.

"But," said Bashir, who knew. He was smiling the loneliest happiest smile in the building.

"The real thing is more astonishing than the fake thing," Naila said. "That's what nobody warns you about when you go to debunk this. You go in thinking you'll find dust and you find — God. The real texts out-wonder the fiction so badly it's almost rude. We make people from clay and a god's blood. Not to be loved — to *work*. To bear the gods' toil so the gods could rest. There's a flood and a man told to build a boat and a bird sent out to find land — a thousand years before Noah, in the same shape, in the same part of the world." She heard the next thing come up and she said it the careful way, the way that was true and didn't take anyone's God off them. "Not copied. Not identical. Different boat, different mountain, different birds, different days. But the same *room*. The same conversation. People telling each other the world's oldest story across a thousand years and a couple of languages, handing it down, arguing with it, changing it." She spread her hand over the whole file, the fiction and the clay together. "The fiction flatters us. *You were designed. You were wanted. Somebody crossed the dark for you.* And the real one says, *you were made out of mud to do the work nobody else would do, and you die, and you knew that, and you made the most beautiful writing in the history of the world about it anyway.* That's braver. That's so much braver. The fake one's a hug. The real one's a *people*."

She stopped because her throat had got tight in the place it got tight, and she didn't perform the tight throat, she just waited it out, and the crew waited it out with her, which was the whole reason there was a crew.

Yusuf reached over and turned the King List sheet face-down, gently, the way you'd close someone's eyes. He didn't say it was for himself either. He said: "So why doesn't anyone *know* this. I had the long orbit on my wall for four years. Four years. And the man who could've told me in one sentence — *the sar's a number* — that man's got no audience and the orbit's got eleven million views."

“Because the fake one’s a better watch,” Edith said, from the windowsill, where she’d been sitting with the camera dark in her lap. She’d shot the file open on the table earlier, asked first, and then she’d stopped. “I framed alien tablets for a glossy outfit once, years back, before — I know exactly how you light a school-text about beer to make it look like it came off a saucer. It’s not even hard. You underexpose, you go low and raking so the wedges throw shadows, you never, ever show the line that says *this is Dubsiga’s*.” She turned the dead camera over in her hands. “The truth’s a wide shot in flat light with a footnote. Nobody buys the footnote.”

“There’s a thing, though,” Bashir said slowly, and they all looked at him, because Bashir went slow only when a thing had been bothering him sideways. He had his thumb on the photograph of the Flood Tablet — he’d carried the image out of Room 55 in his eye the way he carried words. “The doc crew today. They had a *list*. I saw the call-sheet on the producer’s clipboard when Yusuf was charming her. The tablets they’re shooting this whole series. And it’s all —” he searched for it “— it’s all the loud ones. VA 243’s on it. The ‘twelve planets’ one. Every object that *photographs* like a mystery.” He frowned. “And the Flood Tablet’s on it but only the part that says *the gods sent the flood*. Not the part Smith actually wept over. The story. Just the woo-shaped slice of the story.”

“That’s just what sells,” Yusuf said. “We just said that.”

“Maybe.” Bashir kept his thumb on the clay. “But I’ve watched three of these series get made now, doing the money for one of them. And it’s never the *same* tablets that go quiet. It’s always the boring true ones. The disproving ones. The school-text about beer rations — the actual evidence, the dull stuff that kills the case the second somebody reads it. Those don’t get lost loud. They just —” he opened his hand “— stop being available. Stop getting filmed. Slide off the list. Every time. Like somebody keeps choosing which ones the world gets to see, and the choosing all leans one way.”

The onion-gust came up again through the floor. Naila looked at the green folder, soft at its corners, the whole tower laid down in order, and felt the pattern try to assemble itself and refuse — too few data points, a shape with the start of a shape but no closure, the worst kind, the kind that itches.

"That's a coincidence," she said, because it was the honest thing to say. "Probably. Three series isn't a sample."

"Probably," Bashir agreed, and nobody at the table believed it all the way, and nobody could prove a single inch of it, which was exactly the trouble.

Yusuf's phone buzzed on the table, walked an inch, stopped. He read it and his whole face changed register. He looked up, and there was the grin from the museum steps, the talked-the-producer-down grin, but under it something straighter.

"Speaking of which," he said. "He's back tomorrow. Wants the file, Naila. The whole tower. Because we're not staying in London with it."

"Where," said Mira, reading it off his mouth before he aimed the word at her.

"Erbil," Yusuf said. "There's a woman there who can do to my pattern what Naila just did to the orbit. Reads the language. Reads the *meaning*. And she's already said no to us once."

Naila looked at the two exits, front and fire-escape, and then at the file, and then — past the kebab-shop window, out over the orange wash of the road — east, where Jupiter was up, crossing, doing what it had always done, while down here the question of *who keeps choosing what we get to see* sat on the table with no answer and the start of a shape.

"Then we'd better pack the clay," she said, "in the right order."

Chapter 3 — The Man Who Reads the Made Thing

The thing about Jakobus, Yusuf had decided, somewhere over the dark of eastern Turkey, was that you never caught him arriving. You caught him already there.

The flight into Erbil came down through a brown haze of late afternoon, and the airport was new and chilled and wrong, all marble and cologne and a duty-free wall of watches, the kind of place that has been built recently and at speed to tell the world a story about itself. They cleared the visa-on-arrival desk in a slow Kurdish queue, Bashir doing the talking, switching from his careful Sorani to the officer's Arabic to a soft word of Aramaic that made the man look up once, surprised, and stamp the passport a half-second kinder. Mira watched the officer's hands instead of his mouth and told Bashir afterward, *He liked you*, and Bashir said *He liked the Aramaic*, and Frik said *He liked the Aramaic*, a half-beat behind, and nobody minded because nobody ever minded the echo from Frik, it was just the room saying a thing twice.

And then they came out through the sliding doors into a wall of heat that smelled of diesel and dust and somebody's cardamom, and there, leaning on the bonnet of a dust-coloured Land Cruiser that had no business being in a Kurdish airport car park, was the Beast.

Yusuf stopped.

He'd known it was shipped. He'd signed two of the carnet forms himself, in a logistics English so dry it could start fires, and he still stopped, because there is knowing a thing is coming and there is the thing already arrived and weeping water from a canvas bag lashed to

its wing mirror, beading, dripping, the oldest trick in the desert — wet the canvas, let the heat steal the water, let the stealing cool what's left inside. The bag swung a little. Somebody walking past it would not have looked twice. Yusuf looked three times.

The man wasn't at the truck.

He was over by the taxi rank, crouched on his heels in the shade of a concrete pillar, and he was not doing anything, which was the part you couldn't film. He had a small tin in one hand, the lid off, and he was tipping a measure of something rust-red into a paper cup of tea a porter had given him — cayenne, Yusuf would have bet his fee on it, cayenne in the tea in this heat, a desert thing, sweat-to-cool-you-down, *makes-the-skin-do-its-job* — and he and the porter were not exactly talking. They were sitting in a quiet together. The porter said something and Jakobus answered with two words and a slow tip of the chin, and the porter laughed, and it was the laugh of a man who has just been seen by a stranger and not asked for anything.

"Spas," Jakobus said. *Thank you.* Kurdish. A courtesy handful, the right one, no more.

"He's already met the airport," Bashir said, beside Yusuf, dragging two cases. "Look. He's met it."

"He met it before we landed," Yusuf said.

—

They drove in toward the city with the light going long and amber and the Beast's air-con turned off, all the windows down, because the man wouldn't run it. *You don't learn a place from inside a fridge*, he'd said once, in the Namib, and it was the only time Yusuf had ever heard him explain anything, and even that wasn't really an explanation, it was a fact he'd put on the table for them to take or leave.

So they took the heat. Bashir up front, naming road signs out loud in three scripts. Mira behind him with her face to the window, reading the whole moving city — the men at the petrol queue, the woman arguing a price down at a fruit cart with her chin and her wrist and not one word Mira could hear, the boy who flagged them and got a flat palm, *no*, from Jakobus and grinned and flagged the next car. Frik with his hands flat on his thighs, pressing, the long-haul tic-load coming off him in the safe car the way it never came off in the airport

queue, a soft *hut, hut*, a roll of the shoulder, and Edith beside him with her camera in her lap, lens cap on, not shooting.

She'd asked. That was the new thing about Edith, the thing Yusuf had watched grow over three jobs like a callus over a burn. At the airport she'd lifted the camera at the weeping water bag and then she'd lowered it and looked at the back of Jakobus's neck, and he hadn't turned round, and she'd put the cap back on. Nobody had said anything. It was a conversation that had happened entirely without a sentence in it, and Mira had watched the whole thing and signed, badly, to Yusuf, *She asked. He didn't answer. So no.* And that was right. That was exactly the shape of it.

"He's not going to let you get him," Yusuf told her now, low, over the engine.

"I know," Edith said. She wasn't unhappy about it. "I've shot warlords who wanted it more than he doesn't." She turned the camera over in her lap. "There's no frame. I keep finding the frame and it's empty. Like he stepped out of it on the way in."

"That's the man," Yusuf said.

—

Naila had not spoken since the airport.

She sat in the very back, the file across her knees in its grey box, both hands flat on the lid, and she was doing the thing she did, the thing that wasn't magic, that Yusuf had learned the hard way not to call magic, because the one time he'd called it that she'd gone very flat and very polite and said, *It's arithmetic. Please don't make it a séance.* She was counting the city. Not consciously, maybe. Telephone poles. The repeat of a shopfront font. The interval of the streetlights coming on as the dusk dropped. When the intervals held she eased. When the city did something irregular — a roundabout, a wall of car horns, a knot of bodies at a junction with no clear way through — Yusuf watched her hand tighten on the box and her eyes go to the doors.

"Two minutes," he said to her, because that was the deal, you gave her the time and the exit and you did not narrate her nervous system at her. "We're nearly up the hill. It opens out."

It opened out.

The road climbed and the city fell away below them in a wash of low concrete and palm and minaret and the long industrial glow of the new malls, and then ahead, lifted up out of all of it on its own mound, lamp-lit, gold against the bruise-blue east, was the Citadel.

Bashir said the number before anyone asked. He couldn't help it; it was his version of Frik's echo.

"Six thousand years," he said. "Maybe more. People have lived up there for six thousand years without stopping. Not a ruin you visit. A roof somebody slept under last night." He turned in his seat. "Oldest continuously inhabited place on earth, they argue. Jericho fights them for it. Damascus fights them for it." He grinned. "They can fight. It's old."

And Naila looked up the hill at the lamplit wall of it, at the thing that had been a town when writing was young, and her hand came off the box.

"Okay," she said quietly. "Okay. That's — okay."

It was the most Yusuf had ever heard her say about beauty.

—

The uncle's place was below the Citadel, off the bazaar, a flat-fronted house with an awning of corrugated tin and grape vine, two plastic chairs, a low table, and a samovar already going. They were not staying there — that was a hotel near the souk, all arranged, Yusuf had arranged it — but Jakobus took them here first, to the awning and the tea, before the rooms, before the work, and that was not an accident either. The uncle was Narin's; Yusuf knew that much and not much more. An old Assyrian man with a white moustache and reading glasses pushed up into his hair, who came out and clasped Jakobus's hand in both of his like a man greeting weather he'd been told was coming, and said something in Syriac that Bashir caught and didn't translate, only went still, the way Bashir went still when a language did something to him in a place too tender to repeat.

"Tea," the uncle said, to all of them, in English. "Sit. You came on the road. Sit."

So they sat in the dark under the vine with the bazaar noise coming

up the lane, and the man poured tea into little waisted glasses, two-handed, the dark stewed çay over the sugar, and Jakobus sat among them and did the thing he did with his hands around a hot glass in the heat, which made no sense and which Yusuf had stopped trying to make sense of.

“He’s not here,” Edith said suddenly, very low, only to Yusuf, watching the table. “Narin. The uncle keeps glancing at the lane. He’s expecting her and she’s not coming tonight.”

“She already said no once,” Yusuf said.

“She’ll say no again,” Edith said. “You can see it in the way the old man’s bracing for us. He knows she’s going to be hard on you and he’s sorry about it in advance.” She turned the camera, still capped, in her hands. “Don’t film the uncle. Whatever happens. He poured us tea. You don’t pay a man back for tea by taking his picture.”

“No,” Yusuf agreed. And then, because it was the kind of thing he’d never have said three jobs ago: “Good catch.”

—

Here is the part Yusuf would tell people about, after, the part that he could never quite get to land because it had no event in it.

After the tea, Jakobus took the grey box from Naila’s knees — *asked* for it, palm up, and waited until she handed it, which she did, which surprised Yusuf because she handed almost nothing to anyone — and he set it on the low table and lifted the lid, and inside, on foam, in a sleeve, were the prints. Naila’s working prints. Big crisp photographs of the clay, of the tablets and the seals, of the rolled-out impression of the one everyone was here for in the end, the seal they call VA 243, the one that has launched a thousand websites, the one with the man and the star and the little circles that the whole alien story hangs on like a coat on a single nail.

The streaming-doc version of this object — Yusuf had watched it on the plane, he made himself watch the competition — the streaming-doc version put it on screen with a low synth drone and a slow push-in and a voice saying *some researchers believe* over a graphic of the solar system, the little circles lit up one by one like a planetarium, *and here, four thousand years before Copernicus, is a complete diagram of the planets — including a world modern astronomers have yet to*

find. And then the synth swelled and they cut to a man in a good shirt in front of a bookshelf saying you couldn't rule it out.

That was the easy version. The flattering version. The one that says: somebody knew. Somebody up there knew, and drew it for us, and we are the kind of creatures worth drawing for.

Jakobus looked at the print for a long time.

He did not say *solar system*. He did not say *aliens*, and he did not say *nonsense*, which was the other cheap thing, the sneer, the *what-idiots* that Yusuf had heard too many clever men reach for. He just looked, with his glasses on the table and his thumb not touching the surface of the photograph, and the bazaar went on past the awning, and the uncle watched him look.

"Who is he," Jakobus said.

Not *what is it*. Not *is it real*. *Who is he*. He'd found the man in it. Past the star, past the little circles, past the whole apparatus of wonder the West had bolted onto the thing — he'd gone straight to the small figure on the left, seated, one hand lifted.

"That's the part nobody films," Bashir said slowly, leaning in. "Look. He's not a chart. He's a man. He's *seated*. There's a figure standing, bringing him forward — that's the introduction posture, that's a worshipper being led in. And the seated one with the horned cap — that's the god. The little circles are around the god's shoulder, by his star, his emblem. It's not a diagram of where things are. It's a picture of a man being brought before his god." He sat back. "It's the most ordinary thing in the world. It's the single most ordinary scene in all of Mesopotamian art. A man, and his god, and the introduction. They made thousands of them."

"And the writing?" Jakobus said.

"There's writing," Bashir said. "Right there in the field. There's a name." He looked at Naila. "There's always a name. These were signatures. You rolled them in wet clay to say *this is mine*, *this is sealed*, *this is witnessed*. They're not theology. They're not astronomy. They're the Bronze Age equivalent of the franking on an envelope. And somewhere in the cuneiform on this one there is a man's name, and he is a real man, and he had a god he was being introduced to, and he sealed his letters with the two of them together

because it mattered to him, the way you'd put your father's photo on your desk."

Frik had been quiet under the vine, pressing his palms. Now the over-reach came at the table — not from Frik, from the doc still playing in Yusuf's head, the *world astronomers have yet to find*, the voice swelling — and Frik flinched as though it had been said aloud in the room, and his head jerked, and out it came, fast, involuntary, true:

"It's a *receipt*."

A beat.

"It's a receipt," he said again, quieter, his own echo, his shoulders coming down. "Sorry. It's. It's a receipt with a god on it."

And the uncle laughed. The first laugh of the night out of the old man, a short surprised bark, and he reached over and put his hand on Frik's forearm, light, and said, "Yes. A receipt. We had receipts before we had the wheel, habibi. We had receipts before we had *kings*."

"That's the joke," Naila said. She'd come on, the way she came on when the pattern closed, flat and certain and lit up. "That's the whole — the alien version says it's a star map four thousand years ahead of its time, and it's so much *better* than that, it's so much stranger, it's a man clocking in. People had been keeping accounts in this clay for a thousand years before this seal got cut. Tokens, tallies, who owes whom how much barley, how much beer. Writing didn't start with poetry or prayer. It started with *inventory*. They invented the first writing on earth to keep track of *stuff*." She put her finger an inch above the print, not touching. "This — this whole language, the one that the alien story says aliens had to come down and give us — we built it ourselves to count sheep and not get cheated."

She said it the way other people said *I love you*.

—

Jakobus put the print back in its sleeve. Settled it on the foam. Closed the box, and the bazaar noise came back up into the gap his attention had been holding shut, and Yusuf realised that for two full minutes nobody at the table had been thinking about anything but a man and his god in a piece of clay, and that this was the whole trick of him, the thing no camera got — he didn't tell you what to see.

He stood next to the thing and asked it the right question and then got out of the light so you could look.

“It does a job,” Jakobus said. To no one. To the box. “Everything that lasts does a job. You find the job, you find the man.” He pushed the box an inch back toward Naila. “This does a man’s job. Saying *I was here, this was mine, this was witnessed*. Four thousand years and we can still read the I-was-here.” He stood, knees creaking, and pressed the always-clean hanky once to his neck and folded it away, and looked down at the six of them under the vine. “You can read the made thing. You read it better than the people who made the show about it.”

“But not as well as her,” Bashir said.

It wasn’t a guess. It was Bashir naming the firewall before anyone could pretend it wasn’t there.

“Not as well as her,” Jakobus agreed, and there was no contest in it, no apology, just a fact set on the table like the man set every fact on the table — for you to take or leave. “I can tell you it does a man’s job. I can’t tell you the man’s *name*. I can’t read the franking. I can’t hear the joke.”

“The joke,” Edith said.

“Bashir says there’s always a joke,” Jakobus said, and the corner of his mouth moved, the closest he came. “In a language he can feel and I can’t. So.” He nodded down the dark lane, where the uncle had glanced all night. “We’re at the end of what we can do alone. The people who invented this clay — they’re not gone. They’re up the hill. They’re under this vine. They poured you the tea.” He looked at the old man, who looked back, steady. “And one of them reads this better than anyone alive, and she’s already told you no.”

—

He didn’t stay for that. He never stayed for the part that wasn’t his.

He took the empty glass to the samovar himself, and rinsed it, and set it upside down to drain, and clasped the uncle’s hand again in both of his and said the Syriac word back to him that Bashir wouldn’t translate, badly, but said, and the old man’s eyes went bright and he held the hand a moment longer than the handshake needed. Then

Jakobus went out under the awning to where the Beast sat ticking and cooling with its water bag weeping into the warm night, and he checked the bag with the back of two fingers the way you'd check a child's forehead, and he was, for a moment, lit orange under the bazaar lamp — and Edith had the camera up.

She'd uncapped it without anyone seeing. Old reflex. The frame was perfect: the man, the truck, the citadel gold above, the whole story of the desert man arrived in the cradle of writing, the shot that runs the credits, the shot that makes a career.

She held it.

He didn't turn around. He never turned around. But something in the set of his shoulders changed, an awareness with no face on it, and Yusuf watched Edith's finger lie on the shutter and not press it.

She lowered the camera.

"Empty again?" Yusuf said.

"No," Edith said. "Full. It's a beautiful frame." She put the cap back on. "It's just not mine to take." She looked at the uncle's lit doorway, the tea glasses draining, the lane where the woman hadn't come. "I shot this place once before. In oh-three. I shot the sacks coming out of the museum in Baghdad while the whole — while it burned. I've got a Pulitzer-shortlist of somebody else's heritage in a hard drive in London." She said it flat, the way you say the thing you've decided to stop carrying as a secret. "Some shots you take. Some shots you've already taken enough of." She nodded at Jakobus folding himself into the Beast. "He poured the old man's glass out himself. You don't take the picture of the man who washes up after himself."

—

In the Land Cruiser, down the hill, windows down, the city coming up around them again all horn and neon and the smell of grilled fat, Naila held the grey box on her knees and was quiet, and then she said, to the box, the way she said her best things to objects:

"She's going to be right about something we're wrong about. Tomorrow. She'll out-read us. I can feel the shape of it. I don't even mind." A pause. "I usually mind."

"Why don't you mind?" Bashir asked.

“Because the texts are better than the lie.” Naila turned her face to the window, to the old town going up behind them into the dark, lamp by lamp. “Every single time we open them up they’re better than the lie. The lie says somebody came down and gave it to us. The clay says we made it ourselves, in the mud, to count sheep, and then we used it to write the oldest poem on earth about a man who couldn’t beat death and made peace with it.” She breathed out. “I don’t want the version where it was a gift. I want the version where it was ours. And she’s the one who can give us that. So.” Her hand was steady on the box now. “She can be right at me all day.”

Up front, Jakobus said nothing, which was his way of agreeing.

Yusuf watched the uncle’s lane shrink in the wing mirror, the awning light, the vine, the place where a woman who reads cuneiform and speaks the dying language of the men who cut it had not come tonight and would, the uncle’s whole braced body had promised it, come tomorrow — to tell these foreigners no, and then, maybe, if they were lucky, and quiet, and didn’t film her uncle, to tell them the name of the man kneeling in the clay.

And under everything, under the tea and the heat and the beautiful frame Edith had refused, the other thing sat in Yusuf with no answer and the start of a shape: that somebody had paid good money to put a synth drone behind a Bronze Age receipt and call it a star map, and that the loud lie travelled the world on a streaming service while the quiet truth waited under a grape vine for permission. *Who keeps choosing what we get to see.* He didn’t say it out loud. There was nobody to say it to who could fix it.

The Beast went down into the new city, weeping water into the warm dark, and behind them the oldest roof on earth held its six thousand years of lamplight, and somewhere up there, or down here in the diaspora flat she worked from, a woman was deciding exactly how hard to say no.

Chapter 4 — The One Who Owns the Clay

She came up the lane on foot, and Edith heard her before she saw her — the wrong shoes for the gravel, hard heels, a city sound the lane wasn't built for, and under it the uncle's voice dropping from his after-prayer murmur into something fast and low and Aramaic, a warning maybe, or just *they're here, they're already here, behave*.

Edith had her camera on the strap and her hands nowhere near it. She'd promised herself that. The light at this hour was obscene — the citadel above them going from honey to bronze, the vine throwing its lace across the whitewash — and she kept her hands away from the camera the way an addict keeps her hands off a glass, knowing the want and naming it and sitting on it.

Then the woman came round the corner of the wall and Edith forgot the light entirely.

Dr. Narin Youkhanna was not tall. That was the first wrong thing about the photograph Edith had already half-built in her head — the scholar against the tablets, lit from the side, gravely beautiful, a National Geographic spread. The real woman was small and quick and dressed for a meeting she did not want to have, a grey jacket, a phone in her hand she did not put away, and her eyes went round the courtyard in one pass and counted them. Edith watched her do it. One, the loud one with the notebook clutched to her chest like a hot-water bottle — Naila, who had not slept. Two, Frik, who was already doing the small economy of motions that meant he was working hard at stillness. Three, four, five. Bashir near the wall, very deliberately not at the centre. Yusuf with his hands open and visible, the posture of

a man who knew how to walk into rooms that didn't want him. Mira at the edge, watching faces, always watching faces.

And then Narin's gaze found Edith. Found the camera on the strap. Stopped.

Held.

Edith felt it land on her like weather.

"Pala," the uncle said, gentle, a hand half-raised, and there was a current of family in it, *be welcome, sit, these are guests* — and Narin answered him without looking away from Edith, two words, and the uncle subsided.

"You'll forgive my uncle," Narin said, to the courtyard, in English clean as a knife. "He has the hospitality of a saint and the security instinct of a man who thinks the worst people in the world wear bad shoes." A small, controlled smile that did not reach her eyes. "I do not share it. I think the worst people in the world wear very good shoes and carry very good cameras."

Nobody breathed for a second.

"Tea," said the uncle, and fled toward the brazier, and the spell broke into ordinary motion, and the crew did the thing Edith had watched them do at three airports and one museum basement now — they made room. Not a word about it. Naila to the inner corner with her back to the wall and an exit in her sightline, because someone she didn't have to manage had taken that decision for her years ago and it was simply how the furniture got arranged now. Frik between the wall and Yusuf, where his hands had something to face. Mira angled so the light fell on every mouth. The geometry of a found family is a thing you can see if you know to look, and Edith photographed it only with the part of her that could not be confiscated.

Narin sat. She put the phone face-down on the low table, which Edith understood was a concession the size of a country.

"So," she said. "You're the ones who want to film my ancestors as space monkeys."

"No," said Naila.

It came out flat and immediate and a little too loud, and Naila's hand

tightened on the notebook, and Edith saw Yusuf shift his weight to be ready and then not need to be, because Narin had turned the full beam of her attention on Naila and Naila, for once, did not flinch from it. They looked at each other, the woman who read the system and the woman who owned the clay, and something passed between them that Edith had no name for and did not try to caption.

“No?” said Narin.

“The opposite.” Naila opened the notebook. Her fingers found a page she had clearly found a hundred times. “VA 243. The Berlin tablet. The one they put behind a synth drone and called the solar system carved before telescopes.” She turned the book round and pushed it across the table, and on the page in her cramped careful hand was a drawing of the seal, and around it her own arithmetic in three colours. “There are eleven dots. If it’s the planets you have to invent a moon and ignore the fact that the sizes are wrong and pretend a Mesopotamian engraver who couldn’t see Neptune drew Neptune. And then.” Her finger stopped on the cuneiform at the top of the seal, a little box of wedges. “And then there’s this. The writing. Which the documentary cropped out. Which I can’t read.”

Silence.

“I can read the pattern,” Naila said, and her voice did something Edith hadn’t heard from her — it dropped, it asked. “I can count dots. I can do the base-sixty and prove the three-thousand-six-hundred is a number and not an orbit. I brought all of it.” She tapped the notebook. “But I can’t read what the man who made the thing wrote on the thing. So I came to the person who can.”

For a long moment Narin did not touch the notebook. She looked at it the way you look at a photograph someone has taken of your house without asking.

Then she picked it up.

Edith watched her face and so did Mira — Edith clocked Mira clocking it, the two readers of the unspoken triangulating the same closed mouth from two angles. Narin read down the page. Her thumb moved over Naila’s arithmetic, the base-sixty conversion, the place where Naila had written $3600 = a \text{ numeral, a BIG one, NOT a planet's year}$ and underlined it twice and then, smaller, (*unless?*) and crossed

the unless out.

“You crossed out the *unless*,” Narin said.

“Because there isn’t one,” Naila said. “I checked it forty times. Sixty squared. It’s how they wrote big. It’s beautiful. It’s *base sixty*, it’s why we have sixty minutes in an hour, it’s the oldest piece of arithmetic still alive in your kitchen, and they took that — they took the most elegant counting system on earth — and they sold it as a docking schedule for a planet that doesn’t exist.” She had run out of breath. She got more. “It made me so angry I couldn’t read for a week.”

Narin set the notebook down.

When she spoke again the knife had gone out of her voice and left something more tired and much older behind it.

“VA 243,” she said, “is a dedication seal. A man owned it. He pressed it into the clay to say *this is mine, this contract is mine, I stand behind these words*.” She turned the notebook back to face Naila and put one fingernail, lacquered, very precise, on the box of wedges at the top. “The line your documentary cut off says he was a scribe. And under it is a name. The name of his god, or his lord, the one he served — the dub-sar, the keeper of the tablet. A man called *Dubsiga*.”

The name dropped into the courtyard like a stone into a well.

“It isn’t a star map,” Narin said. “It’s a business card.” A flicker, almost a real smile this time. “A four-thousand-year-old man wanting you to know whose servant he was. And the West looked at a dead man saying *remember me, remember who I served*, and decided he was drawing them a route to Mars.”

“I knew it wasn’t planets,” Naila said, half to herself, fierce and quiet. “But I didn’t have the *man*.”

“No,” said Narin. “You didn’t have the man. That’s the whole disease.” And she looked round the courtyard again, slower this time, and Edith saw the assessment shift by some increment too small to name. “You came a long way to be told you were right about the arithmetic and wrong about everything that matters.”

“That,” said Yusuf, very gently, from the wall, “is the most encouraging thing anyone’s said to us in two thousand miles.”

The tea came. The uncle did it himself, would not let anyone help, and Edith watched Jakobus over by the Beast do the thing he did, which was to be exactly the right amount of nowhere — far enough to not be in the family's space, near enough that the uncle, carrying the tray, caught his eye and got a nod, and the nod said *your house, your kin, your call*, and the uncle's shoulders came down half an inch. Narin's eyes went to him once, the tall foreigner by the vehicle who hadn't tried to be in the photograph of this at all, and then came back, and she filed him somewhere Edith couldn't see.

It was Frik who broke first. It always was, and it was never his fault, and the crew had long ago stopped pretending the small explosions were anything but weather.

"The sar is the orbit," Frik said.

It came out of him whole and bright and wrong, in a voice that wasn't quite his, a documentary-narrator cadence, the thing he'd absorbed off some screen and that surfaced now under the pressure of a room with rules in it. His face did the thing afterward, the small collapse of *that wasn't me, that was the tic*, and his hand came up.

And Narin — Edith was watching, Edith would always be glad she was watching — Narin did not do any of the things people did. She didn't startle or smile-too-kindly or look away to spare him. She turned to Frik like he'd asked an honest question.

"No," she said. "And you know it's no, or it wouldn't have made you angry to say it."

Frik went very still. "Three thousand six hundred years," he said, in his own voice now, low. "The orbit of Nibiru. That's the line. That's the famous line."

"It's a number that means thirty-six hundred," Narin said. "It means it on a receipt for barley. It means it on a list of how many soldiers a king lied about having. It means it the way *a thousand* means a thousand to you — sometimes a count, sometimes just *a lot*. It was never a year of anything. To make it an orbit you have to take a word out of every mouth that ever used it for two thousand years and put it in the mouth of one planet that has to be invisible to work." She lifted her tea. "The tic told the truth. That *is* the famous line. The famous line is a mistranslation with a soundtrack."

Frik laughed — a real one, surprised out of him — and the laugh was permission, and the courtyard breathed.

“That’s his job,” Bashir said.

He’d been quiet so long Edith had half-forgotten the shape of his voice. He said it from the wall, mild, not pushing in.

“Telling the truth at the wrong moment?” Narin said.

“Telling it before anyone’s decided to,” Bashir said. “He says the thing the room is being careful around. We’ve learned to listen for it.”

Narin considered him. “And you,” she said. “What’s yours? You’ve been arranging your face for ten minutes.”

Edith almost flinched for him. But Bashir only inclined his head, and then he did the thing — the thing Edith had seen him do at the airport with the visa officer and once with a furious taxi driver in Erbil traffic, the small surgical kindness of meeting a person inside their own language — and he said it in Aramaic.

Edith didn’t have the words. She had the music of it, and she had Narin’s face, and Mira’s face watching Narin’s face, and that was the whole text. Whatever Bashir said was short. It was not fluent — Edith could hear even across the gap that he was reaching, that this was a borrowed tongue worn over the bones of forty others, that he was a man who belonged to no language by blood and had simply gone and *learned* the one this woman bled. He said it gently and a little wrong and entirely on purpose.

And the door that had been a finger’s width open came open another inch.

Narin’s whole body changed. Not dramatically. The jacket-armour stayed on. But her chin came up and her eyes brightened with what Edith, watching, identified after a second as *grief* — the specific bright grief of hearing your dying mother tongue come out of a stranger’s mouth in a courtyard under a foreign occupation’s ruins, badly, with love.

She answered him. Longer. Edith caught one word twice — it sounded like *lišana*, and she’d find out later it meant *tongue*, it meant *language*, it was the word at the bottom of everything they were here to do.

Then Narin turned back to the English and the room, and her voice had gone rough at one edge.

"He greets me in the language of the people who wrote the thing your documentary turned into a cartoon," she said. "It's the oldest continuously spoken language in this country. There are villages on the plain north of Mosul where they still say their prayers in it. Were. Were villages." The roughness held. "ISIS came through them in 2014. The ones who didn't die left. The language goes where the people go, and the people are in Sydney now, and Chicago, and a flat in west London where I do most of my work because it isn't safe to do it here. So." She looked at Bashir. "Thank you. For knowing it was worth learning. Most people who come for the tablets never once think the tongue is still warm."

"I think the tongue is the whole thing," Bashir said.

"It is," Narin said. "It's the only thing. Every lie you came here chasing is a translation lie. *Anunnaki* — do you know what it means? Properly?"

Naila opened her notebook. Narin held up a hand, not unkindly, *let me*, and Naila closed it.

"*Anunna*," Narin said. "The princely ones. The princely offspring. The children of the great god, the high gods, the council of heaven. It's a *title*. It's *Your Royal Highnesses*." She let it sit. "Over two thousand years — longer than English has existed, twice over — it drifts. By the late period it's come to mean the gods of the underworld, the judges of the dead. A word can travel that far inside one civilisation. And a man in the twentieth century picks it up at the far end of all that travel, after it's already crossed two thousand years and three meanings, and he says: *ah. Astronauts*." Her mouth twisted. "He didn't even read it. He read *about* it, in translation, in a footnote, and built a solar system."

"Zecharia Sitchin," Yusuf said.

The name came out of him oddly. Edith looked over. Yusuf had been the easy one, the open-handed one, the one who unblocked rooms — and just now there was a thing in his face she hadn't seen, a kind of carefulness, like a man saying a name he'd once said in love.

"You've read him," Narin said. It wasn't a question. She'd heard it

too.

“All of it,” Yusuf said. “Years ago. The twelfth planet. The whole —” He stopped. “It got me through a bad stretch. I’m not going to pretend it didn’t. The idea that there was a *reason*. That somebody made us on purpose and we mattered enough to be made.” He turned his tea glass a quarter-turn on the table. “It’s a kinder story than the real one. I’ll defend that to anybody. It’s just not true.”

Narin looked at him for a long moment, and the armour came down a notch further, because she was, Edith understood, a person who had built a fortress against exactly this conversation and Yusuf had walked through the wall by being soft.

“The real one is better,” Narin said quietly. “When you can bear it. But I grant you it isn’t kinder. Not at the start.”

“What’s the real one,” Naila said. Not greedy. Hungry the way Yusuf was hungry, the way they were all a little hungry, the way you get when you’ve come a long way for something true.

Narin shook her head once. “No,” she said. “Not tonight. Not for free. You don’t get the clay because you flew here and said please.”

And then she turned, finally, fully, deliberately, to Edith.

Edith had known it was coming. She’d watched it not happen for forty minutes, the way you watch a wave hang.

“The camera,” Narin said.

“It’s off,” Edith said.

“I know it’s off. I can see the light isn’t on. I’m not an idiot.” A beat. “Do you know what’s in my museum?”

“Which one,” Edith said, and regretted it, and meant it.

“Good answer.” Narin’s voice had gone very flat and very level, the dangerous register. “Baghdad. The National Museum. April 2003. You’d have been — what. Doing your job?”

The courtyard had gone quiet in a different way now. The crew had stopped being a found family arranging furniture and become an audience for something between two women.

“I was there,” Edith said.

She heard Mira go still beside her. She felt the crew not look at her, which was its own kind of looking.

"I know," Narin said. "I looked you up. The shoes thing was a joke. The cameras thing wasn't. I know exactly who you are, Edith Vos. I've seen your war." She didn't raise her voice. "There's a photograph of yours. The boy on the museum steps, the empty cases behind him through the doors, the dust. It won things. It's beautiful. It's on a wall in a building in New York where people drink wine and feel something for ninety seconds about the cradle of civilisation."

Edith said nothing. There was nothing. The photograph was real. The wine was real. The award was on a shelf she didn't dust.

"While you were making that beautiful thing," Narin said, "they were carrying the actual cradle out the back in sacks. Cylinder seals by the thousand. Tablets. The Warka Vase — they got the Warka Vase, do you understand, five thousand years old, the first picture humans ever made of a procession, of *society*, and it went out in a sack while a lens made art of the door it went out of. And the thing about your beautiful photograph," and here her voice finally cracked, just once, and re-set, "is that it taught the whole world to grieve the building and never once ask where the things *went*. It made a tragedy you could feel without doing anything. It made the looting *photogenic*. It made it a mood."

Edith found she had no hands. She had hands. They were empty and very far away.

"That's a fair charge," she said, when she could.

"I don't care if it's fair," Narin said. "I care that you're standing in my uncle's courtyard with a camera and my ancestors on the table, and I have to decide whether the next beautiful thing you make is a document or a sale."

"Then let me ask you something," Edith said, and her own voice came out steadier than she'd earned. "What's the difference. For you. What's the difference between the frame that documents and the frame that sells. Because I'll take the rule. I'd rather have your rule than my taste." She made herself say the next part. "My taste is the thing that took the museum picture. I know what my taste does. I'd like to put it down for a while and use yours."

It was the most honest thing she'd said in years and it cost her like surgery.

Narin studied her. The phone stayed face-down on the table. Up the lane a generator coughed and caught somewhere in the new city, and the citadel above them held its bronze a minute longer than seemed possible.

"The difference," Narin said slowly, "is the caption."

She picked up Naila's notebook again, the drawing of VA 243, and turned it so the seal faced Edith.

"You photograph this," she said, "and put under it *cylinder seal, Old Babylonian, dedication of a scribe, name of his lord, see catalogue, here is the museum's free page, go and read it* — that's a document. That serves the dead man. He wanted to be remembered. You remembered him correctly." Her thumb moved to the edge of the page. "You photograph the exact same object and put under it *Was This Carved by Aliens?* — and now you haven't photographed a seal, you've photographed a *price*. Because a tablet that proves spacemen is worth a fortune on the grey market and a tablet that says *Dubsiga's barley account* is worth a coffee. The lie is the markup. The lie is *why the sack is full*. You think the woo and the looting are two stories. They're the same business."

Across the courtyard, Edith heard Yusuf exhale like he'd been hit.

"Say that again," Yusuf said.

Narin looked at him.

"The lie is why the sack is full," Yusuf said. "The mystery isn't decoration. It's the *invoice*."

"It always was," Narin said. "Make a thing too boring to steal and nobody steals it. Make it scream *secret of the gods* and it walks out the back at midnight and somebody films the door for an award." She set the notebook down a final time and looked, for the first time, weary rather than armed. "That's why I gate it. Not because you're bad people. Because the loud version of my ancestors is worth money to people I will never meet, and the quiet true version — the man saying *remember whose servant I was* — is worth nothing to them, which is exactly why it's the only version worth protecting."

Nobody said anything for a while. The brazier ticked. Mira, who had read the whole of it off mouths and shoulders, signed something small and lopsided toward Edith, and Edith caught half of it and held it, and let it land where it was meant to.

Then Narin stood, and gathered her phone, and looked round the courtyard one more time — the loud one who'd flown across the world to be told she was right and wrong; the truth-teller; the polyglot who'd learned her dying language well enough to greet her badly in it; the watcher of faces; the money man who'd needed the aliens and was letting go in real time at her uncle's table; the photographer who'd offered to put her own eye down. And the tall one by the Beast, who had gathered all of them somehow and then stood out of the picture on purpose.

"Tomorrow," Narin said. "My uncle's roof. Early, before the heat. I'll bring photographs of the real tablets — the British Museum lets you, they put it all online for free, which is the most subversive thing that institution has ever done. And I'll start at the beginning. Not the aliens. The clay. What we were actually made of, in the story they actually told." A pause. "It's worse than spacemen. It's so much braver. You won't sleep after."

"What do we have to do," Naila said.

"Be quiet," Narin said. "Don't film my uncle. And when I tell you the men I'm worried about wear very good shoes — believe me. Because someone made the loud version of my country, and someone keeps it loud, and someone makes very sure the quiet true version never trends." She was at the corner of the wall now, the city sound of her heels ready to take her back down. "I've spent twenty years watching which stories get a soundtrack and which ones disappear from the catalogue between one visit and the next. I have stopped believing it's an accident."

She let that hang in the bronze air, and did not explain it, and Edith felt the back of her neck go cold for reasons that had nothing to do with the dark coming up the lane.

"Who's keeping it loud," Yusuf said, and Edith heard the money in his voice now, the old instinct waking up, the man who could follow a sack.

Narin paused at the wall's edge, half in lamplight, half gone.

"That," she said, "is the better question than aliens. That's the one I'd film." And she went down the lane into the new city, hard heels on the wrong gravel, leaving the oldest roof on earth behind her and a courtyard full of people who had finally, all of them, started looking the right way.

Edith did not lift the camera.

It was the best shot she'd never take, and she let it go, and it felt like the first clean thing she'd done in a long time.

Chapter 5 — Conveniently Loud

Yusuf knew the room before he knew the city.

He'd never been to Erbil and the city wasn't the room. The room was on his phone, behind a glass face smeared with the courtyard's lamp-oil and the grease of three days of bad falafel, and it was the room he'd worked out of for two years of his life he didn't talk about. Same furniture, even. There was always a long table you could project onto, a coffee machine that cost more than a forklift driver's month, and a slide deck with the word *narrative* in it.

He'd waited until the others were asleep. He sat on the low wall at the edge of the uncle's roof with a glass of tea going cold against his knee, the new-city lights laid out below like a circuit board someone had soldered over the old ground, and he typed the name of Narin's streaming-doc company into a search bar with two thumbs that had stopped being steady about an hour ago.

Apsû Media.

Of course. Apsû. The freshwater deep under the world in the old stories, the abyss the gods came out of. Some MBA had paid a consultant for that. They always named themselves after the thing they were strip-mining. He'd worked for a logistics firm once called *Restitution*.

He pulled the corporate site. Slick. Of course it was slick — that was the whole engine. A landing video that opened on a slow drone shot over a desert at dawn, a voice with the gravel sanded off it, *some questions are older than history*, and a montage: a cuneiform tablet

rotating in a black void, lit like a watch in a watch advert, the wedges catching highlight as it turned. A man's hands — gloved, white cotton — laying it on velvet. A title card. *THE FIRST CONTACT — coming this autumn.*

Then the part that made the old part of him go very quiet and very awake at the same time.

A press page. A grants page. A *partnerships* page with logos. And buried in the footer, in the legal grey that nobody reads because nobody is supposed to, a line about *cultural-asset facilitation services* and a sister entity registered three jurisdictions away.

He knew that line. He had *written* lines like that line.

He sat back. Below him a generator coughed somewhere and steadied. The cold tea had a skin on it. He didn't drink it.

It was Naila who found him, which surprised him, because Naila didn't generally come looking. She came up the roof stair without announcing herself and stood at the lip of the light with her notebook held against her sternum the way she held it when she'd been thinking too hard to sleep.

"You're doing money," she said. Not a question. She'd clocked his posture from across a courtyard once and named the precise figure he was anxious about within fifty pounds; she read him the way she read a ledger that had been balanced too neatly.

"I'm doing money," Yusuf said.

She came and sat, not close, an arm's length down the wall, which from Naila was an embrace. She set the notebook on her knees. On the open page she'd drawn the VA 243 seal from memory, the figures, the eleven dots, and beside it a column of base-sixty arithmetic, and beside *that*, underlined twice, she'd written *NOT AN ORBIT* in block capitals with the satisfaction of a woman who had personally executed a lie.

"Narin said the men wear good shoes," she said. "I keep trying to fit it to the tablet. It doesn't fit the tablet. The tablet's solved. Dubsiga's the owner, the dots are stars but the arrangement is decorative, the whole thing's a dedication. There's no mystery in the object. So the worry can't be the object." She turned her face to him, that level grey

look. "So what's the worry."

"The worry's not what it says," Yusuf said. "The worry's where it goes."

She waited. She was very good at waiting; it was one of the few social moves she trusted, and on him, tonight, it worked like a key.

"Okay." He set the phone down between them, screen up, the rotating tablet still turning in its expensive void. "I'm going to tell you how a thing like this actually runs, because I was inside one. Not this one. One like it. You ready?"

"I prefer the real one to the polite one," she said.

"Right. Cradle of writing, yeah? Best clay in the world's been coming out of this ground for four thousand years. Most of it boring. *Gloriously* boring. Three sheep delivered to the temple of Inanna, receipt acknowledged, sealed by Lu-Ningirsu. A school exercise where some kid copied out a proverb forty times and got the third line wrong. Beer rations. So much beer." He could hear something coming alive in his own voice, the part of him that had loved this before he'd learned what he was loving it *for*. "A tablet like that — a real one, properly out of the ground — on the legal market it's worth, what. A few hundred quid? If it's clean. Most aren't clean. Most can't *be* clean, because the only way they get here from there is a chain of hands that all need deniability, and deniability has a price, and the price eats the few hundred quid."

"So a boring true tablet isn't worth moving," Naila said slowly. He watched her start to assemble it.

"A boring true tablet is a *liability*," Yusuf said. "It's heavy, it's traceable, it's illegal, and it's worth less than the bribe you paid the man at the second border. The math is terrible. I sat in rooms and watched men look at genuine cradle-of-civilisation school texts and go *ugh, paperwork*, like it was a parking ticket." He picked the phone back up, turned it so the tablet caught the light again. "Now. Same tablet. Same beer receipt. Except this time, the man with the good shoes says — out loud, on a podcast, in a doc with a drone shot — *this object may rewrite human history*. This object has *symbols modern science can't explain*. This object proves we were *visited*."

"It doesn't," Naila said. "It says Lu-Ningirsu got his sheep."

“It says Lu-Ningirsu got his sheep,” Yusuf agreed. “But nobody who’ll pay for it can read it. And here’s the thing you have to actually sit in, because it’s ugly: *nobody who could read it will ever be in the room*. You’ve made the object worth a hundred times more, and you’ve made it a hundred times *safer* to move, with the exact same sentence. Because now it’s not a smuggled artefact. Now it’s *evidence*. Now it’s a *relic*. Now a rich man in a city I won’t name buys it for a number that makes the border bribes look like the tea money, and he buys it *because* of the story, and the story is the thing that means he will never, ever hand it to a woman like Narin who’d take one look and say *Dubsiga, your servant*, and price-crash his miracle back down to beer.”

Naila had gone very still in the way she went still when a pattern locked. She picked up her pen. She didn’t write anything. She just held it over the page like she needed something in her hand to think with.

“The story is the markup,” she said.

“The story is the markup.” He’d never heard it put that clean. “You said it better than the slide deck did.”

“And the truth—” She stopped. He could see her run it both directions, the way she ran everything both directions before she’d let herself trust it. “The truth is what makes it *cheap* again. The truth is the thing that empties the value out of the crate.”

“The truth,” Yusuf said, “is what turns the relic back into a parking ticket. So the truth is the enemy. Not because they want the aliens to be real—” and this was the part he’d been turning over on the wall for an hour, the part that had made his hands stop being steady, “—they don’t care if the aliens are real. I never met a single one who *believed* it. That’s the part nobody gets. They’re not cranks. They’re not even liars, technically; they never *say* it’s true, they *say could it be?* *Some experts believe*, they keep it a *question*. They need the question loud. A loud question is a market. A loud question keeps the catalogue full of mysteries and empty of beer receipts. And a loud question keeps people like us—” he tipped his head down the roof toward the dark rooms where the others slept “—looking at the wrong tablet.”

The generator below them cut out. For a second there was only the

new city's hum and, further off and lower, the older sound, the one Yusuf had been half-hearing all night without naming it — water somewhere, a drip, the Beast's canvas bag weeping against the truck's flank in the lane, Jakobus's desert habit of keeping water cool by letting it cry through the cloth. A sound that belonged two thousand miles south and had come up the road anyway, the way the man had, the way the whole crew had.

"There's a worse part," Yusuf said. "You want the worse part?"

"Always," Naila said.

"The loud version's only half the cover." He swiped the doc page closed and the rotating tablet died. The roof got darker. "The other half is *you*. Or — people like you and me before we got here. The skeptic. The smart one in the comments who watches the drone shot and goes, *oh come on, it's all just myth, it's a fairy tale, who cares*. You know what that man is, to a trafficker? He's the *best customer in the world*. Because he's just told everyone it doesn't matter. He's just announced to the room that the clay is worthless mumbo-jumbo not worth protecting. The believer makes the price go up and the skeptic makes the *guarding* go down, and between the two of them they walk a four-thousand-year-old object out the back of a country that's already been bled white, and the only person in the entire transaction who actually *loses* — who loses her ancestors, her language, her dead — is the woman who can read it. Who isn't invited. Who they keep *very* sure isn't invited."

He hadn't meant to say it with that much in it. His voice had thickened on the last of it and he heard the thickening and didn't like it, because the thickening was the part that was about him, and this wasn't supposed to be about him.

Naila was looking at the dark where the city was.

"You sound like you miss it," she said. Flat. Not cruel. Just true, the way she was true, with no padding around it.

He breathed out. The tea was undrinkable. He drank it anyway, cold and skinned and bitter.

"I miss who I got to be when I believed the cover," he said. "Not the second one. The first one. The believer." He turned the empty

glass in his hands. “You want to know why I came on this trip? Everyone thinks it’s because I read the manifests, I follow the money, I’m useful. And I am. But I came because some part of me still — God, this is embarrassing. Some part of me still *wanted it to be true*. The big version. The visitors. The twelfth planet. I read Sitchin at nineteen on a night shift in a warehouse outside Mosul, moving boxes I wasn’t supposed to ask about, and that book — it was a *door*, Naila. It was a door out of the warehouse. It said: you, specifically you, are not an accident of mud and bad luck and a war you didn’t start. You were *made*. On purpose. *Wanted*. By something out among the stars that bent down and chose. That’s — that’s not nothing. To a kid in a warehouse, that’s not nothing at all.”

Naila wrote something now. One line. He didn’t look.

“And then I got good at moving the boxes,” he said, “and one day I understood that the men paying me to move them needed me to believe the door so I wouldn’t ask what was actually in the crate. And the door I needed to walk through and the lie they needed me asleep behind were the *same door*. That’s the part I can’t—” He stopped. “They built my way out of the warehouse out of the same lumber they used to rob the warehouse. And I helped.”

The water wept against the canvas in the lane. Somewhere a dog. Somewhere, faint, music — Jakobus, awake, almost certainly, the radio in the Beast turned low to something with a steady spine to it, the metronome he kept the dark off with.

“Narin’s going to think we’re them,” Naila said.

“Narin already thinks we’re them,” Yusuf said. “She’d be an idiot not to, and she’s not an idiot, she’s the smartest person I’ve met since I stopped being one of them. She’s seen this exact crew before. Western strangers, a camera, a notebook, a fixer who knows too much about logistics—” he laughed, no humour in it “—a *man no one can photograph* — and a beautiful theory about her ancestors. She’s been here. The version of us she’s met before walked off with the contents of her museum in 2003. In sacks. While the building burned. Edith’s got pictures of it. *Edith was there*. You think Narin doesn’t know that? You think she didn’t clock the camera the first second?”

“Edith didn’t take the museum’s pictures,” Naila said. “Edith took pictures *of* the museum being taken.”

"Same lens, far as Narin's concerned, until proven otherwise. The witness and the thief use the same machine. That's Edith's whole problem. That's why she didn't lift the camera tonight." He set the glass down on the wall. "And it's why she was right not to."

Naila was quiet. He could feel her doing the thing, fitting it against the others, the great clicking ledger behind her eyes balancing the trip the way she'd balanced his anxiety to fifty quid. When she spoke again it was slower, and there was an edge in it he didn't expect.

"Apsû Media has a partnerships page," she said.

"You saw that."

"I saw it over your shoulder ten minutes ago." Of course she had. "Logos. One of them I know. A foundation that funds digitisation projects. *Open access. Heritage for everyone.* They put museum collections online. Tablets. Photographs. Catalogue numbers." She turned the notebook toward him in the dark, though he couldn't read it. "I use their database. Everyone does. It's how I checked Dubsiga while Narin was still on the wall — I pulled the seal's record, the publication history, the line that says it's a personal dedication. It's a good database. It's *free*."

"So?"

"So Narin said something." Naila's voice had gone careful, the way it went when she was holding a pattern she didn't want to be true. "On the wall. She said she's watched stories disappear *from the catalogue between one visit and the next*. The quiet true ones. The ones that say *beer rations*. She said she's stopped believing it's an accident."

The roof was very dark now. Below them the new city pulsed its circuit-board pulse, and under it the old ground held its four thousand years of receipts and proverbs and the names of men who'd wanted to be remembered enough to press them into wet clay before they died, and Yusuf felt the floor of the thing he'd thought he understood tilt very slightly, just enough.

"You're saying," he said slowly, "it's not just that they make the loud ones loud."

"I'm saying I can't prove that anyone makes the quiet ones quiet."

Naila said it fast, the disclaimer of a woman who had been burned for pattern-matching past the evidence and would not do it again. “I’m an arithmetic person. I count what’s there. I don’t count what’s missing, because *missing* isn’t a number, missing is a story, and stories are where the lying lives.” She held the notebook tighter. “But Narin counts it. Narin’s spent twenty years watching the catalogue. She says the entries thin out. She says the disproving ones, the ones that price-crash a miracle, those are the ones that go *under review* and don’t come back. And she’s not an arithmetic person either. She’s a *language* person. She reads what got written *and* she reads what got—”

She stopped.

“What got un-written,” Yusuf said.

“I don’t have a word for it,” Naila admitted, and from her that was nearly a confession of helplessness, this woman who had a base-sixty column for everything. “There isn’t a number for a tablet that used to be in the catalogue and isn’t. There’s just a gap. And a gap could be a clerk. A gap could be a server migration. A gap could be nothing.” She breathed. “Or a gap could be a person with very good shoes who understands that you don’t have to *burn* the truth anymore. You don’t need sacks and a fire. You just need to make sure the truth is never the version with the soundtrack, and you need to be patient, and you need to control which door the world walks through.”

Yusuf looked at the dead black phone screen with its smear of lamp-oil and his own face faintly ghosted in it.

He thought about the rooms he’d worked in. He thought about how nobody in them had ever once said anything you could put in a court. How they’d never needed to. How the whole genius of it was that no single hand ever did a single thing you could point at — the believer believed for free, the skeptic shrugged for free, the database had a clerk who was probably just overworked, the doc company kept everything a *question*, and somewhere a long way back from all of it, where there were no fingerprints because there were no fingers, the value moved and the clay moved and the only loud thing in the whole arrangement was the one thing that wasn’t true.

“I want it to be a clerk,” he said.

"I know," Naila said.

"I want it to be a server migration and an overworked clerk and Narin being twenty years tired and seeing a shape in noise, because the other thing is too big and too quiet and I've watched what too-quiet looks like up close, and I would rather it be a clerk."

"I know," Naila said again. And then, after a moment, because she was Naila and she would give him the true thing over the kind thing every time and that was the kindest thing about her: "But you don't think it's a clerk."

Below, in the lane, the canvas water bag wept its slow tears against the Beast's flank, and the low radio kept its steady spine, and out past the parapet the new city's lights ran their bright loud current over the dark of the old, where the receipts slept.

"No," Yusuf said. "I think someone made the loud version of her country. And I think someone keeps it loud. And I think the thing they're keeping loud—" he heard the shape of it as he said it, the awful economy of it, the markup and the cover folded into one perfect sentence "—is a question they don't even *want* answered, because the question's the asset. The answer crashes the price. The answer's a parking ticket. The answer's *Dubsiga, your servant*."

He thought about the boy on the night shift outside Mosul who'd needed the door so badly. He thought about how the people who'd robbed him had needed the same boy to keep loving the door. And he thought, with a kind of vertigo, that the door had never once been locked from the inside — that it had been held open *for* him, all those years, by men in good shoes who wanted exactly one thing from a kid who needed the stars to have made him on purpose, which was for him to keep his eyes up so they could empty the room.

Naila closed her notebook. She stood. She didn't put a hand on his shoulder, because she didn't do that, but she stood near him a moment longer than her arithmetic required, which was its own grammar.

"Tomorrow," she said, "Narin reads us the real one. The clay version. The one that out-wonders the fiction." She looked down at the lane, at the truck, at the slow-weeping water and the man no light ever quite held. "We should hear it before anyone makes it quiet."

“Yeah,” Yusuf said.

She went down the stair. Yusuf stayed on the wall a while longer with the cold dregs and the dead phone and the city laid out below him like a board someone else had wired, and he thought: *if it wasn't aliens, then who, and why did a boy in a warehouse need it so badly that the men robbing him could build his only exit out of it.*

He didn't have the answer. That wasn't his to give. The language wasn't his and the meaning wasn't his and the grief, God knew, was not his — it belonged to the woman who'd gone down the lane in the wrong heels on the wrong gravel, who'd left the oldest roof on earth behind her and told them all, finally, to look the right way.

But the money was his. The grift was his. He'd lived in its rooms and he knew its furniture and he knew, now, sitting on a roof over a city he'd never see again, exactly what shape the hand had to be that could turn a beer receipt into a relic and a relic into a parking ticket with the same loud, patient, fingerprintless sentence.

He just didn't know whose hand it was.

He poured the cold tea over the parapet, into the dark, where it fell without a sound he could hear over the city, and went down to sleep among the others, badly, the way he slept now that he'd stopped believing the door.

Chapter 6 — What the Word Doesn't Mean

Frik woke before the muezzin, which in Erbil meant before everything. He lay on the thin guest-room mattress and let the call come up out of the city the way it had come up every dawn since they'd landed — first one minaret, then a second leaning on it half a beat late, then the whole bowl of the old town singing slightly out of tune with itself, and he didn't have the words for any of it, but he had the shape, and the shape held him still. That was the gift nobody believed about him. The tics ran on noise and clenched on silence and went quiet, sometimes, inside a rhythm large enough to forgive a man for being one more arrhythmia in it.

Then his right shoulder snapped up to his ear, twice, hard, and the spell broke, and he was just a man on a floor in a country that hadn't asked for him.

He got up. He drank the water from the clay jug Narin's uncle kept on the sill, which tasted of the jug, and he went out into the courtyard where the light was the colour of weak tea and Jakobus was already crouched by the front wheel of the Beast with the canvas water bag weeping its slow dark stain into the dust beneath it, doing whatever he did to a vehicle that was older than most of them and ran better. The man didn't look up. He lifted two fingers off the wheel rim, which was hello, and went back to it. Somewhere in the truck a cassette was playing something with a marimba in it, very low, keeping time with nothing.

"Morning," Frik said, and then, because the morning quiet was too clean and his throat needed the load off, "*morning, morning,*" twice

more, lighter, getting it out.

Jakobus tipped his head. The cayenne tin came out of his shirt pocket, was offered, was waved off, went back. None of it remarked on. That was the thing about the truck and the man at it: nothing Frik did out here was a problem to be solved. It was just weather. The crew was the first room he'd ever been in where his body wasn't the most interesting thing about him, and he'd have crawled across the bazaar on the broken glass of his own teeth before he'd say that out loud.

They worked in the long room off the courtyard, the one Narin's uncle used for storing the good rugs and the dates and a forty-year-run of agricultural-ministry calendars he would not throw away. Narin had cleared the long table. On it she'd laid, side by side, three things: a printout of VA 243, big, the famous one, the seal with the little gods and the little circle of dots that a man in New York had once called the solar system; a fat reference grammar with a cracked spine; and her own laptop, open to a photograph of an actual tablet, dun-coloured, fingernail-marked, with the cuneiform standing up off it in the slant light like a field of struck matches.

Naila stood at the head of the table with her arms folded close, not because she was cold but because the room had six people in it and the door was at her back and that arithmetic was always running. Yusuf had put himself by the door without being asked. He did that now. He'd done it since the roof.

"Show me the orbit," Narin said.

She said it without heat. She said it the way a teacher says a thing she has said before and will say again and would, if she were honest, like to stop having to say.

"The sar." She tapped the printout, the little dots. "This is the place people start. Three thousand six hundred. The orbit of the planet that comes back every three thousand six hundred years. So." She slid the grammar across to Bashir, who caught it without looking, the way he caught everything, and then she pulled the laptop toward Naila instead. "You read numbers. Read me that one."

Naila came off the wall. The table was a thing to do with her hands

and her eyes and it pulled her in past the count of the doors. She bent over the screen.

“Sexagesimal,” she said. “Base sixty.” Her finger hovered, not touching. “It’s not a quantity that means *years*. It’s a digit in a place-value system.” She looked up. “Sixty squared. Thirty-six hundred is just — it’s *the round number*. It’s how a kid in a scribal school writes a big tidy figure, the way we’d write a thousand or a million. It turns up everywhere. Loan periods. Grain. Gods reigning before the Flood — this king ruled a *sar*, this one ten *sars*, and they didn’t mean he was on the throne for thirty-six thousand years, they meant a *very long time, a clean impressive number*.” She straightened. “You can’t take a digit and bolt a telescope to it. It’s a *ten*. It’s a *ten* with a hat on.”

Edith had her camera up — quiet, low, the lens an extension of her cheekbone, the way she held it when she’d already asked. She’d asked Narin yesterday, formally, in the courtyard, *may I photograph the work and not the room*, and Narin had looked at her for a long time and said *the work, yes. Not my uncle. Not the calendars*, and something had been agreed there that the rest of them only half saw. So now Edith framed the table and the tablet and Naila’s clean unjewelled hands and she did not frame Narin’s face, and the not-framing was its own kind of statement, made over and over, a hundred small refusals an hour.

“Now,” Narin said. “Nibiru.”

She let the word sit. It was a word the whole world thought it owned now — doom-planet, hidden planet, the planet the network’s other channel ran a special on every eighteen months, *Nibiru: Is It Coming?*, with a render of a brown gas giant looming over a screaming coastline.

“It’s a real word,” Narin said. “That’s the part people don’t expect. It is *in the texts*. Right here.” She pulled up a column of glyphs. “*Né-bé-ru*. From the verb *to cross*. It’s the crossing-place. The ford. Where you ford a river, where the ferry runs — that’s a *nibiru*.” She looked round at them. “And in the astronomical texts, when a planet reaches the point in the sky where it *crosses* — its station, the place it turns — they call that the *nibiru* of that planet. It’s a *position*. Anything can have one.” A small, dry pause. “The one they wrote about most, the *nibiru* that became a proper name almost, the king of the crossing-

places —”

“Jupiter,” Bashir said. He’d looked up from the grammar. There was a particular pleasure on his face that Frik had learned to watch for, the pleasure of a man who’d just felt a word click home in a slot it had been cut for three thousand years ago. “It’s Jupiter.”

“It’s Jupiter.” Narin almost smiled. “Marduk’s planet. The biggest light that isn’t the moon or the morning star. They watched it cross every year. *Every year*. You can watch it tonight, off the citadel wall, if the haze lifts. It is the least hidden object in that sky.” She spread her hand flat on the table. “It was never a twelfth planet. It was never coming for us. And it was *never*—” and here she touched the printout of VA 243, the little gods, the little dots — “*never once, in any text, in any list, attached to these.*”

“The Anunnaki,” Naila said.

“The Anunnaki.” Narin took her hand back off the seal. “Different word. Different file. Different shelf. The man who made all this famous put the planet and the gods in the same sentence and the sentence has been travelling under its own power for fifty years. But the *clay* never put them together. He did.”

It went very quiet in the long room. Frik felt the quiet land on him the way it always did, a pressure, a thing his nervous system would have to pay for, and he held still and breathed through it and watched the dust turn in the slant of light over the table.

Because here was the floor tilting. He could feel it tilt. He’d come in through the front door like everybody did — he’d watched the network’s stuff, the gold-mining gods, the bred-from-apes, the whole gorgeous machine of it — and now a woman in a rug-room in northern Iraq had taken a screwdriver to it in its own language, gently, professionally, the way you take apart a thing you respect even when it’s wrong, and the planet was just Jupiter and the orbit was just a *ten with a hat on*, and the question that came up through the hole where the aliens used to be wasn’t *were they real* anymore.

It was: *then who, and why did we want it so badly.*

“VA 243,” Yusuf said, from the door. His voice was careful. “The solar

system seal. The dots. If it's not — what is it."

Narin pulled the printout to the centre. "It's a dedication."

She said it so plainly that Frik watched it not land, watched the whole alien architecture of the thing fail to fall just because a fact had been spoken, because facts didn't work like that, never had.

"There's an inscription on it," Narin said. "Two lines of cuneiform. People who talk about the solar system never read the two lines, because the two lines are the boring part, and the boring part is the whole point." Her finger moved along it. "*Dub-si-ga*. A name. A man's name, or a title — a high official, a scribe-prince. And then: *your servant*. Somebody had this seal cut and dedicated to a person named Dubsiga. *To Dubsiga, from your servant*. That's it. That's what it says. It's a business card. It's a man telling another man, *I'm yours, here's my mark*." She looked up and her face had gone, for a moment, entirely undefended. "And the little dots aren't planets to scale. There's no astronomy in the proportions, there's no orbit, the spacing is wrong for the solar system and right for *decoration*. It's a star and the moon and stars, the way you and I would draw a sky. The kind of sky a child draws. The kind a god stands under." She sat back. "It's a man, kneeling, with his mark, in front of a god, under stars. It's the most ordinary devout thing in the entire collection. That's why nobody photographs the inscription."

And it was at that moment — Frik would think about this for a long time, about the timing of it, the way his body knew before he did — that the man on the floor near the door said it.

There was a person in the room nobody had named yet. Apsû had sent a producer-fixer with them, a young man called Deniz, fluent and bright and embedded, who'd been quiet and useful all morning and who was, Frik understood now, *of the network*, in the soft way the network was of everything, a clean-handed cheerful young man who believed, who actually believed, who'd grown up on the channel and the renders and the looming brown planet. And Deniz had been getting more and more wound through Narin's whole patient demolition, leaning forward, and now he couldn't hold it.

"Okay but," Deniz said, "but the sar — the thirty-six hundred — that is the orbit, though, right, because the King List, the reigns, they match the —"

"The sar is the *orbit*—" Frik said.

It came out of him entire and finished, in Deniz's own cadence, in Deniz's own rising hopeful pitch, the echo arriving a quarter-second behind the original and landing dead on top of it like a second foot in the same footprint — *the sar is the ORBIT* — and the whole room heard it for what it was, which was the sentence held up to the light, the sentence detached from the man and rotated once in the air so everyone could see clean through it.

The echolalia. It took whatever was loudest and gave it back. And what had been loudest, just then, was an honest man reaching for the thing he needed to be true, and Frik's nervous system had photographed the reach and printed it large.

Nobody laughed. That was the mercy of this crew, the thing Frik had crossed a continent to find — nobody laughed, and nobody hushed, and nobody looked at *him*. They looked at the sentence, hanging there, *the sar is the orbit*, with the question mark filed off it by the flatness of the repetition, so that it stopped being a hope and became an X-ray of a hope, and you could see in it exactly where the bone was broken.

Deniz heard it. You could see him hear it. His mouth was still half-open on his own version of it and there was his own want, played back to him in another man's broken voice, with all the *but* and the *though* and the *right?* burned off, just the naked claim, *the sar is the orbit*, and it sounded — out there in the air, separated from him — like exactly what it was. Like a thing somebody needed. Not a thing that was so.

"Sorry," Frik said. His shoulder jerked. "Sorry. It does that. It grabs—" his head ducked, twice — "grabs the loud one."

"No," Yusuf said quietly, from the door. "Don't be sorry."

Because Yusuf had gone very still. Frik watched him, because Frik watched the men by doors. And what was on Yusuf's face wasn't triumph and wasn't the cheap-scorn-on-the-believer thing the network would have shot in close-up — it was *recognition*, the bad soft kind, the kind a man wears when he sees his own old face on a stranger.

"It's a good thing to want," Yusuf said. He was talking to Deniz now, but he wasn't, really; the room understood that he wasn't, re-

ally. “That’s the part nobody says. It’s a *good* thing to want. You want it to be bigger than rations and tax-lists and a man named Dubsiga leaving his card. You want somebody to have come down. You want it to mean we were *chosen* — designed, planted, watched. You want the dust to not be the whole story.” He turned the dead phone over in his hand, a habit now, a worry-stone. “I wanted it too. I wanted it like a door. You’re in some warehouse job or some — some ordinary nothing life, and the alien story’s the one door in the wall, and you’d be a fool not to want the door.” His jaw worked. “I’m not laughing at you. I spent ten years walking through that door. It costs more than you think and it doesn’t go anywhere, but God, it’s the prettiest door in the building.”

Deniz didn’t say anything. He looked at the printout, at the little kneeling man and his little card and his little homemade sky, and something went out of his shoulders that wasn’t faith exactly — Frik wouldn’t have called it faith, faith wasn’t being touched here, that wasn’t what this room was for — but was the *flattery* going out of it. The thing Yusuf had named. The story had told Deniz he was chosen and the clay was telling him he was a man, made of clay, like the man on the seal, kneeling under a sky he’d drawn himself.

Mira had been at the far end of the table the whole time, where she could see every mouth, her chin tipped, reading. She’d missed none of it — Frik knew she’d missed none of it, she got more of a room than any of them, she got the part under the words. Now she lifted her hands and signed something to Bashir, who’d been learning, badly, eagerly. He frowned, parsing, then said it for her, low, to the table:

“She says — the want is the real subject.” He watched her hands again. “She says nobody’s wrong here. She says—” his eyes flicked, careful, getting it right — “the only liar in the room is the one who *sells* the want.”

And that landed in Frik’s chest harder than the orbit had. Because the want wasn’t the lie. The want was the most human thing on the table. The lie was somebody monetising it.

They broke after that. Narin’s uncle came through with the tea on a dented tray, the glasses too hot to hold, and outside in the courtyard Jakobus had got the second water bag rigged over the awning and

the shade under it was ten degrees cooler than the lane and they drifted to it the way the crew always drifted to whatever shade the man had built without being asked. He poured nobody's tea. He'd taught them, somewhere back along the road none of them had been on with him, that you let a man pour his own. He'd taken his shades off in the shade. He said, to Narin's uncle, two careful words in Kurdish, badly pitched, and the old man laughed and corrected him and Jakobus said them again, worse, and the old man laughed harder and it was, Frik understood, a thing the man did on purpose — got the word wrong so the local could own being right. *Sawubona with the mouth*, Bashir had called it once. *He greets you by handing you the win.*

Naila stood at the edge of the awning's shade with her tea, near the open arch of the courtyard, where the doors were the whole world and not just a wall at her back, and Frik went and stood near her, not too near, and said nothing, which was the company she could take.

"It's cleaner than the lie," she said, after a while, not to him exactly. "The real one. The clay one." She was looking at nothing, at the angle of the citadel up the hill. "The lie says we're special. The clay says we're tired. Made to be tired. Made out of mud and a dead god's blood to do the gods' work so the gods could rest." She turned her glass. "That's a worse story and a better one. I keep doing the arithmetic on it and it keeps coming out *braver*." She glanced at him, fast, sideways, the way warmth came off her, never head-on. "You did a good thing in there."

"Doesn't feel like a thing I *do*," Frik said. "Feels like a thing that does me."

"Same," Naila said, which from her was practically an embrace, and they stood in the shade and didn't look at each other and were, both of them, fine.

It was Yusuf, in the end, who asked the question.

He'd helped Narin's uncle carry the empty tray back and he came out into the white lane light wiping his hands and he stopped in front of Narin where she stood under the awning with her own tea cooling, and he asked it the way you ask a thing you've earned the right to

ask, which is humbly.

“So what were they,” he said. “If they weren’t planets and they weren’t astronauts and the orbit’s a ten with a hat on. The Anunnaki. What were they. What were they *for*.”

It was Jakobus’s question, really. *What is it for*. It had been hanging over the whole table since London. But it wasn’t Jakobus’s to answer and the man knew it; he didn’t even look up from the strap he was checking. The question went to the woman it belonged to, the way everything in this country was supposed to and so rarely did, and Frik watched the network’s whole machine — the renders, the looming planet, the gold-mining gods, the fifty years of a sentence travelling under its own power — wait, in that hot lane, on what an Iraqi Assyriologist would do with her own ancestors’ word.

Narin didn’t answer.

She set her tea down on the low wall. She went back into the long room, and they heard her moving among her uncle’s shelves, and she came back out with a different printout — not VA 243, not the famous one, nothing the network had ever sold. A column of dun clay, struck-match glyphs, older-looking, harder.

“Anunnaki,” she said, “is not a *what*. It’s a *who*, and the *who moves*. Over two thousand years the word slides under your feet like wet shale, and where it ends up is nothing like where it starts, and the slide is the whole story, and *nobody* who’s selling you a planet has ever once watched it slide.” She held the new sheet against her chest, not yet handing it over. “You want to know what they were for. You’re asking the wrong tense. Ask me what the word *did*. Ask me what it *became*.”

She turned the sheet around.

The light came across it and the glyphs stood up off the clay, and at the top of the column, set apart, a single word waited to be read — older than the King List, older than the seal, older than the man named Dubsiga and his little homemade sky.

“Start here,” Narin said. “*The princely offspring*. That’s where it begins.”

She held the page out flat, into the white lane light, and waited for

them to come and read it with her.

Chapter 7 — The Princely Offspring

Bashir watched her hands.

Not the page — the page he could read for himself, or read enough of, the dun column with its struck-match wedges, the single word set apart at the top like a name on a door. He watched Narin's hands hold it, because hands told him things before mouths did, and her hands were doing the thing he did at borders: holding still on purpose, the stillness costing something.

The lane behind her uncle's house ran narrow and white between two walls, and the awning over the low bench cut the heat into shade and not-shade in a hard line, and the not-shade landed on the printout and made the glyphs lift. Yusuf had pulled a plastic stool from somewhere. Naila stood where she could see the whole lane and both ends of it, which Bashir had learned not to mention. Mira had her back to the wall and her eyes on Narin's mouth. Edith's camera sat on the bench beside her with the lens cap on, which was its own kind of sentence. Frik bounced once on his heels and went still.

"The princely offspring," Narin said again. "Say it the Sumerian way and you'll forget the planet exists. *A-nun-na*. The seed of An. An is the sky — the sky-as-a-person, the oldest of the old — and the *nun* is the prince, the noble, the high-born. So: the high-born seed of the sky. The aristocracy of the gods." She tipped the page so the light ran down it. "Their children. Their grandchildren. The ones who got the good seats."

"Not a crew," Naila said. It wasn't a question. She'd been turning something over since the tea. "*A family*."

“A dynasty.” Narin let that sit. “And here’s the part nobody selling you a spaceship has ever once stayed in the library long enough to find. The word doesn’t *hold still*.”

Bashir felt it land in his chest before his head caught up — the small electric thing that happened when someone was about to do the only trick he truly loved, which was to take a word and walk it through time and show you it had legs.

“Go on,” he said. Quietly. Just enough to half-open the door.

She glanced at him. Something in her shoulders gave a quarter-inch.

“In the oldest texts,” she said, “third millennium, the Anunnaki are *everything*. They are the great gods, the deciders. There’s a phrase — they fix the *me*, the destinies, the divine order of things. The flood is coming or it isn’t because the Anunnaki sit in council and decide. They are the supreme court of the cosmos. The board.” She turned the sheet a few degrees. “You want a word for power, that’s the word. They don’t dig gold. They sit. They rule. People down here in the mud are terrified of them in the good way — the way you’re terrified of weather and harvest and the river.”

“And later?” Yusuf had leaned forward on the stool. Bashir clocked it — Yusuf always leaned in at exactly the moment a story started doing something he hadn’t paid for.

“Later.” Narin’s mouth did something complicated. “Centuries pass. Empires fall and other empires write over them. Akkadian comes up under Sumerian like a second language stitched into the first. And there’s another bunch of gods running around the texts by now — the *Igigi*.”

“The *Igigi*,” Bashir repeated. The word had a gear in it. *Igigu*. The plural sat in his mouth like something tired.

“The junior gods. The working gods. And in some of the texts the line between Anunnaki and *Igigi* gets drawn one way, and in others the other way, because — and write this down, Edith, because this is the thing —” she didn’t look up to check whether Edith was writing; she just trusted it the way you trust a wall is behind you — “because it was *never one fixed system*. It was a theology. A living one. Two thousand years of priests in twenty cities arguing about who outranked whom. The names migrate. The jobs migrate. In the late texts — first

millennium, the period when half the famous tablets in the British Museum were actually copied — the Anunnaki have *slid all the way down*. They're not the high court of heaven anymore."

She stopped.

Bashir watched her decide whether to give it to them. The gating again — the firewall she ran on access, on her own ancestors' word, the one Yusuf had bumped into twice and learned to wait out.

"Where do they end up?" Mira signed it and said it, voice flat and careful the way she shaped the words she couldn't hear, and the question had no patience in it, only weight.

Narin answered her face-on, which Bashir noticed, because almost nobody did.

"They become," Narin said, "the *judges of the dead*. The Anunnaki of the underworld. The grey ones who sit in the dark and weigh you when you go down. By the late period that's mostly what the word means. Not the lords of destiny up in the bright. The bailiffs of the pit." She let the page drop a little. "Two thousand years. From the board of directors of the universe to the parole panel in hell. The same word. The whole way down."

Nobody said anything for a second.

Then Naila said, "That's a *drift*." And there was hunger in it, and Bashir knew that hunger — it was the same one he got, only she got it in shapes and he got it in sounds. "That's a — the word's not a thing, it's a *trajectory*. You'd plot it. Early, middle, late, and the meaning's a curve, it's *sliding*, and if you—" she stopped herself, the way she did, the brakes coming on visibly, and Bashir watched her choose to finish anyway, smaller — "if you only had one point on the curve you could call it anything you wanted."

"Yes," Narin said. Just that. And she looked at Naila for a beat longer than the room expected, the look of one specialist recognising another's instrument.

Frik, who'd been holding it, said it.

"One point — *one point on the curve*—" the echo running first, the way it always did, and then the blurt arriving under its own power, fast and clean and not askable-back: "*they froze it*."

The lane went quiet around the words.

“They froze it,” Frik said again, quieter, his hand opening and closing. “Whole — the whole word *moving*, two thousand years of it moving, and they just — *click*. Snapshot. Crew of twelve, gold mine, planet. Done.” He blinked. “That’s the cheat. That’s the whole—”

“That’s the whole cheat,” Narin agreed, and she said it to Frik directly, no flinch, no wince, no managing him, just answering the truest thing in the lane like it was the truest thing in the lane. “You take a word that drifts through twenty centuries and you nail one frame of it to a corkboard and you sell tickets. You take a theology — a *changing*, arguing, living theology — and you call it a roster. A roster doesn’t change. That’s the appeal. People don’t want a god whose meaning is wet shale under your feet. They want a name tag.”

Bashir felt the seam open. Not loudly. Just the first half-inch.

Because this was the move, this was the actual move the book they didn’t know they were in kept making: the alien version was the easy version, and the easy version fell apart the second you read the clay, and it fell apart not because someone shouted *fake* at it but because the real thing was *more*. The real word had been alive. The fringe had embalmed it.

“Show me how the planet dies in *this* one,” Yusuf said. “VA 243 we did. The number, the Nibiru thing, fine. But this—” he gestured at the dun column — “if I’m the network, I’m telling a guy in a hangar this says *the Anunnaki came from the sky to mine gold*. What does it actually say? Make it die in the words. That’s the only place I believe it.”

Narin almost smiled. Bashir saw it cross and go.

“You learn fast for an honest man,” she said.

“I’m not honest. I’m reformed. There’s a discount.”

She did smile then, briefly, and turned the page so the top word stood clear, and put one fingertip — not touching, hovering — over the wedges of *nun*.

“Here’s the planet dying,” she said. “*Nun* is the prince. You can *read* it. It’s a sign for nobility, for the high-born, and it’s all over the language — it’s in titles, it’s in the names of cities, *Eridu* has it, the temple of

Enki at Eridu is the *E-abzu*, the house of the deep, and the deep, the *abzu*, the sweet water under the earth — that's where the wisdom lives, down, not up. The high-born gods of the *sky-and-earth* couple. An above, Ki below. Their children straddle both. They are not from *somewhere else*. They are from *here* and *up there* at once, because the whole cosmos is family, and family is how a Sumerian explained the weather."

"So when Sitchin reads *they came down*," Bashir said, feeling the translation crack along its real fault line, "the *down*—"

"The *down* is theology, not a landing." Narin's eyes were bright now, the gating relaxed a notch further, the scholar coming up through the gatekeeper. "Gods come down to their temples. They *inhabit* the statue, the house, the city. The divine descends into the made thing — the cult image, the ziggurat that's literally built as a stairway so the god has somewhere to put his foot. *Come down* is the most ordinary verb in the religion. It's what the god does on a feast day. You translate it as a spaceship and you've — you've heard a man say *grace* and reported that he summoned food from orbit."

Naila made a sound — not a laugh, a kind of exhale through the nose, the closest she came in a crowd. "That's good," she said. "That's a clean — that's *clean*."

"It's clean because it's *true*," Narin said, and for the first time there was an edge under it, the old wound flexing, "and the true reading is *better*, and that's the part that makes me—" she stopped. Re-calibrated. Bashir watched her put the heat down somewhere safe and pick the words up cooler. "These were my ancestors. Not in a poster way. The Nineveh plain is forty kilometres from where you're sitting. My family is from villages where they were still naming kids out of these names a hundred years ago. And a Russian-American businessman who couldn't read a line of Sumerian decided my great-great-grandparents' great-great-grandparents were too stupid to invent the wheel, the city, the *first writing on earth*, and that sky-people must have done it for them. And then a streaming company made it look beautiful." She breathed out. "So when you ask me what they were *for*. That's the tense I keep wanting to break."

The lane held it. Even Frik held it.

It was Mira who moved into the quiet — Mira, who read the thing

the mouth wouldn't say, and who had been watching Narin's face the whole time and not the page at all.

She signed something small and only half for the room — to herself, working it out — and then she said it aloud, slow: "You're not angry that they got it wrong."

Narin looked at her.

"You're angry," Mira said, "that they got it wrong in a way that made your people *furniture*. In their own story."

Bashir watched Narin not answer for a second, which was its own answer, and watched her decide Mira had earned the truth and hand it over with a single nod, no words wasted, the way you pass something heavy to the one person who reached for the right handle.

"Yes," Narin said.

And that — Bashir thought, and didn't say — that was the whole inversion. Not *clever foreigners crack Sumer*. The cracking had been done by foreigners once already and they'd cracked it open and poured aliens in. The repair was hers. They were here to watch her do it, and hold the light, and write it down, and the win was not theirs to take.

Edith had not picked up the camera.

He noticed because he was watching for it now. She'd had three moments any photographer would kill for — Narin's hand over the wedge, Naila's exhale, the nod to Mira — and she'd sat there with the cap on and her hands in her lap, watching like she'd taught her hands to wait. At the nod to Mira her fingers had twitched toward the strap and stopped.

"You can shoot the page," Narin said, without turning, like she'd felt it. "Not us. The page."

"I wasn't going to shoot you," Edith said.

"I know." A beat. "That's new. Shoot the page."

Edith lifted the camera, took the cap off, and framed the dun column flat and square in the lane light — the document, not the woo, the clay and not the headline — and the shutter went once, soft. She put it down again.

Yusuf was still on the planet. Bashir recognised that too: the man circling back to the thing he most wanted to be true, picking at it, not ready to let it go clean.

"But the *Igigi*," Yusuf said. "You said it like it mattered. Junior gods. Working gods. That's the part — if I'm selling, that's where I plant the gold mine, isn't it? *Working* gods. Labour. There's labour in it somewhere, that's real, that's actually in the clay, that's why it *grabs*."

"There's labour in it," Narin said carefully. "That part's not invented. That's the thing I want you to understand about the good lies — they're not made of nothing. They're made of something *true* with the lights changed." She set the dun page down on the bench, flat, and put her two hands on her knees. "The *Igigi*. The junior gods. And in one of the oldest stories we have — older than Genesis by a long way, older than most of the Bible by a thousand years and more—"

She stopped, and Bashir saw her clock the word *Bible* land in the lane, saw her register that it had changed the air, and saw her not flinch from it and not lunge at it either. Just set it down on the bench beside the page, gently, like a thing she'd handle properly later.

"—in one of the oldest stories, the junior gods are made to *dig*."

"There it is," Yusuf breathed.

"Not for gold." Narin's voice came down like a level. "For the *rivers*. For irrigation. The *Igigi* are made to dig the Tigris and the Euphrates, to haul the basket of earth, to break their backs on the canals — which is the most Mesopotamian image in the world, by the way, because that's what *living here was*. You dig the canal or you die. You haul the basket or there's no barley. The whole civilisation is a fight with two rivers and a desert. So when they imagined the gods working, they imagined them doing *the work everyone in the room had blisters from*. Digging mud. Carrying mud. Year on year on year."

"For how long?" Naila asked. Of course she did.

"Forty years, in one version. The text says it like a complaint. *They have borne the toil night and day*. Forty years of carrying the basket." Narin's hands turned over. "And then—"

She let it hang.

"And then they put down the basket," she said. "The *Igigi*. The junior

gods. They set fire to their tools in the night and they march on the house of the chief god and they surround it and they refuse to dig one more cubit of canal. A *strike*. Four thousand years ago. The oldest labour action in literature is a *god* throwing his shovel in the fire.”

Frik laughed — a sharp bark, half tic, half genuine, his hand going to his mouth and not making it. “*Sorry* — sorry, that’s — the gods *unionised*,” and the echo caught it and ran it once more under his breath, *unionised*, *unionised*, and then he was grinning helplessly at the clay.

“They unionised,” Narin agreed, and let him have it, and the lane laughed with him and not at him, which Bashir had come to understand was the entire architecture of this crew, the one load-bearing wall — that the laugh went *with*.

“So the management’s got a problem,” Yusuf said, leaning all the way in now, money-brain fully lit. “Workforce down tools. Production stops. Canals silt up. No barley. What’s the fix? You can’t make the gods go back, they’ll just strike again. You need—”

“You need a *new* worker,” Narin said. “Cheaper. Replaceable. One that won’t burn its tools, or one that you don’t mind if it does.”

She picked the dun page back up. The light ran down the word at the top of it one more time — *the princely offspring*, the high-born seed of the sky, the ones who sat in council and weighed the world and would, two thousand years on, slide all the way down into the grey courts of the dead.

“And what they decide to make,” she said, and her voice changed, went lower, went almost reverent, the scholar and the heir and the believer all standing in the same body in the same heat, “what the council of the great gods decides to make so that the junior gods can rest — what they reach for, to make this new worker out of—”

She didn’t finish it.

She looked at them — Naila at the lane’s mouth, Yusuf on the stool with his whole hunger showing, Mira against the wall reading every face including hers, Edith with her hands folded over a camera she hadn’t raised, Frik bright and undefended, Bashir holding the door half-open with his whole body.

Out past the awning, in the white part of the lane, the Beast sat ticking in the heat with its water bag weeping a dark line down the dust, and a shape moved around it slow and unhurried, checking the shade, doing the thing he did that nobody could ever quite photograph; and somewhere in the citadel above them the call to something drifted thin across the rooftops, and the two rivers that had made all of this kept running south the way they'd run for six thousand years toward the cradle none of them had a permit to enter yet.

"You'll want this in the right tongue," Narin said. "Not mine paraphrasing it. The actual words. Because the next part is where they stole the most, and built the most, and where it stops being about Iraq and starts being about a book half the world prays out of — and I'm not handing *that* across on a paraphrase."

She stood. She gathered the dun page against her chest the way she had before, the gatekeeper coming back up over the scholar, but gentler now, the gate left on the latch.

"Tomorrow," she said. "My uncle's got the Atrahasis. The good edition. And we read what they made the worker out of, in the language it was written in, line by line." She looked at Bashir. "You read Sumerian?"

"Some," he said. "Enough to embarrass myself in front of you."

"Good." Almost a smile. "I'll need someone who can hear when I'm rushing it. There's a pun in the next part." She paused at the door. "There's a pun three thousand years old that the whole West missed because it can't survive the trip into Hebrew. You'll like it. It's the best joke in the Bible and nobody who quotes that verse has ever once laughed."

And she went inside, into the cool, among her uncle's shelves, and left the seven of them in the cut light of the lane with the word still hanging there unfinished — *what they reach for, to make this new worker out of* — and the answer waiting one day off, down in the older clay, in the tongue it was written in.

Bashir looked at the dust where the man and the truck had been.

The clay didn't say *spaceship*. It never had. It said *we were tired, and we made something to be tired in our place, and we made it out of—*

He didn't finish it either.

He'd wait for her to say it right.

Chapter 8 — Made of Clay

The good edition of the Atrahasis turned out to be three books, two photocopied folders, and a paper-clipped sheaf that smelled of someone else's cigarettes, all of it spread across the uncle's table under the awning while the morning still had some cool left in it.

Bashir had not slept. He'd lain on the borrowed cot in the back room and run the line in his head — *we were tired, and we made something to be tired in our place* — except in his head it kept trying to assemble itself in Sumerian and failing, because he didn't have the lines, only the rumour of them, and a man who's spent his life inside other people's words knows the difference between a sentence he can carry and one he's only heard described. He'd lain there reaching for it and missing, the way you reach in a dark kitchen for a glass you put down somewhere else.

Now Narin set a real glass in front of him. Tea, not water. The uncle's, poured from the dented pot, two sugars dropped without asking because the uncle did not ask, he simply decided you were the kind of guest who took two and was usually right.

"Drink," Narin said. "Then we work."

The uncle had gone in out of the heat. Jakobus was somewhere past the gate with the Beast and a problem involving a radiator hose and a length of rubber that had, the last anyone heard, come off a tractor; you could hear the occasional clink of a spanner and, once, a low run of whistling that climbed a scale and then abandoned it. Edith sat at the table's far end with her camera on the bench beside her, lens-cap on, hands folded, asking nothing. Friik had his back to the wall and his knee going. Mira sat where she could see all their faces at once, which was a thing Bashir had stopped noticing she did until

he'd noticed it, and now he couldn't stop seeing it. Yusuf had taken the chair closest to the books. He had a notebook open. He had not written anything in it.

"Atrahasis," Narin said. She laid her hand flat on the topmost folder. "Old Babylonian. The copy we lean on dates to the reign of Ammisaduqa — that's a name, not a date, but call it eighteenth century before Christ. Three tablets. The scribe signs them. His name is Ipiq-Aya. A junior scribe. He tells you he's junior. He apologises, basically, in the colophon."

"The scribe apologises," Frik said.

"He says he's a junior apprentice and he writes the date and then he asks the gods to bless the man who doesn't erase his tablet." A small dryness moved across her face. "Three thousand seven hundred years and a junior scribe is still asking you not to delete his file."

Yusuf made a sound that wasn't quite a laugh.

"This is older than the Bible," Narin said, and she said it plainly, the way you'd say a river is older than a bridge — not a provocation, a fact about water and stone. "Older than the oldest layer of it. I want that sitting in the room before we start. Not to take anything from anybody. Just so nobody's surprised later about which way the borrowing ran." Her eyes touched Yusuf, then moved on, kind and quick. "Now. The opening. Bashir. Read me the first line you can read."

He pulled the photocopy toward him. The transliteration ran in its little italic forest, the Sumerograms shouting in capitals through the Akkadian, and his eye found the place she'd marked with a pencil tick.

"*Inūma ilū awīlum*," he read.

He stopped. He read it again, slower, and the stopping was not for the others.

"When the gods," he said, "were man."

The awning ticked in the heat. Out by the gate the spanner went still.

"That's the first line," Narin said. "*Inūma ilū awīlum*. When the gods were man. When the gods were the man. It's deliberately strange.

It's meant to snag. The gods *were* the human — meaning, before there was a human, the gods did the human's work. They were the labour. There was no us yet, so the gods themselves had to dig."

"Dig what," Yusuf said.

"Canals." She turned a page in the folder, and there it was, the lines marching down. "This is the part everyone skips on the way to the flood. The gods are sorted into two ranks. The Anunnaki up top — the high ones, the princely ones, the bosses." She let the word sit; they'd earned it the day before, and she didn't relitigate it. "And under them, the Igigi. The working gods. The labour gods. And the Igigi carry the load. They dig the Tigris. They dig the Euphrates. By hand. For — the text gives you a span, and the span is brutal."

Bashir found it. The number stood up off the page at him.

"Forty years," he said, before he'd meant to translate it out loud. Then he checked himself, because numbers in cuneiform were exactly the trap they'd spent two days falling into. "It says — that's how I'd read it. Long stretches. Forty. Then ten. The text piles up time on them."

"Read it as 'too long,'" Narin said. "Read it as 'longer than a god should be made to dig.' That's the register. The point isn't the arithmetic." She didn't look at Naila when she said it, but Naila, who'd come up quietly to the table's edge with a heel-thump of socked feet, looked at the number and then at Narin and gave one short nod, granting it, *yes, that one's not for me, that one's a feeling dressed as a figure*, and the small permission of it passed between them without a word.

"And then," Narin said, "the Igigi have had enough."

She read it herself now, in the Akkadian, low and even, not performing it, and Bashir watched the room change shape. Mira had gone very still and was reading Narin's mouth and her throat and the small muscles beside her eyes, gathering the part of the meaning that doesn't ride on sound. Frik's knee had stopped. Even Edith's folded hands had loosened.

"They down tools," Narin said, coming back into English. "That's the only way to say it. They set fire to their digging tools. At night. They surround the house of Enlil — the chief god, the boss of bosses — they march on his door in the dark with torches, and they will not dig

another canal.” She tapped the page. “It’s the oldest labour action in the written record. The first wildcat strike is *gods*. Striking against *god*.”

“They strike,” Frik said. Soft. Delighted, almost, and ashamed of being delighted, which was its own kind of true. “The workers strike.”

“The workers strike,” Narin said, and let him have it.

Yusuf had stopped pretending to hold the pen. “So what do the bosses do.”

“They panic.” Narin almost smiled. “They genuinely panic. Enlil cries. There’s a whole scene of the high gods milling around at the door in the dark not knowing what to do, sending messengers, asking *who started this, who’s the ringleader* — and the Igigi answer, beautifully, that *all of us* started it, every one of us, we declared war together. No ringleader. You can’t behead a no.” She turned the page. “And the mother. Now we get the mother.”

Bashir felt the chapter of it turn under his hand. The forest of italics rearranged itself around a name.

“There’s a goddess,” Narin said. “Names shift on her across the versions — Nintu, Mami, Bēlet-ilī, Lady of the gods. She’s the womb-goddess. The birth-goddess. The midwife of heaven. And one of the gods — the clever one, Enki, Ea, the water-and-wisdom one — stands up in the council and proposes the solution. The Igigi won’t dig. Fine. *Make a substitute*. Make a thing that will carry the load instead. He says it to her directly.” Her finger came down on the line and stayed there. “He says: *you are the womb-goddess, the one who can create. Create a lullû. Create the human. Let him bear the yoke*.”

She looked up.

“*Lullû awīlum*. The savage human. The primitive man. The clay-thing. *Let him bear the yoke that was the gods’ yoke. Let him bear the load*. And then there’s the line. Bashir.”

He’d already found it. He’d found it before she said his name and he’d been sitting on it because saying it felt like a step you couldn’t take back.

“*I have imposed your toil on man*,” he read.

He let it land in his own chest first. It went in clean.

"I have imposed your toil on man," Narin said after him, in English, and then in the Akkadian, so the room had it both ways, so it had the dressed version and the naked one. "The gods are freed. The Igigi never have to dig again. That's what we're for. That's the *job description*. In the oldest version of the human story this civilisation wrote down, the reason we exist is that the gods got tired of working, and they made a tool, and the tool was us."

Nobody said anything.

Out at the gate a hose-clamp went *tk-tk-tk* against the radiator, three small turns, and stopped.

"Now," Narin said. "What do they make us *out of*."

She didn't rush it. She let them want it. The gatekeeper and the teacher had become, in two days, hard to tell apart; the gate was open but she still chose the order you went through.

"Two ingredients," she said. "First. Clay. Earth. The mud of the abzu, the deep waters under the ground." She paused. "Hold the clay. We come back to the clay. Second—"

She turned to the other folder, the Enuma Elish, the *good* edition with the better photographs, and slid out a glossy plate, a museum photograph of a tablet, the wedges crowding the broken edge.

"—because the recipe gets two writers, and they don't agree on the cooking, only the ingredients. Atrahasis says: they slaughter a god. A god named We-ila — a god who *had* something, the texts argue about what, intelligence, breath, a heartbeat, a *planning-spirit* — and they kill him in the assembly, and they mix his flesh and his blood into the clay. And the womb-goddess spits on the clay. And the great gods spit on it. And it's worked together — *and a ghost comes into being from the god's flesh*. The text says that. A spirit, an *eṣemmu*, a ghost, comes into the clay from the slain god and it stays. It's the part of us that doesn't go quiet. The drumbeat that goes on beating after the body's mixed. They give us a leftover piece of a dead god so the clay will get up and walk."

Bashir's hands were flat on the table. He found he'd flattened them to stop them moving.

“And Enuma Elish,” Narin said, sliding the plate an inch toward the middle of the table so they could all see the photograph, “the Babylonian one, the great one, says it slightly differently and worse. There the slain god is Kingu — the rebel general, the consort of the chaos-mother Tiamat, the one who carried the rebellion’s authority. The victorious god, Marduk, has won the war in heaven. And the council needs a labour force, same as ever — *to set the gods free, to release them from service*. And the question goes around: who’s to blame for the war? Who do we kill for this? And Kingu’s given up. They arrest him. They cut his arteries. And from *his* blood — the rebel’s, the traitor’s, the guilty party’s — Ea fashions humankind.”

She set her hand beside the photograph but did not touch it.

“So in the version half of you might’ve grown up adjacent to, in the great state liturgy of Babylon,” she said, “the substance of the human being is the blood of a condemned rebel, mixed into mud, *so that the gods can take a day off*. We are made of the guilty. We are made of the loser. We are made to clock in.”

It was Yusuf who broke.

He didn’t make a scene of it. That was almost the worst part, Bashir thought afterward — that Yusuf, who could fill a room when he wanted to, who’d talked their way past three checkpoints and a man with a clipboard who’d hated all of them on sight, just sat there with his closed notebook and his idle pen and went somewhere behind his own eyes, and his jaw worked once, and he said, to the photograph, not to any of them:

“That’s it?”

“Yusuf,” Narin said.

“No — I’m asking. That’s the real one. That’s the original. The thing under the thing.” His voice stayed level and that was how Bashir knew it wasn’t level at all. “We dug it up, we deciphered it, we did all the work, and *that’s* what it says. We were made because somebody upstairs didn’t want to dig their own ditch.”

“Yes,” Narin said. She didn’t soften it. She’d watched a lot of people meet this text and she knew the only insult was a lie. “That’s what it says.”

Yusuf turned the pen over in his fingers. Once. Twice.

And Bashir watched the door close on him, and understood — fully, with his whole chest, for the first time since a man with sunglasses and a clean hanky had found him in a Marseille hostel and asked him in four languages whether he'd ever wondered about a certain seal-impression — understood what the man had actually gathered them around. Not a mystery. A grief, with a mystery painted over it.

Because Bashir had read the other version too. He'd read it in English, years back, in a paperback with a foil cover, on a long train with nowhere to be. *They came for gold*. The sky-people, the long-lived ones, the home planet with the failing atmosphere; they came down to the marsh-lands to mine, and the work was hard, and the working ones rebelled — *they* down their tools, in that telling, same as the Igigi — and so the chief scientist and the birth-goddess took the clay of this planet and the *essence* of a sky-person and they made a worker. A primitive worker. Made in their image, with a piece of them inside it, to carry the load.

The skeleton was the same. He could see it now, laid bare on the table beside the real one: rebellion-of-the-workers, decision-to-make-a-substitute, clay-of-the-earth plus a-divine-contribution, made-to-bear-the-load. Bone for bone. Joint for joint. Whoever had written the foil paperback had not invented a thing. He'd kept the whole skeleton and changed the meat. He'd swapped the gods for astronauts and the canals for gold and the ghost-in-the-clay for *a splice of DNA*, and—

And he'd done one more thing, and that was the thing that had Yusuf turning his pen over, and Bashir said it before he could stop himself, the way Narin had read the line about the toil before she meant to.

"He made it kinder."

They all looked at him. Mira's eyes came to his mouth.

"The — the other version. The famous one." He kept his eyes on the photograph because it was easier than faces. "It says the same skeleton. But it tells it kinder. In that one *we're designed*. *We're a project*. Someone clever stood over the clay and *wanted* a thing and made it on purpose and put a piece of themselves in it because they needed it to be smart enough to use a *pickaxe*. You're — in that story

you matter. You're the solution. You're wanted." He swallowed. "In *this* one—" he put two fingers on the museum plate, near the broken edge, not quite touching the glossy wedges "—in this one we're a way the bosses got out of digging. We're made of mud and a corpse so the management can knock off early. There's no part of it that needs us to be clever. There's no part of it that *wants* us. It just needs the ditch dug by something that isn't a god."

He stopped.

"That's the trade," he said. "That's the whole trade. The alien story keeps every bone and gives you back the one thing this story takes away. It tells you you were *meant*."

The awning ticked. Somewhere a generator two streets over coughed and caught.

Naila had been standing at the corner of the table with her arms wrapped around herself, swaying a little, the table-edge under one hand where she could feel the grain of it. She'd been quiet through all of it, doing her own arithmetic, and now she said, to the wood, in the flat clear way she said the true things:

"It's the same shape. Drawn around a nicer middle." She tapped twice on the table, lining something up nobody else could see. "If you want the shape to be true you have to take the middle that comes with it. They cut the middle out and glued in a better one and kept the shape, and people felt the shape was *real* — because it is, it's three thousand seven hundred years real — and they thought the feeling of the shape was a feeling about the middle." Another tap. "It isn't. The shape's old. The middle's new. The new middle is the part that makes you feel chosen." She looked up, found Yusuf, held it for the half-second she could. "It's a comfort wearing a fact's coat."

Yusuf put the pen down. Flat. Deliberate. Like a man laying down a tool.

"I read all of it," he said. Quietly. To Naila, because she'd given him the room to. "All twelve books. I read them on a phone, in a Land Cruiser, between two consignments I'm not proud of, while a man across the dashboard counted money that was the wrong colour. And the whole time I'm reading—" He stopped. Started again. "You want to know the worst of it? It wasn't even about the aliens for me."

It was that it made the world have a *reason*. It made all of it — the consignments, the money, the man, *me* — it made it a chapter in something. Like there was a plan and I'd just lost the page. And I needed there to be a plan so badly that I never once asked the page what it actually said." He looked at the photograph. At the wedges. "And this is what it actually said. We were made to dig. And then to die. There's a flood coming in tablet three to thin us out because we get too loud. We breed and we make noise and the boss can't sleep, so he drowns us. That's the *plan*, Naila. That's what was on the page I was so desperate to find."

"Yes," said Narin, again, and this time she did soften it, but not the fact — only the silence around it. She reached and turned the Atrahasis folder so the photograph faced her, and she touched the broken edge of the worker-line, the *I have imposed your toil on man*, with a fingertip, the way you'd touch a scar that wasn't yours.

"But listen to me, because I'm the one who has to live next door to this text," she said. "It is the bleaker story. It's mud and a dead man's blood and forty years of digging and a flood for the crime of being loud. That's all true. And it is also the *braver* one. Because these people—" her hand opened over the books, the photocopies, the cigarette-smelling sheaf, her uncle's whole crowded shelf "—these people sat in the heat between two rivers four thousand years ago and looked their actual situation in the face. The canals really did have to be dug. By hand. By people. Forever. The river really did flood and really did drown the loud and the quiet alike with no regard for anybody's plan. And instead of telling themselves a story where the sky loved them and built them on purpose, they told the truth: *we are clay and a borrowed spark, and the work is endless, and the water does not care*. And then—"

She stopped. The teacher caught herself one syllable before a sermon, and the gate came down to exactly the height she wanted it.

"And then they kept going anyway," she said. "They wrote it down. They signed it. Ipiq-Aya the junior scribe wrote *please don't erase me* at the bottom of the bleakest story a person ever told about themselves, and three thousand seven hundred years later we did not erase him. He's right here. We're saying his name." She looked around the table. "That's not nothing. That's the opposite of nothing. They didn't need to be chosen to be worth the clay. That's braver

than any spaceship.”

It was very quiet for a moment.

Then Frik, who had not blurted once in twenty minutes, who’d held it the way you hold a breath, let it out, and it came out true the way it always came out true, aimed at the foil paperback that wasn’t even on the table:

“He gave you the gold to look at so you’d never read the *ditch*.”

And the awful elegant rightness of it sat there, because that was the seam, exactly — the gold was the bright thing, the gold pulled the eye, *they came for gold* was a treasure-hunt and a treasure-hunt is a kind of hope; and behind the gold the original word stood plain and unhopeful: *toil*. Imposed. On man.

Out at the gate the spanner clinked down onto stone. There was the sound of a hand testing a fresh clamp, the squeak of rubber seating home, and then the low whistle again, climbing its scale, and this time finishing it — a small, complete, unhurried tune, the sound of a man who had fixed a thing and was content to let the fixing be the whole of it, and asked nothing of the table about what it had found.

Narin let it breathe. Then she pulled the third folder over — thinner, older photocopies, a different hand of marginalia in it, in a script Bashir didn’t know.

“Tomorrow we’ll do the pun,” she said. “The Lady of the Rib. I promised you the best joke in the Bible and I keep my promises.” A flicker. “But you’re not ready for the joke until you believe the rest. Until you believe it isn’t a fairy tale somebody made up at a campfire. Until you believe people sat in a real city and read this off a real tablet and *checked each other’s work*.”

She set her hand on the thin folder.

“Because that’s the part nobody tells you,” she said. “Everyone wants to argue about what the clay says. Almost nobody asks the question that should come first.” She looked at them, the gatekeeper gone all the way down now, the scholar offering it up. “How do we even know we can *read* it? A dead language nobody’d spoken in two thousand years, in a script with six hundred signs, dug out of a hill in pieces? How does anyone *prove* they cracked that — and didn’t just make up

a story about a story?"

She turned the folder so its faded first page faced the room.

"Tomorrow," Narin said, "I'm going to tell you about the time four men sealed their answers in four envelopes."

Yusuf picked his pen back up.

This time, he wrote.

Chapter 9 — The Real Evidence

Naila woke before the heat did, which was the only honest hour in Erbil. She had learned this in two days. The light came up grey-gold over the citadel and the air still held the night's coolness like a held breath, and for maybe forty minutes a person could think without their own sweat arguing with them. She took the thin folder out to the awning table while the others slept, because she wanted to read the sealed-envelope story alone before Narin narrated it. She wanted to find the shape of it herself. She did not want to be *shown* the pattern. She wanted to *catch* it.

The marginalia in this folder was in the script Bashir didn't know — Syriac, Narin had said, her grandmother's hand, a woman who had copied scholarship by lamp the way other women copied recipes. Naila couldn't read the Syriac either. But she could read the photocopied English under it, and she could read the structure, and the structure was what made her sit very still with her tea going cold.

It went like this.

A man named Henry Rawlinson, an army officer, had spent years hanging off a cliff in Persia. The cliff was called Behistun, and three hundred feet up it, a Persian king named Darius had carved a brag the size of a billboard: I am Darius, I crushed the liars, the god Ahuramazda gave me the kingdom. He'd carved it three times, in three languages — Old Persian, Elamite, Babylonian — because he wanted everyone in his empire to read it, and the three languages were three doors into the same room.

Naila's chest did the thing it did when a system clicked. Three state-

ments. Same content. Different code. If you could read one, you had a key to the others. It was *parallel text*. It was the most beautiful kind of proof there was, because you didn't have to trust the man who carved it; you only had to trust that he'd said the same thing three times, and that arithmetic — the brute, unbendable count of which sign sat where — would hold him to it.

She heard the awning rustle. Mira, barefoot on the packed earth, hair flat on one side from sleep, reading Naila's face before Naila said a word. Mira tapped two fingers near her own eye — *you're seeing something* — and sat, and Naila turned the page so they could both look, and that was a whole conversation.

The rest of the house woke in pieces. Yusuf with coffee he'd made wrong and drunk anyway. Bashir with a notebook already open, as if he slept holding it. Frik in last night's shirt, hands going, jaw working on a word that hadn't decided to come out yet. Edith last, camera bag over one shoulder by reflex, the strap-mark already worn pale into the canvas. Out past the gate the Beast sat with its hood down now, and a low African vowel-music drifted off it — Jakobus, working a wet rag over the windscreen against the dust, asking the morning for nothing.

Then Narin came out with the real coffee and the rest of the folder and the morning began.

"He nearly died for it," Narin said, before she sat. "Rawlinson. Behistun. People skip that part. He's swinging off a rope on a cliff three hundred feet up, copying a Persian king's victory speech sign by sign, and the only ladder to the Babylonian section is gone, so he hires a Kurdish boy — a local boy, mind you —" a small, dry stress on *local* that landed on every foreigner at the table at once — "who free-climbs across the rock face with a paper squeeze and copies what no adult could reach. So when people tell you cuneiform was *cracked*, remember a Kurdish kid with no rope is in that sentence, and nobody knows his name."

Edith's hand moved toward the camera bag. Stopped. Did not.

Naila watched her stop. So did Mira.

"Old Persian came first," Narin went on. "Forty-odd signs, alphabetic-

ish, the easy door. They guessed at it from the proper names — you find *Darius*, *Xerxes*, *Hystaspes* in the king-lists, you find the same shapes on the rock in the right places, you start matching sounds. Slow. Years. Arguments. But the Persian gave them the key, and the key turned the Babylonian, because Darius had said the same thing three times.” She set a hand flat on the table. “And *that’s* where it gets ugly. Because Babylonian — Akkadian cuneiform — isn’t forty signs. It’s six hundred. And the same sign can be a syllable, or a whole word, or a silent marker telling you what *kind* of word is coming. One sign reads four different ways depending on its mood.”

“Polyvalence,” Bashir said, soft, like a name he was glad to hear out loud. “It’s not a code. It’s a *language wearing* a code.”

“It’s a nightmare,” Narin said. “And here’s the part the believers should sit with. By the 1850s you had four men in Europe all claiming they could read it. Edward Hincks, an Irish parson stuck in a country rectory — possibly the best of them, never got the credit. Henry Rawlinson, the cliff man, all bluster. Jules Oppert, German-French, brilliant and prickly. And William Henry Fox Talbot — yes, *that* Talbot, the photography one—”

Edith’s head came up.

“—he invented the negative and then got bored and learned dead languages,” Narin said, and let the small smile happen. “And the field had a problem. Because four men reading the same broken tablet and getting four different stories — that’s not a science. That’s a séance. That’s everybody seeing the face they brought with them.”

Frik’s hands went still. His mouth opened. “*That’s the fringe*,” he said — flat, blurted, not to anyone. “Four men. Four stories. Pick one.” His face coloured at having said it. Nobody moved to make it a thing.

“Yes,” Narin said simply, like he’d answered a question correctly. “That’s exactly the fringe. So in 1857 they did something the fringe has never once done in its life.”

She slid a single page to the centre of the table. A photocopy of a printed report, Royal Asiatic Society, the long S’s of old type.

“Somebody had dug up a clay prism — a barrel of baked clay, eight sides, covered in the annals of an Assyrian king, Tiglath-Pileser the First. Eight hundred lines. A king bragging about his wars and his

hunts and the temples he fixed, which is what kings did, it was the only thing they ever did. And the Society had a brilliant, nasty idea.” Narin’s eyes had the brightness now that Naila had learned meant the gate was open all the way. “They printed four copies of the prism. They sent one to each man. Hincks, Rawlinson, Oppert, Talbot. *Translate this. Independently. Tell no one. Seal your answer in an envelope and send it back to us unopened.*”

The table was very quiet. Out at the gate the rag stopped on the glass, then started again.

Naila felt the shape lock. This was the thing she’d caught at dawn and hadn’t had the word for. “Blind,” she said. “It was blind. None of them could bend toward the others. None of them could see the answer and steer the glyphs to meet it.”

“It was a *trial*,” Narin said. “It was the cradle of the whole discipline putting its own neck on the block. Because if the four envelopes came back four different stories, that was the end. Then cuneiform was a *séance*, and everyone reading it was a fraud or a fool, and you could fold the whole field up and go home. They *risked it*. That’s the part. They were willing to be proven liars in public.”

“And?” Yusuf said. He’d stopped writing. He had a habit, Naila had noticed, of going still when money or proof was on the table — the part of him that used to evaluate whether a thing was real for a buyer.

“The twenty-ninth of May, 1857,” Narin said. “They opened the four envelopes in front of a committee. Four men. Four sealed translations of eight hundred lines of an arrogant dead king. And they *matched*.” She tapped the page. “Not perfectly. There were disagreements — a number here, an unclear sign there. They were honest about those; it’s *in the report*. But the substance? The king, the campaigns, the gods, the structure, the sense of it? The same. Four men in four rooms had read the same dead tongue the same way and not known they agreed until the envelopes opened.”

She let it sit.

“That,” Narin said, “is the moment cuneiform stopped being a guess and became a *reading*. That is the receipt. When somebody tells you the scholars just *invented* a way to read the clay — that they’re all in on a story — you tell them about the envelopes. Because the men

who made this field earned it by agreeing to be caught if they were wrong. They submitted to the seal.”

Naila was already running it. Couldn't not. The arithmetic of it, the cleanness.

“It's reproducible,” she said. “That's what it is. It's the whole thing science is. You hide the answer from the people generating it, you let them work alone, and if they land in the same place by separate roads, the place is real — not the road, the *place*.” She heard her own voice going faster, the flat fast cadence the others had stopped flinching at. “It's a control. They built a control. They didn't trust *themselves*, that's the genius, they didn't trust their own desire to be right—”

“Naila.” Bashir, gently, two fingers tapped on the wood — their version of *land it*.

She landed it. Breathed. “It's a good system,” she said, quieter. “It's a really good system.”

“It's the *opposite* system,” Bashir said, and now he leaned in, and the polyglot's loneliness went out of his face the way it always did when language stopped being a border and started being a key. “Think about what the other method is. The fringe method. You decide first — the gods were astronauts, say. You *know* the answer before you open the envelope. Then you go to the clay and you find the signs that fit and you blur the signs that don't. You bend the glyph to the story.” He turned his hands over, empty. “These four men did the inverse. They made it *impossible* to bend. They sealed the story away from the glyph. They made themselves blind on purpose so the clay could speak.”

“Say the other one,” Naila said. “Say nibiru.”

Bashir almost laughed. “*Nibiru*. Yes. The famous twelfth planet. It's a real Akkadian word — *nēberu*. You know what it means? It means a crossing. A ferry-point. The place you cross a river. The Babylonians used it as the name for a celestial *position* — the point a planet crosses at its high station.” He spread his hands. “Most often: Jupiter. You can watch it. It's up there every year. *Nēberu* is the crossing-point of *Jupiter*, a thing a Babylonian could see with his own

eyes from a rooftop.” A beat. “It is never — not once, not anywhere — a death-planet on a thirty-six-hundred-year orbit full of gold-miners. That sum was done by reading the word as a story you brought with you, and never opening the envelope.”

“And the *sar*,” Frik said. He’d been holding it, Naila could tell — the over-reach he’d punctured at the museum, days ago now, that had cost him a flinch then too. He got it out clean. “The three-thousand-six-hundred. They call it the *orbit*.” His hands flared and settled. “It’s a *number*. Base sixty. Sixty times sixty. It’s how they *counted*. It’s not a clock for a planet, it’s — it’s *math homework*.”

“It’s their sixty,” Narin said. “We still have it. Sixty seconds, sixty minutes, three hundred and sixty degrees. We are standing in their arithmetic right now and we don’t even feel it. *Sar* is a *big round number* the way we say a *million* — and someone read it as a doomsday calendar.” Her mouth twisted, but not cruelly. “The men who guessed read forward from a story. The four men in 1857 read backward from the clay. One of those methods built a discipline that can read a dead king’s grocery list. The other one sold a lot of paperbacks.”

The cruelty wasn’t in it. Naila noticed that, the way she noticed everything. Narin wasn’t sneering at the paperbacks. She’d said it almost tired.

Yusuf had gone quiet in the particular way he went quiet, and Naila watched Mira watch him, because Mira had clocked it first. He turned the RAS page around with one finger, slow.

“It would’ve been easier if they hadn’t matched,” Yusuf said, to the page. “For them. Four different answers, you can argue forever. Argument is a market. As long as nobody’s *sure*, everybody’s selling.” He didn’t look up. “These four men closed the market. They made it boring. They made it *settled*. And settled doesn’t sell.”

Nobody asked him what he meant. Naila understood it sideways anyway — that he was talking about the paperbacks, and not only the paperbacks. That he’d been the kind of man who profited from things staying loud. That the man across the table from himself five years ago would’ve hated this room.

The heat had its hand on the day now. The awning’s shade had pulled

in tight. Out at the gate Jakobus had gone from the windscreen to the radiator, and the Beast made its small sounds, and twice his shadow crossed the gravel and didn't come closer.

Narin folded the RAS page back into its sleeve, and the gate in her face changed key. The teaching gate closed. A harder one came down.

"Now," she said. "The next part isn't a story. It's logistics. And it's where I find out whether you're tourists."

Edith's camera bag was on the table. Narin looked at it, then at Edith, until Edith moved it onto the bench beside her, off the wood. It was not subtle and was not meant to be.

"You want to go south," Narin said. "All of you, even if you haven't said it. You've got the cradle in your eyes. Uruk. Ur. Eridu. The first city, the first writing, the first wheel — it's all *down there*, in the alluvium, where the two rivers used to meet the sea before the silt moved the coast. That's the real thing. That's where the clay we've been reading came *out of the ground*." She let it ache for half a second, because it was aching in her too. "And we are *not going there*. Not on this trip. Maybe not on any trip you're part of."

"Why?" Bashir asked. No challenge in it. He of all of them knew what a border cost.

"Because south is Baghdad's writ, federal Iraq, and that's a different set of permits, a different security picture, a different *decade* of trust I'd have to spend to take seven foreigners with cameras down there safely, and I won't spend it on a road trip." She didn't raise her voice. That was the thing — she never raised it. "Up here is the Kurdistan Region. The KRG runs its own antiquities, its own roads, its own answer to the question *who is this person and why are they near the tablets*. It's the safe north. It's the part the West is allowed to visit. And even *here* I had to vouch for you. With my name. To people who remember every foreigner who ever came to look at the clay and decide what it meant *for us*."

The diesel-and-dust grain of it sat in the room now, the way it had sat under the whole trip — that they were not on a set, that there were forms with real stamps, that a man named Yusuf had spent three weeks of phone calls and one favour he didn't explain to get them an

awning to sit under at all.

“There’s a tablet moving,” Narin said. Flat. “You should know that’s why I let you this close. Not the lecture. The lecture’s just so you don’t embarrass me. There’s a tablet that came out of the south in ’03 — out of the museum, or out of a dig nobody licensed, I don’t know which yet — and it surfaced two months ago in a sale catalogue. A streaming outfit’s involved. The kind that makes the pretty documentaries. And the catalogue copy calls it—” her jaw set “—it calls it *possible evidence of pre-Sumerian astronomical knowledge*. Which is the new way of saying aliens without saying aliens, so the lawyers stay calm.”

“What’s it actually say,” Naila asked. She had to know. The arithmetic of the thing was already itching.

“I’ve seen one photograph. Bad light.” Narin’s mouth did something complicated. “It’s a school text. A *practice* tablet. A scribe-student copying out grain measures and a list of beer rations for temple workers. *Dubsiga* — a name, a foreman maybe, *your servant so-and-so*. It’s a kid’s homework, three and a half thousand years old, and somebody is going to sell it for the price of a flat by calling its number-columns a star map.” She looked around the table. “And here’s the obscene part, the part that should make you angry. The *louder* the lie, the *safer* the theft. A tablet called *proof of ancient astronauts* is worth more on the grey market — and *nobody who could read it ever gets near it*, because the only people in the room are buyers who want the story. If they called it what it is — a beer-ration list — some Assyriologist would walk past the case, read it in four seconds, and ask where it came from.” She let that land hard. “The myth is the markup. And the myth is also the *camouflage*. It’s the best cover a smuggler ever had. Make it about aliens, and you’ve made it *un-investigable*, because everyone serious looks away and everyone who looks is in on the wanting.”

Edith had gone very still. The 2003 in her was on her face — Naila couldn’t read it the way Mira could, but she could see the cost of it, the held breath. Edith had photographs of the museum that year. The sacks going out. She’d never said it but it was in the room every time the looting came up, and Narin knew it was in the room, and that was half of why the camera bag had had to go on the bench.

“And the other lie’s just as useful to them,” Narin said, softer now, and this was the part Naila hadn’t seen coming. “Not just the believers. The *shruggers*. The clever ones who say *oh it’s all just myth, who cares, it’s all made-up stories anyway*.” She looked, briefly, at no one and everyone. “That’s the best cover of all. Because the believer at least *wants* the tablet to be real. The shrugger doesn’t care if it’s real or stolen or sold or smashed, it’s all *just old superstition* to him. You want to move a crate of looted clay through customs? Don’t hire a smuggler. Hire a cynic. Hire a man who thinks none of it matters.” Her voice didn’t rise. It got quieter, which was worse. “Both of them — the one who thinks it’s spaceships and the one who thinks it’s nothing — both of them help the crate move. The only person who stops the crate is the one who thinks it’s *exactly* what it is. A boy’s homework. Sacred and ordinary and *somebody’s*.”

The Beast’s engine turned over out at the gate, caught, settled into an idle. Jakobus had it breathing again. The water bag swayed on the wing where it had been hung to weep and cool, and the music had stopped because the engine was the music now. He didn’t come in. He never came in for this part. He was outside making the thing that would carry them, and he left the inside of it — the language, the meaning, the grief, the *who decides* — to the people whose it was.

“So that’s the gate,” Narin said. “It doesn’t open south. It opens *here*, it opens *slow*, and it opens only as far as I say, and I can close it whenever you make me regret it.” She looked around once more, and something underneath the hardness was almost — not soft, but *level*. Equal. “You read pattern. You read tongues. You read faces and money and the thing a man blurts when he can’t help it. Fine. Good. I needed people who read. But the place is not a puzzle for you to solve and leave. There are people *living* on the cradle right now, in the alluvium, in the dust, going to school, getting married, burying their dead, over the top of the first city anybody ever built. They are not scenery. The West made my ancestors into scenery once. Into a B-movie. I will not hand them to you to do it again.”

Nobody spoke. Frik’s hands were still. Even Naila’s were.

Then Mira moved.

She’d been watching the whole time — not the page, not the tablet talk, *Narin* — and now she lifted one hand and signed something slow

and careful and entirely wrong, the crew's terrible handmade dialect, and Bashir started to translate it and stopped, because Narin's face had changed before the words arrived. Whatever Mira had read in her — the thing under the hardness, the thing the lecture was built to cover — Mira had seen it, and let Narin see that she'd seen it.

Narin didn't answer. She looked at Mira for a long moment, and the room understood, in the way a room does, that they had walked up to an edge and that the edge had a name and that Narin was not going to say it.

Naila looked at the third folder, the one with the grandmother's Syriac in the margins. The pun was in there. *Tomorrow*, Narin had promised. The Lady of the Rib.

But the pun lived in the same book as the Flood and the clay and the genealogy, and Naila understood, watching Mira watch Narin, that the joke was going to cost the woman who told it more than any of them had thought a joke could cost.

Mira lowered her hand. And kept her eyes on Narin's face, reading the thing the mouth wouldn't say.

Chapter 10 — What She Won't Say

The bazaar came at Mira through her feet first.

Erbil's old market wrapped the base of the citadel like a thing that had grown there, and Mira walked it the way she walked everywhere — through the soles of her boots, through her hips, through the rail of warm air that pressed off a baker's oven and broke against her cheek. She felt the generator before she saw it: a low industrial shudder coming up the cobbles, the kind of drone that lived under hearing aids and made them useless, so she'd switched them off an hour ago and let the world go to its truer self. Vibration. Light. Faces.

The faces were the loud part.

Two men by a copper stall, arguing about a price with their whole bodies, hands open, shoulders rolling, neither of them angry — she could tell from the eyes, which stayed soft even as the hands shouted. A grandmother in black, sorting dried limes, her mouth moving in the patient nothing-shapes of a song. A boy running a tray of tea glasses overhead, threading the crowd, his attention a wire pulled taut from the tray to the gap to the next gap. Mira read it all without trying. She'd never had a choice. When the ears go, the eyes do the work the ears refuse, and after thirty-some years the eyes don't stop, can't be told to stand down, will sit in a meeting and tell you who's lying before the lie finishes its first syllable.

Narin walked two steps ahead, and Narin was the only person in the bazaar Mira couldn't fully read.

That was the interesting thing. That was the thing that had kept Mira

up the night before, after the session under the awning, after she'd reached out one bad clumsy hand and shown Narin that she'd seen the edge of it — the thing under the lecture, the thing the lecture was a wall against. Narin had built a beautiful wall. Mira admired walls. She'd built a few. But she'd spent a lifetime watching the seams where a wall meets the face that's holding it up, and Narin's seam was *there*, just under the left eye, in the small muscle that tightened every time the talk got near the third folder. The one with the grandmother's handwriting in the margins.

Narin turned and said something. Mira caught *uncle*, caught *tea*, caught the lift of her brows that meant a question, and nodded, and they climbed.

The uncle's place was up a stair off the bazaar, under an awning of corrugated tin and threaded vine, on a flat roof that looked over the whole churning market toward the walls of the oldest continuously inhabited place on the planet. Mira knew that fact the way you know a thing from a placard. Standing in it was different. The citadel sat up there in the late gold like a loaf of risen earth, and somewhere under it, layer on layer on layer, were the bones of every Erbil that had ever been, going down past memory into the dark where the first writing had been pressed into the first clay by people who never imagined a woman would stand here who couldn't hear a word of their language and would understand them anyway.

The uncle was small and broad and had hands like the limes downstairs, brown and creased and capable. He saw Mira's hearing aids — she watched him see them, watched the half-second recalibration that most people botched and he didn't — and he didn't shout, didn't slow his lips into a mush, didn't grab her elbow. He simply turned his body square to her, full face, good light behind her so his own face was lit, and welcomed her with his whole front. Some people knew. You couldn't predict who. A man who'd spent eighty years on a roof above a market had learned to be read, and so he made himself readable, and Mira loved him instantly and without complication.

He poured tea. There was no negotiating it. The glass came small and waisted and scalding, amber going to copper, a sugar cube parked on the saucer, and he set it in front of her and watched until

she lifted it, and only then did his shoulders come down. *You cannot refuse this*, his whole posture said, and Mira had no intention of refusing anything on this roof.

The rest of the crew came up the stair in ones and twos. Bashir, who folded onto a cushion and started talking to the uncle before he'd finished sitting, the two of them lobbing words back and forth — Arabic, then something older, the uncle's eyebrows going up in delight at whatever Bashir had reached for. Naila, who took the corner seat with the wall at her back and the stair in her sightline, and to whom the uncle handed tea without making it a thing, because Bashir must have said a quiet word at some point about exits. Frik, whose head ticked twice toward the citadel and who said, very clearly, "*Big*," and nothing else, and the uncle laughed, a real laugh, and Frik's whole face opened. Edith last, with the camera at her hip, not raised, the strap doubled around her wrist.

And outside the awning, down the stair and across the little square where the Beast was parked under a plane tree, Jakobus. Mira could see him through the gap in the vine: a shape at the rear of the vehicle, doing something to a canvas bag that hung off the back and wept a slow dark line of water down the dusty paint. Cooling the water by letting it cool itself, some desert magic. He didn't come up. He never came up to these. He stood by the made thing he understood and let the people who understood the other things do their understanding. The uncle, though — the uncle had gone to the edge of the roof when the Beast first pulled in, and called something down, and Jakobus had answered him, three words, and the uncle had come back to his stove looking like a man who'd been handed a small good gift. Mira had no idea what was said. She only knew that Jakobus, who could not be read, who stood at the wrong angle to every light, had said something to an old Kurdish man on a roof that made the old man glad.

Then Narin sat, and the tea went around, and the third folder came out of her bag and lay on the low table, closed.

Edith lifted the camera.

She did it slowly, the way she'd been doing everything slowly since Baghdad came up — and it had come up, the museum, the sacks,

the year that was in Edith's camera roll and was the reason Narin had looked at the lens for the first three days like it was a weapon, because for Narin it had been. Mira watched the lift. She watched Narin's eyes go to it. She watched Edith *stop*, the camera at half-height, and turn it toward Narin instead of toward the table, and ask — actually ask, not with a raised brow and a hopeful angle but with her free hand making the small flat circle the crew used for *okay?*, then a point at the folder, then a question-shrug.

Narin looked at the folder. Looked at the camera. Said something. Mira caught the shape: *the folder, no. My uncle, no. Me, you can.*

Edith lowered the camera all the way down. Set it in her lap. Put her open hand over the lens like a lid.

Something in Narin's seam eased. Not the deep one. A shallow one, the one that had been about the lens. There were two walls, Mira had understood that under the awning — one against the camera, which Edith was learning to disarm, and one further in, against the folder, which no one could disarm because Narin was holding it up herself with her own face.

The uncle refilled glasses no one had emptied.

Bashir began to translate the session as it ran, but Mira didn't need the words and the words weren't where it lived anyway, so she let his hands do their job at the edge of her sight and gave her eyes to Narin.

The folder opened. The grandmother's Syriac was there, looping up the margins of a typed Sumerian transcription, and beneath each line in a third hand the English. Narin's finger moved along a line. Her mouth made a word Mira had seen her make before, two days ago, under the awning, when the whole conversation had bent around a single broken bone of a joke. *Ninti*. The Lady of the Rib. Bashir's hands flowered when he came to it — Mira saw him reach for the air the way he did when a thing only lived in one language, his fingers opening on *rib*, then opening again on *life*, the same sign twice because Sumerian had hung two meanings on one peg and the joke was the peg. *Ti* is rib. *Ti* is life. So Ninti, the goddess made to heal the water-god's aching side, is both Lady of the Rib and Lady Who Makes Live, and the pun is three thousand years old and it is still

funny, and it is hiding under a woman built from a sleeping man's rib in a book that came a thousand years later, the joke worn smooth by the crossing, the peg pulled out and only the rib left.

Mira watched Frik take that in. Watched his hands go still on his knees the way they had at the very end of the last session — the stillness that wasn't a tic at all, that was the opposite of a tic, a man so caught by a true thing that the noise in him went quiet. Naila had gone still the same way. They'd all gone still. A joke that survived three thousand years and one whole change of God.

But Mira wasn't watching the joke.

She was watching Narin, because the joke was the easy part, the part Narin had promised under the awning — *tomorrow, the Lady of the Rib* — and the easy part was over now, and Narin's finger had stopped moving on the page. It rested at the foot of the column. Below the joke. Where the typed Sumerian ran out and there was only the grandmother's Syriac and then the English under it, and Narin's mouth was not making the English.

Bashir's hands paused, waiting for her.

Naila leaned in toward the page, and her voice came — Mira couldn't hear it, but she saw it land on the others, saw Bashir's hands pick it up: *the same flood, the same clay, the same council of gods deciding to make a worker out of mud and a dead god's blood*. The pattern. Naila's gift. The same shape across cultures, the older draft showing through the newer one like a wall showing through plaster. Naila said it cleanly, kindly, the way she said the true things, with no idea — Mira could see she had no idea — what it was doing to the woman across the table.

Because Narin had not moved.

Here is what being talked-over feels like, from the inside.

It is not loud. That's the thing people get wrong, the hearing people, who think the harm is volume. It's the opposite of volume. You are in the room. You have a thing to say, and the thing is true and you can see that it's true and you have seen it before anyone, you saw it three sentences ago and you have been carrying it, waiting for the

gap — and the gap doesn't come, because the gap is sound and you don't make sound the way they do, and the talk runs over the place where your turn would be like water running over a stone. You are not contradicted. You are not even disagreed with. You are simply not there in the part of the room where the deciding happens, and you watch them decide without the thing you carried, and the thing was the thing they needed, and you watch them go without it.

Mira had lived in that room her whole life. She knew it from the floor up. And so she knew, watching Narin's finger rest at the foot of the column, watching Narin not make the English, that Narin was in a version of the same room. Not Mira's room. Narin could hear. Narin could speak; Narin spoke five languages and out-read every person on this roof on the clay and the meaning, and it was *her* meaning, her language, her dead and her grief and her God. But she had walked up to a thing she carried, the thing under all the other things, and she had reached the gap where her turn was — and her own mouth had run over it like water over a stone. She was talking-over herself. She had a wall and the wall was made of her own voice, the beautiful confident teacher's voice, and the voice was running so the silence couldn't, because in the silence was the thing she would not say.

Naila and Bashir kept working the pattern between them, gentle, brilliant, building the bridge from the clay to the page, the older draft to the newer, and Mira understood with her whole body that they were building it *toward* Narin and that Narin could not cross it, and that no one but Mira could see she couldn't.

So Mira reached across the low table and put two fingers, very lightly, on the back of Narin's resting hand.

The talk stopped. Bashir's hands froze mid-sign. The whole roof felt it — the way a room feels it, the way the cobbles had felt the generator. Narin looked up.

Mira signed.

She signed badly. The crew's handmade dialect, half-invented at a thousand campfires, was a pidgin even by the generous standards of pidgins, and Mira's own native sign was a different country anyway, and Narin knew no sign at all. So Mira did the only true thing, which was to make the signs slowly enough that the *shape* of them carried even when the words didn't. She touched her own chest. She touched

the folder. She made the sign the crew used for *holy*, which was wrong, was somebody's guess from years ago, two hands lifting like a roof — and Narin, who couldn't read the sign, read the roof, read the lift, read Mira's face under it, which was not asking Narin to say the thing.

That was the whole message. Mira had it down to nothing. *I see that you won't say it. You don't have to say it. I am not going to make you say it, the way they're about to make you say it without knowing they're making you.*

Bashir started to translate the sign and Mira shook her head at him, once, and he stopped, and got it, and his hands came down, and the roof understood that for once the words were not the point and the man who lived inside all the world's words was the one who saw it first.

Narin's seam went. The deep one. The one under the left eye that the whole lecture had been built to hold.

She didn't cry. It wasn't that. Mira would have hated it if it had been that — the easy release, the witnessed weep, the camera-shaped grief. It was smaller and worse and truer. The muscle let go, and for one second Narin's face was not a teacher's face and not a gate-keeper's face and not the face of the woman who had told the West *I will not hand them to you*. It was the face of a person who had found out, somewhere back along the line of her training, in a library or over her grandmother's shoulder, that the book her people had carried into exile and out of it, the book they'd kept their soul inside while empire after empire tried to grind them into scenery — that this book had a genealogy. That the Flood in it had an older draft. That the clay-and-blood, the council, the worker made of mud, were *there before*, in Babylon, in the very tongue of the people who carried her ancestors off in chains.

And that this was not a wound to the book.

That was the thing under the thing. Mira read it whole, in the second the seam gave, before Narin's voice came back to cover it. The terror in the wall was that the genealogy would be a verdict — that a hundred grinning men with green-lit logos would say *see, it's all just stolen*

myth, the Bible's a fraud, the woo and the shrug are the same coin and we'll spend it both ways — and that her grandmother's loops in the margin would become a punchline in someone's streaming doc. And under *that* terror, the deeper thing, the thing she had walked up to and would not say:

That she had read the older draft, and the newer one, and she knew what the newer one had *done* with the older furniture. The Babylonian gods make the man out of mud to do the gods' toil, to break their backs digging the rivers so the gods can rest — the man is a slave, made because somebody had to dig and the gods were sick of digging. And the book her people carried took that same furniture — the clay, the breath, the council, the *let us make* — and turned it inside out. Made the man in the image. Not for toil. Not slave-clay. The same mud, and a god who didn't fight a monster to build the world but *spoke* it, and a man not bred to dig but made to be like the one who made him. The newer draft is an argument *against* the older one, written in the older one's own words, by a conquered people sitting in the conqueror's city refusing the conqueror's story of what a human being is for.

Narin knew this. It was the most beautiful thing she knew. And she could not say it on a roof to six foreigners with a camera, because to say it she would have to lay the genealogy on the table first, naked, the sources, the dates, the older clay — and trust that none of them would pick it up and run to the market and sell it as *the Bible is a Babylonian knockoff* before she got to the part where it stops being a theft and starts being the bravest re-authoring a people ever performed under occupation. She would have to hand them the explosive to get to the song. And the West had already shown her, once, in 2003, in sacks, what it did with the explosives.

Mira knew all of it because Narin's face said all of it in the second the seam gave, and faces don't lie, not at that depth, not for that fraction of time.

Mira didn't say any of it.

That was the whole gift, and she knew it, and she gave it. She had read the thing the mouth wouldn't say, and the reading was complete, and the completion did not require speech. A book about everything

that ever got written down — the clay, the sealed envelopes, the four scholars who proved the language was real, the grandmother's loops in the margin, the joke that crossed three thousand years — a whole book of the written, and it was finished here, on a roof, by the one who read what stayed unsaid, and who understood that the kindest thing she could do with what she'd read was to keep it unsaid too.

She just held Narin's gaze. And nodded. Once. *I have it. It's safe. You don't have to.*

Narin's hand turned over under Mira's two fingers, slowly, until it was palm up, and her fingers closed around Mira's, brief and hard, a grip and a release, the most articulate sentence spoken on that roof and the only one with no language in it at all.

Then Narin's voice came back — Mira saw it return, saw the teacher reassemble — but it came back changed, lower, and she did not pick the folder up. She left it open on the table, the grandmother's loops face-up in the gold light, and she said something short to all of them, and Bashir's hands made it:

Tomorrow. The whole of it. Not today.

And Naila, who missed faces the way Mira missed sound, looked up from the pattern she'd been building and read, finally, from Mira's stillness rather than from any face, that the bridge had been built toward something that wasn't ready, and let it lie. She closed her own folder. She put her tea to her lips. The crowd-shudder of the bazaar came up through the roof, and Mira watched Naila's jaw, and reached over without a word and tapped the table twice in front of her — *exit, the stair, two steps* — and Naila's shoulder came down a centimetre, and that was a whole conversation too.

The uncle, who had read the entire wordless thing from his stove, came and refilled the glasses one more time, and set the pot down with finality, and said something to the roof in general that made Bashir laugh out loud and translate it as: *Drink, argue tomorrow, the dead have waited five thousand years, they will wait one more night.*

Down in the square, under the plane tree, the Beast's water bag had stopped weeping. The light was nearly gone off the citadel. Jakobus was at the front of the vehicle now, hood up, a torch in his teeth, and

Edith — who had not raised her camera once on the roof, who had kept her hand over the lens like a lid through the whole of it — leaned at the parapet and watched him work and did not photograph that either.

He shut the hood. Wiped his hands on a hanky that came out of his pocket impossibly clean and went back impossibly clean. Looked up at the roof, at the line of them along the parapet with their copper glasses, and lifted two fingers off the brim of nothing in a small salute, and said three words up the dark — Mira couldn't hear them, couldn't read his mouth at the angle, would never know them — and the uncle, beside her, raised his glass down into the square in answer.

Then Jakobus crouched by the rear wheel with the torch and unfolded a map across his knee, and traced a line on it with one finger, north and west, toward the edge of the gold country where the safe north thinned out into the disputed ground, and held the finger there, on a place, in the dark, and did not look up again.

Chapter 11 — The Beast on the Plain

The Beast did not have headlights so much as a strong opinion about the dark.

Edith learned this somewhere past the last village with a name she could pronounce, when Jakobus killed the mains at a wave from the old man on the motorbike ahead — a cousin of a cousin of Narin's uncle, she'd been told, which here meant the same as a passport — and the world went to moon and starlight and the small amber pilot of the dash, and the truck kept moving anyway, downhill into a basin of grass and stone, on a track Edith could not see and Jakobus apparently could.

She had her camera in her lap. She had not lifted it.

This was the discipline now. She felt it in her hands like a held breath: the want of the body to bring the eye up and frame the thing, the click that resolved the world into something she owned, and underneath it the new muscle she was building, slow and against grain, that let the want pass through her and out the other side without her hands moving.

Beside her, in the middle of the bench, Naila had her knees up and a folded printout against them and a penlight in her teeth, reading. She read in moving vehicles the way other people sat still in chairs. The light made a coin of orange on the paper and threw the shapes of cuneiform up onto the underside of her chin.

"Stop here," Narin said, from the back. Quiet. Not to Jakobus — past him. The cousin had stopped his bike at the lip of the basin and was

off it, holding something to his ear, a phone with no signal that he was using as a watch. “We walk the last part.”

“How far,” Yusuf said. He had the look he got near money. Not greed. The opposite of greed — the face of a man reading a room for the exits, who had once been very good at being the danger and was now only good at smelling it.

“Eight hundred metres. Maybe less.” Narin opened the door before the Beast had fully stopped. “The site is over the rise. They work it at night because there are no inspectors at night. There are no inspectors at night because the inspectors are in Baghdad arguing about whose budget pays for the road, and the road washed out in March.”

“And we’re here,” Bashir said, “because—”

“Because I want to see it with my own eyes before I file a thing nobody reads.” She was out, on the grass, a dark shape against darker land. “And because Hozan says they brought a lorry tonight. Lorry means they are loading. Loading means it is leaving. Once it leaves, it is gone. There is no after. There is only the photograph of the hole where it was.”

Edith heard that and felt it land on her like a hand.

She got out.

The grass was waist-high and dry and full of the small constant noise of insects, and it smelled of dust and something green underneath, crushed where they walked. Jakobus came last from the Beast, and Edith watched him do the thing he did — the thing she had stopped trying to photograph because it never came out, because there was never enough of him in the frame to say it was him. He took a tin from his breast pocket. Cayenne, she knew now; he’d dusted the truck’s air intake with it at the last fuel stop, against something, she hadn’t followed the logic and hadn’t asked. He pressed the lid back down. He set off behind them, not leading, a half-shape that the starlight refused to commit to, his shape forever about to become a bush or a fence-post or nothing at all.

The cousin Hozan led. Then Narin. Then the rest of them strung out

in the grass like a bad idea.

“Down,” Hozan said — Bashir relayed it, low — and they went down into the grass, and over the rise the night had a colour to it, a sick electric orange, and a sound: a generator’s flat industrial drone, and under it the chunk and scrape of metal in earth.

Edith came up over the lip on her elbows beside Naila and looked.

It was not a dig.

She had photographed digs. She knew what a dig looked like: the string grids, the trowels, the little flags, the unbearable patience of a person on their knees with a brush, the whole grammar of *we will be here for years and we will write down everything*. This had the grammar of a quarry. Floodlights on poles run off the generator, throwing everything into hard orange and black. Three trenches torn straight down through stratigraphy that someone had spent five thousand years laying — she could see it in the lit walls of the cuts, the bands, the dark line of an old floor, the paler line of an old flood, all of it sheared through like a cake by people who only wanted the cherry. Men in the trenches. Men on the spoil heaps with sieves. A lorry, canvas-sided, backed up to the largest cut.

And the sacks.

That was the part. That was the part she would carry. Not the violence of it — she had a high tolerance now for the violence of it, that was the wound, that was the thing the doctor in London had a word for. It was the sacks. Rice sacks, the woven plastic kind, white going grey, the kind you saw stacked outside every shop in the bazaar with flour and bulgur and dried limes in them, and men were carrying them two-handed up out of the trench and swinging them up into the lorry, and the sacks were full of the cradle of writing.

“They’re packing tablets in grain sacks,” Naila said. Flat. The penlight was off. “Like potatoes.”

“Don’t,” Bashir said, very gently, automatically, because the word had landed wrong in the dark, and then he heard himself and almost laughed and didn’t.

Naila didn’t laugh. She had gone still in the particular way Edith had learned to read — not the still of calm, the still of a system loading too

fast. Her hands were flat on the dirt. The orange light, the generator's drone that never resolved into rhythm, the figures moving without pattern, the smell of diesel: Edith watched the whole night arrive on her at once and saw her decide, by some private arithmetic, to stay.

"Count them," Edith said, low, into the side of Naila's head. Giving her a fence to hold. "The sacks. I can't from here."

A breath. Then: "Nineteen in the lorry. Four at the lip. Two men filling. They've been at it—" the smallest pause, the eyes flicking, doing the thing she did that was not magic, that was just counting faster than the rest of them could "—the spoil heap is wrong for one night. They've been here a week. Minimum. Look at the lorry's tracks, there's a rut, they've parked it there before, the rut has dried."

"A week," Yusuf said, and the word had a whole career in it. He'd come up on Edith's other side. "A week, this close to the line, undisturbed. Somebody's paying for that. The quiet isn't free out here. Somebody bought the quiet."

"Who," said Bashir.

"That's the wrong question." Yusuf's voice had gone very even. "*Who* you can't find. *How* leaves a trail. How does a sack of school-texts about beer rations turn into money? It can't, that's the thing, nobody loots Sumer for the beer rations." A breath. "So you make it about aliens."

Down in the orange light a man straightened from the trench holding something up to the floodlight, turning it, and even at this distance Edith could see it was a cone — a clay cone, a foundation deposit, a thing a king had buried in a wall four thousand years ago so the gods would know who built it — and the man wasn't looking at the writing on it. He was looking at the shape. Whether it would *photograph*.

"There it is," Naila said. "That's the markup."

"What is?" said Edith.

"He's not selling a text. He doesn't read it, he can't read it, the buyer can't read it. He's selling a *story*." Her voice had found its rail and was running on it now, fast and certain and almost happy, the way she went when the pattern came clear, the cost forgotten in the click of it. "A clay cone in a museum case with a card that says *Founda-*

tion deposit of Ur-Nammu, c. 2100 BCE, recording the building of a temple is worth — what, Yusuf?”

“On a clean market with provenance, a few thousand. Without provenance, on the grey, nothing, because no auction house will touch it.”

“Right. But the *same cone*—” and she had it now, the whole shape of it, and Edith felt the grief of the thing pour out of her sideways as delight, because that was how Naila grieved, by understanding “—the same cone, in a streaming documentary, lit blue, with a synth chord, and a man in a leather jacket saying *but mainstream archaeologists CAN’T EXPLAIN how a Bronze Age culture* — what’s underneath, the lighting, do it — *and what if this symbol here is in fact a star map* — that cone is worth a fortune. Because now it’s not a building record. Now it’s a clue. Now it’s *contraband from the gods*. And the beautiful part—”

“The ugly part,” Edith said.

“The ugly part,” Naila agreed, “is that the story makes it *more* sellable and *less* likely to be read by anyone who’d notice it just says a man’s name and that he built a wall. The lie is the lock. You can’t read a thing that everyone’s been told is unreadable.”

Frik had been silent the whole walk, which Edith had learned to clock the way you clock a held breath. He was on his stomach, fists working in the grass, jaw tight with the effort of holding, and Edith watched him lose it the way it always went — not a choice, a sneeze, the body overriding the man.

“*Beer rations*,” he said. Too loud. Then his own hand to his own mouth, eyes shutting, the small flinch of a man who’d spent forty years apologising for his own throat. And then, lower, helpless, the truth coming out the way it came out of him, sideways and exact: “Some scribe — Dubsiga’s cousin — counting out the *beer*. For the wall crew.” A breath. “And these *cunts* are selling him as a spaceman.”

It rang in the grass. The generator ate it. Nobody flinched but Frik, who flinched at himself.

“Yeah,” Yusuf said, simply, and put a hand flat on Frik’s back, between the shoulder blades, and left it there. “Yeah. That’s it. That’s exactly it.”

And Frik went still under the hand, and the night held.

Narin had not said anything for a while.

Edith found her a little apart, lower on the slope, on her knees in the grass with her hands open on her thighs, watching, and the watching was a different kind than the rest of theirs. The crew watched the way you watch a thing you've come to understand. Narin watched the way you watch a house burn that you grew up in.

Edith went to her on her knees, slow, telegraphing it, the way you approached a person who'd asked you to ask first. She did not bring the camera up. She left it on its strap, dead weight against her sternum, and she felt the want of it like a tooth.

"They're not even good trenches," Narin said. She didn't look round. "Look. There. The wall — see the line, the pale line, mud-brick — they've cut straight through a wall to get to the floor below, because the floor below is older and older sells. They've destroyed the building to get the bricks out of the way of the floor. The building was the context. Without the building, the floor is just—" her hand turned over, empty "—objects. Loose objects. A man finds a tablet in a floor and you can read the room. You know it was an archive, you know what was kept here, you know who they were. A man finds the same tablet in a sack and you know nothing. You have a *thing*. They are making things out of a city."

"I know," Edith said. Then, because it was true and she had decided to stop hiding behind being a professional: "I was here in 2003."

Narin turned her head at that. Just her head.

"Not *here* here. Baghdad. The museum." Edith kept her eyes on the orange trenches. "I photographed the looting. Day three. They were carrying things out in — the same. Sacks. Cushions. A man with the Warka mask wrapped in a — I never found out if it was a curtain or a flag. I photographed all of it. It ran on the front of three papers. It won a prize." She made herself say the next part. "I have never once stopped that man. In any of the pictures. I have a lot of pictures of him leaving and not one of him not leaving, and the pictures are very good, and I have thought, for twenty years, that taking them well was a kind of — that the beauty was a kind of—"

“Absolution,” Narin said.

“Yeah.”

Narin looked back at the trenches.

“It’s why I didn’t want your lens near my grandmother’s hand,” she said. “You understand. Your prize. Their grief, your prize. The most honest thing the West did with my country was photograph it leaving.”

There was nothing to say to that that wouldn’t be a defence, so Edith said nothing, which was the new muscle, and it hurt, and she let it.

Below them, the floodlights threw two long shadows up the slope, because a man with a clipboard — a *clipboard*, out here, the banality of it — had walked into the light, and he was not a labourer. Clean shirt. He held up a tablet, an actual tablet, oblong, dark, and turned it under the floodlight, and he had a phone up, and he was photographing it where it was, on site, the trench wall behind it, for someone, somewhere, who wanted to see it *in the ground* before they paid, because *in the ground* was the story, *in the ground* was the markup, *just discovered, never before seen, what the experts don’t want you to know*.

Edith’s hands came up.

She did not decide it. The camera was up, the eye was to it, the floodlight had given her everything — the trench, the clean shirt, the dark tablet held to the light like an offering, the lorry’s canvas catching orange behind, the *whole sentence* of it composed in the frame the way it only ever composed itself maybe twice in a career, the picture that explains the thing, the picture that runs everywhere, the picture with her name under it.

She had the focus. She had the man’s face turning a half-degree more into the light. She had the tablet’s cuneiform catching as a row of small hard shadows. Three stops down, the floodlight wouldn’t blow. One frame. Quiet shutter. Nobody would hear it over the generator.

The picture that makes my name, she thought, with the cold clarity of the body that has done this a thousand times, *and the dig coordinates are in it. The wall behind him is in it. Hozan walks these hills. Narin’s uncle pours tea three valleys from here. This frame names this place,*

and the network has a media arm, and a media arm reads the news, and the news would run this, and they would read where it ran, and they would come for the people who could only have stood here.

The frame was perfect. She held it.

She felt Narin not moving beside her. Not reaching for the camera. Not telling her. Trusting her, or testing her, the two being the same thing here.

She lowered the camera.

She let the man's face turn the rest of the way into the light unphotographed. She let the perfect frame dissolve back into ordinary dark. Her hands were shaking, which she noted and did not stop. She put the lens cap on. The small click of it was the loudest thing she had done all night.

"I'll get the lorry," she said, low, "when it's on the road. No site. No faces. Plate, if there is one. Make of truck. Direction. That's the trail, that's what Yusuf can run. The picture that catches *them* and not you."

Narin looked at her for a long moment in the dark.

"Yes," she said. "That one."

It was not absolution. Edith knew it was not. But it was the first frame she had ever *not* taken because of what the taking would cost someone else, and the not-taking sat in her chest like a coal, hot and clean, and she understood — no, she did not understand, that was the crutch, she would not do that — she *felt*, in the meat of her, that the wound and the cure were the same shape. Beauty as absolution had killed something in her. Maybe witness without consuming would grow it back.

The generator changed pitch.

Everyone on the slope felt it before they understood it — Naila's hand was on Edith's wrist, hard, before Edith had registered the change — and then the floodlights died, all of them, and the basin went to moon and the lorry's reverse-lights, red, and there was shouting, fast Arabic, fast Kurdish, a man's voice over it that had authority and no patience.

"They're spooked," Yusuf breathed. "Something spooked them. They're cutting it short. Leaving."

"Did they see us?" Bashir.

"No." Naila, certain. "They saw their own perimeter. Somebody's man up on the far rise stopped checking in. Their pattern broke. They don't know why their pattern broke, they only know it broke, so they run."

And up on the far rise, where the network's perimeter had stopped checking in, there was — Edith brought her old long lens up, the night-glass, slow, no shutter, only to see — there was a shape on the skyline that the starlight would not commit to. A shape that was about to become a fence-post, or a juniper, or nothing. It moved along the ridge against the grain of the wind, unhurried, and where it passed, a man with a phone to his ear lowered the phone and looked at it and looked at it and could not, by his whole posture, by the cant of his shoulders that Mira three feet away was already reading and would tell them later, *resolve* it into a man. The network had cameras on that ridge. Edith would learn that, after, from Yusuf, who would learn it from the trail. The network had three trail-cameras on that ridge and a man with a phone, and not one of them, that night, got a clean frame of whatever walked their line and made their watcher come down off the ridge to start his own engine.

She did not photograph it either. She would not have got it. Nobody ever got it.

"They left a man," Mira signed, fast, her hands catching the moonlight, and Bashir voiced it under his breath for Narin, *they left a man, the one with the phone, look how he keeps looking back, he didn't see a person, he saw a —* and Mira's hands stopped, and started, finding it — *a wrong. He saw a wrong and he can't say what.*

The lorry's engine caught. The canvas sides shuddered. Nineteen sacks plus four, Naila had said, twenty-three sacks of the first writing on earth, of grain-counts and god-lists and a scribe's complaint about his fee and somewhere in there, statistically, a school-text where a boy had copied out the flood, the older one, the one with the different mountain and the different birds, the one that was a thousand years old before anyone in Judah was carried off to Babylon to hear it — twenty-three sacks of it grinding away north and west across the dark

plain toward the seam in the country where the safe north thinned out and a sack of cradle became, on the far side, *contraband from the gods*.

Edith got the lorry on the road, on the rise, against the last grey of the west. No site. No faces. The plate was muddled over, which told its own story. The make of the truck. Two reflective triangles on the tailgate, one cracked. The direction. The trail, handed to Yusuf, who took the camera screen and looked at it and said, quietly, “Okay. Okay. That I can follow. That I know how to follow,” and there was, under the professional flatness, the smallest live thing — a man who had once moved crates like this for the wrong side, who had needed, more than any of them, for the lights in the sky to be true so that his old work might have been about something bigger than money, and who was here instead, in the grass, on his stomach, finding that the real work — *follow the cracked triangle, follow the muddled plate, follow the road that washed out in March* — was the bigger door after all.

They walked back to the Beast in the new dark, the generator silent behind them, the basin returned to its insects and its five thousand years of patience.

Naila walked beside Edith and was quiet, which after a thing like that was its own weather, the system unloading, and Edith did not fill the quiet. Then, near the truck, Naila said, to no one, to the grass:

“It’s not even the worst of it. The selling. That’s just money, money’s stupid, money I almost understand.” She stopped. Her hands found each other. “The worst of it is — they took those people’s name off their own work. A man wrote *I, Ur-Nammu, built this wall*, he carved his *name* into it so the gods would know him in five thousand years, and the gods waited, and we dug him up, and instead of saying his name we said — *aliens did it*. We looked at the most patient act of authorship in human history and we gave the credit to the sky.”

Nobody answered her. The Beast’s water bag, hung again under the wheel-arch, had begun, very faintly, to weep.

Jakobus was already at the front of it, hood up, doing the thing with the torch in his teeth, separate, a half-shape, the man no camera

could hold. Narin went to him — to the truck, to the open hood, the only one of them who could — and stood a moment, and said something low, three valleys from her uncle's awning, in the old tongue, the courtesy handful, and he answered with the same handful, and shut the hood, and wiped his hands on a hanky that came out clean and went back clean, and they got in.

"North and west," Yusuf said, from the back, watching the cracked triangle on his little screen go dark as the lorry crested out of range. "Toward the line."

"Toward the line," Narin said. And then, after a while, with her grandmother's notebook somewhere in her bag and her whole burning country in the back of her throat, quiet enough that only Mira, watching her mouth in the dash-light, was sure of every word: "We have to stop thinking of it as *stealing*. That's not what it is. That's not big enough for what it is."

Bashir half-turned. "Then what is it?"

Narin looked out at the dark plain going by, the grass, the old floors under the grass, the names carved into walls so the gods would remember.

She didn't answer yet.

The Beast carried them on into the night, headlights off, toward the seam.

Chapter 12 — The Seam

The safehouse was a half-finished concrete shell on the edge of a town Yusuf had stopped trying to name, two floors up a stairwell with no rail, and the room they'd taken had a window with no glass and a view of a sodium light and, under the sodium light, a goat. Yusuf had been watching the goat for an hour. The goat had been watching him back. Of the two of them, the goat seemed more at peace.

Below, the Beast sat in the dark with its hood down and its water bag rehung, drinking nothing, weeping nothing, finally. Jakobus was somewhere out by it, a shape that resolved into a man only when the sodium light caught the rim of his glasses and then unresolved again, the way he did, going quiet and grey at the edge of any frame. Edith had her camera in her lap with the cap on. She'd had the cap on for two days. Yusuf had clocked it without saying anything. They all had.

Naila sat on the floor with her back to the good wall — she always found the good wall, the one with two exits in her sightline — and she had Narin's grandmother's notebook open beside her own, not touching it, just open, two pages of two different hands. She'd been doing the thing she did, the soft thing under her breath, numbers, the base-sixty going round and round. *Sixty, six hundred, three thousand six hundred.* The sar. She'd killed the sar a week and a country ago — *it's a numeral, it's a big round Mesopotamian ten, it's not an orbit* — but she still ran it sometimes, the way you press a bruise.

"I keep coming back to the gold," Yusuf said. To the room. To the goat.

Nobody answered for a moment. Bashir was lying flat on the bare floor with his eyes closed, which was how he listened. Mira sat by the window where the light was, because the light was how she heard,

and she was watching Yusuf's mouth.

"The gold," Yusuf said again, slower, for Mira, turning so she had his face. "Sitchin's whole thing. The Anunnaki come down, they need gold — for their atmosphere, for their dying planet, whatever — and they're too grand to mine it themselves, so they make us. Workers. Out of an ape, with a bit of their own genes spliced in. Made-to-dig." He laughed, once, with no air behind it. "That's the version I bought. That's the version that got me through about four years of nightshifts at a freight desk."

"It's a good story," Bashir said, eyes still shut.

"It's a *great* story." Yusuf heard his own voice go up and brought it down. "It's got everything. We're special. We're engineered. We matter so much the gods crossed the dark to build us. You ever notice that? The whole thing's a love letter to *us*. We're not nothing. We're a *project*."

Naila stopped the number under her breath. She looked up.

"That's the cheat," she said.

Yusuf waited. With Naila you waited; the thing came when it was built.

"That's the whole cheat in one sentence." She had the two notebooks open and she put a finger on neither of them, hovering, the way she held a pattern before she'd say it. "Sitchin's story makes us *want it*. It flatters. Designed. Wanted. Important enough to build a star-bridge for." She tipped her head at the dark, at the plain out there under the goat-light, the old floors under the new grass. "But that's not what the clay says. I read it again on the truck. Atrahasis. Tablet one." She found it in her own book and turned it to him though he couldn't read a word of it, because that wasn't the point; the point was she was holding the real thing. "The little gods — the Igigi — they're the ones digging. Forty years they dig the Tigris and the Euphrates out by hand, by *order*, and they crack. They burn their tools. They march on the big house at night with torches. A *strike*." She almost smiled. "Forty centuries before anyone had a word for it. And so the great gods — to break the strike — kill one of their own, a god named We-ila, and they mix his blood and his *spirit* into clay, and the womb-goddess pinches off fourteen lumps, and that's us. That's what we're for." She closed the book. "Toil. We're a strike-breaker. We're made

of clay and a murdered god so the gods don't have to dig their own canals."

The room held still. The sodium light buzzed.

"That's worse," Yusuf said. It came out small.

"Yes," Naila said. Not unkindly. "It's much worse."

"I mean—" He scrubbed a hand down his face. "I mean it's *bleaker*. Nobody crossed the dark for us. We weren't a project. We were a *labour solution*. Clay and blood, get to work, you'll die, the gods will sleep better." He surprised himself with the shape of it in his mouth. "That's not a love letter. That's a—"

"A foreman's memo," Bashir said, from the floor, and opened one eye, and there was no cruelty in it.

"A foreman's memo," Yusuf agreed, and something in his chest did a thing he didn't have a clean name for, half a laugh and half the other.

Mira had been reading Yusuf's face the whole way down, and now she signed something to him — slow, because his sign was bad and she was patient — and when he didn't catch it she spelled the last word into the air with her hand, *G-R-I-E-V-I-N-G*, and pointed at him, eyebrows up. A question, not a verdict.

Yusuf looked at the goat.

"Yeah," he said. To Mira, to her face, so she had it. "Yeah. I think I am."

It would have been easier, Naila thought, watching him, if the real one were boring. That was the lie the genre lived on — that the choice was *aliens* or *nothing*, magic or homework, the wonder or the dust. As if when you took the spaceship away you were left holding a school-text about beer rations and a hangover. Bashir kept saying it on the truck, the loneliest true thing she knew: *every alien decode is a bad translation*. And the corollary, which was the whole reason she could stand any of this — that a *good* translation didn't leave you with less. It left you with a four-thousand-year-old labour dispute. It left you with a strike.

She did the arithmetic of it almost without meaning to, the way other people hummed. Atrahasis: older than Genesis by — she ran it — over a thousand years on the conservative copies, more on the oldest. Enuma Elish, the Babylon one, where the warrior-god Marduk splits the salt-sea goddess Tiamat like a fish for drying and builds the sky from one half and the ground from the other and then makes mankind from the blood of a *second* murdered god, the rebel Kingu — that one a little later, but the bones of it old, old, the bones of it everywhere. The clay-and-blood. The slain god. The toil. It wasn't one text. It was a *tradition*. You could lay the copies out across centuries and watch the same skeleton get re-dressed for each new empire, and the skeleton was always the same:

The gods were tired. So they made us to be tired in their place.

That was the thing the West had taken. Not a tablet. Not even a story, exactly. The *authorship*.

"It's not stealing," she said, out loud, picking up the thread Narin had dropped in the truck two nights ago and left hanging in the dark. "Yusuf, you said it. Narin said it. *Stealing's not big enough.*"

"Then what is it." Bashir sat up. He'd been waiting on this; she could see he had the same itch she did, the one where a word was *almost* there and your whole skin wanted it.

Naila put her two notebooks side by side, the dead language and her grandmother's-equivalent, her own hand.

"There's a man," she said. "Swiss. Von Däniken. He's the one who really lit the fuse, before Sitchin, the sixties — *Chariots of the Gods*. And his actual argument, when you strip the airport bookshop off it, is one sentence. He looks at the Nazca lines, the pyramids, the Sumerian king lists, the canals — all of it, every wonder built by brown and Black and ancient hands — and he says: *they couldn't have done this.*"

The room had gone very quiet now, a different quiet.

"That's it," Naila said. "That's the engine. *These people were too primitive*. The lines are too straight, the stones too big, the maths too good — for *them*. So someone came down and did it. Someone from outside. Someone—" she didn't say it, let it sit, "—from *up*."

“Whiter,” Bashir said softly. Stateless, switched-tongues-at-the-border Bashir, who had crossed more lines than the rest of them put together. “Up is whiter. Up is always whiter.”

“It’s the oldest move there is,” Naila said. “It’s the colonial move with the serial numbers filed off. You arrive, you see the city, the city is too good, so you decide the people in it didn’t build it — a lost race did, a vanished superior, the *real* architects, who happen to look more like the man holding the notebook. And then the people who actually quarried the stone and cut the canals and *invented writing* —” her voice didn’t rise; it went flatter, which was worse, which was the thing she did when it was real, “— they become the squatters. The tenants. The ones who found the keys to a house they could never have made.”

She looked at the window, at the plain.

“That’s what was done here. Sumer invents the *written word*. The first poem. The first law. The first joke we can still read. And we looked at it and decided they were too primitive to have done it, so we gave it to the sky.” She closed both books. “It’s not theft. Theft’s a thing you can give back. This took the *making* away from the makers. It un-authored a civilisation.”

Frik had been quiet in the corner the whole time — Frik went quiet when it mattered, that was the secret nobody knew about Frik, that the blurts came when it *didn’t* — and now his head jerked once and his shoulder rose and he said, fast, helpless, in the voice that wasn’t choosing it:

“They wrote it *down*.”

It hung there.

“They wrote it down,” Frik said again, slower, and this time it was him, riding the back of the tic, claiming it. “That’s the — that’s the thing nobody — you can’t *un-write* it. It’s in the clay. It’s their *hand* in the clay. You can lie about it but you can’t—” his neck pulled, his eyes squeezed, “—you can’t get their *hand* off it.”

“No,” Naila said. “You can’t.”

And Mira, watching all their faces from the window, in the light, saw Yusuf’s do the thing again, the half-and-half, and she signed nothing

this time, just held his eye and put her flat hand to her own chest and pressed it there. *I see it.* Yusuf nodded. The goat, outside, ate something off the ground and did not care.

Narin came up the stairwell with no rail like she'd been born to it, ducked the lintel, and stood in the doorway with two glasses of tea she'd got from God-knew-where in a half-built town at midnight, the way she always could, the local always could, and she handed one to Naila and one — after a beat that was a decision — to Edith, whose camera-cap had been on for two days.

Edith took the tea like it weighed something.

Narin had heard the last of it from the stairs; you could tell. She didn't perform having heard it. She just leaned in the doorway and let the steam off her glass go up into the sodium light.

"You're close," she said. To all of them, in English, her London English with the Nineveh under it. "You read the pattern. The same flood, the same clay, the same council of gods, the same strike. You read it across the cultures and you saw the skeleton and you named what the aliens did to it." She drank. "That's good. That's real work. Most people who come to my office with the word *Anunnaki* in their mouth can't do half of it."

"But," Bashir said. Quietly. The way you say *but* to someone who's earned it.

"But you're reading it like a crime," Narin said. "Sitchin took it. Von Däniken un-authored it. The looters down there pack it into grain sacks. The doc people up in their offices sell it back to the world with a spaceship glued on. All theft. All loss. The clay goes out the door and the hand goes off it." She set her glass on the windowsill, careful, near Mira so Mira had her mouth. "And that's all true. I've spent twenty years being angry about exactly that. I watched my own museum go out the door in sacks in 2003." She didn't look at Edith when she said it; she very precisely didn't, which was its own kind of looking. "So believe me, I know the inventory of what's been lost."

She picked the glass back up.

"But you've stopped one country too early."

Naila's head came up.

"You all keep saying it went *out*," Narin said. "Out the door. Into the market. Into the lie. And it did. But that's not the only direction this story ever travelled." She turned the glass in her hand. "You're sitting in the room thinking about where the tablets go. I'm asking where the *story* went. Not the looted object. The thing Frik says you can't get the hand off. The flood. The clay. The murdered god. The seven days of toil before the gods rest." A small pause on that last; Naila clocked it, didn't know yet why. "Where did *that* go, after Babylon?"

"It—" Yusuf started, and stopped, because he didn't actually know, and the not-knowing was a clean, cold, exciting thing in him, the first clean thing in days.

"You know what happened to Babylon," Narin said. "Six hundred years before anyone's Christ. The empire comes — and it takes a people, a small people, a people with a god and a temple and not much else, and it marches them off into exile. Out of their hills. Into the great brick city. Into the libraries. Into the *liturgy*. Into the place where every educated man and woman knew Enuma Elish the way you all know — what, song lyrics. By heart. Recited at the new year. *Marduk splits the sea-goddess, builds the sky from her ribs, makes the slaves from a dead god's blood.*" She let it sit. "And the exiles sat in that city for two generations. Hearing it. Knowing it. *Made of clay to bear the gods' toil.*"

The sodium light buzzed. The goat had lain down.

"And then," Narin said, "some of them wrote something."

Naila felt it land before she had the words — felt the pattern *click*, the way it did, two pages of two hands sliding into register. She put her finger down at last, on the dead language and on her grandmother's hand, both, at once.

"Oh," she said. Just that.

"You said it un-authored a civilisation," Narin said to her, gentle, the local out-reading them all and choosing to do it kindly. "I want to show you a civilisation that got *re-authored*. By the people the empire tried to delete. With the empire's own furniture." She finished her tea. "There's a flood story you all know. Older than you think — *no*. Not older. The *Mesopotamian* one is older, by a thousand years and more,

that part you've got right, don't let anyone tell you the other way round. But there's a *second* flood, written down by a conquered people with the first one ringing in their ears, and it is *not the same*, and the places it's not the same are the whole point." A flicker of the scholar's fierce joy, the thing the West had alienated out of her ancestors and she was about to hand back. "Different mountain. Different birds. Different boat. Different god — and the *difference of the god* is the argument. They're not copying. They're *answering*."

"Genesis," Bashir said. The word came out of him soft and enormous.

"Genesis," Narin said. And then, before anyone could fill the room with the wrong thing, before Yusuf's face could fall the wrong way or Edith's hand could go to a camera that would steal it, she put up one finger and held them there. "And I want to be very careful with you now, because the cheap version of where I'm taking you is just as much a theft as Sitchin's. The man who says *aha, the Bible's plagiarism, it's all just stolen myth* — he's doing the exact same move von Däniken did. He's un-authoring it. He's getting the hand off the clay." She looked, for a second, almost tired. "Both of those men think they're the clever one in the room. They're the same man."

"Then what is it," Naila said. The question of the whole book, in three words, in her flat clear voice.

Narin smiled, and it was the smile of someone who had waited a long time for the right people to ask.

"That," she said, "is the question." She stood off the doorframe. "It's not a copy and it's not a coincidence. It's a *conversation*. A conquered people sat in the heart of the empire that ate them, and they took the empire's biggest, oldest, most sacred story — *the gods made you out of mud to be their slaves* — and they wrote it back, line for line, furniture and all, and they changed the verb. Not *made to toil*. Made in the—" she stopped herself, deliberate, a teacher refusing to give the answer the night before the lesson. "No. You'll read it. In the morning. In the light. I'm not handing it to you in a concrete box at midnight like it's contraband. It deserves better than the way the *other* tablets travel."

She looked at the window, at the dark plain, the old floors under the new grass, the same long look she'd given the night the Beast carried them out.

“You wanted to know what was bigger than *stealing*,” she said. “Here it is. Somebody downstairs is packing the flood into a grain sack to sell with a spaceship glued on. And three thousand years ago, somebody who’d lost everything took the same flood and used it to keep their soul. Same story. Two directions.” She turned for the stairwell. “One of those is the saddest thing I know. The other one is why I do this.”

At the lintel she paused.

“Mira,” she said, and faced her full-on, mouth clear in the light, and made the sign — clumsy, learned-for-this, the way they all signed for each other, badly and on purpose — for *thank you*. Because Mira had been watching her face the whole time, reading the thing under the lecture, the grief and the joy braided so tight you couldn’t pull one out without the other, and Narin had felt herself being read, and had let it happen.

Mira signed it back. Cleaner. *Thank you*.

Then Narin ducked the lintel and went down the stairwell with no rail, and her footsteps faded, and outside, far down, you could just hear — for a moment, no longer — three notes of something hummed low and steady by a grey shape near the Beast, a metronome for a man no light could hold, and then that faded too.

Yusuf sat with the goat-light on him and the cold tea in his hands and the foreman’s memo in his chest, and waited for the grief to be the only thing in there.

It wasn’t.

That was the part he hadn’t seen coming, on all those nightshifts, with the spaceship and the splice and the *we’re a project*. He’d thought the rabbit-hole was the door out of an ordinary life, and he’d thought that letting go of the aliens meant the door swung shut and you were back at the freight desk with nothing but dust. He’d grieved it on the truck. He was grieving it now, for real, the way Mira had named.

But there was a draught coming under the other door. He could feel it. *Same story, two directions*. A conquered people who’d taken the empire’s own myth and turned it into a way to survive the empire. He

didn't have it yet — Narin had pulled her hand back, *in the morning, in the light*, and she was right to, he'd have grabbed at it and broken it — but he could feel the size of the room on the far side. It was bigger than the spaceship. The spaceship had only ever flattered him. This thing didn't flatter anybody. It had been written by people in chains and it was *braver* than anything he'd believed for four years on the nightshift.

Naila had her two notebooks closed in her lap, and her eyes shut, and she was running it under her breath again, but it wasn't the sar this time. It was something new, a count he couldn't follow, the rhythm of a thing that hadn't been read yet and was about to be.

"Bashir," she said, eyes still shut.

"Mm."

"The flood story. The Genesis one. You've read it in—"

"All of them," Bashir said, simply. The polyglot's loneliness and the polyglot's gift, one sentence. "Hebrew. Greek. Syriac. Aramaic. The Sumerian's the only place I have to crawl."

"Tomorrow," Naila said. "In the light. The two of them. Side by side. The mountain and the birds and the boat. Where they're the same and where they—"

"Answer," Bashir said.

"Answer," she agreed.

Frik, in the corner, jerked once and said, very quietly, to no one, riding the tic and then choosing the last of it himself the way he'd learned to in this room and nowhere else on earth:

"Same flood."

Nobody corrected him, because he wasn't wrong, and nobody finished it for him, because he didn't need them to.

Outside, the sodium light buzzed, and the goat slept, and the plain stretched off to a horizon they couldn't see, full of old floors and old names cut into walls so the gods would remember — and three thousand years of a story that had gone two directions out of this same mud, one toward a grain sack, one toward the morning.

In the morning, in the light, they would read the other flood.

Chapter 13 — The Same Flood

The light came up grey and then gold, and Bashir was awake before any of them, which was usual, because the first hour of a day in a new place was the hour nobody talked, and the hour nobody talked was the only hour he ever truly rested. He sat on the cool of the unfinished step with a tin mug of tea that Yusuf had made too sweet, and he watched the plain take its colour back from the dark, and he ran the two stories through his head the way you'd run two threads through your fingers to feel where they were spun the same and where they parted.

He had told Naila the truth last night. He had read the flood in all of them. Hebrew with the *vav* doing its quiet work, the *and-and-and* that made the prose move like water itself. Greek with the Septuagint's careful sandals on. Syriac, his grandmother's church-tongue, the one that still wept the old words out on Good Friday. He could read the flood in his sleep. The Sumerian was the only place he had to crawl, and crawling was where the love was.

Inside, the others were beginning. He heard Mira's bare feet, which made no sound he could name but which moved the air, and then her hand on his shoulder, light, a question. He turned so she could see his mouth.

"Tea's poison," he said. "Yusuf made it."

She read his lips and her face did the thing it did, the small flat amusement that lived mostly in the eyes, and she signed something fast and sloppy that he didn't catch, and he gave her the open palm, *again*, *slower*, and she did it again, and it was *coward*, and she took the

mug out of his hand and drank the poison herself, watching him over the rim, daring him.

Narin came out last. She had a thermos of her own — she'd brought it from London, real tea, leaves, the kind you let breathe — and a laptop under one arm and, under the other, a thing wrapped in a tea-towel that turned out to be a stack of printouts, the British Museum's own photographs, the tablets shot from above under raking light so every wedge stood up in its own little shadow.

She did not say good morning. She set the printouts down on the upturned crate they'd been using as a table and looked at the seven of them — six and herself — gathering in the cool concrete shade with their mugs, and Bashir watched her decide, again, whether to do this. She decided it fresh every morning. He respected that. A door you open carelessly is a door you've stopped guarding.

"I'm going to say something first," Narin said, "and then we read."

They waited.

"There is a stupid version of what we're about to do," she said. "The stupid version is a man on the internet with a graphic. Left side, Genesis. Right side, Gilgamesh. Big arrow. *PLAGIARISM*. Caption: *they don't want you to know*." She let that sit. "I've spent twenty years cleaning that man's fingerprints off my field. He is, in his way, the same animal as the alien man. He needs the two texts to be *identical*, because identical is loud, and loud is what gets clicks. And identical is a lie." She tapped the printout. "They are not identical. They are *related*. Those are completely different sentences and the difference is the whole entire point. If anybody in this room says *the Bible just copied it* I will pack the truck myself. Are we clear."

"Clear," said Yusuf, quietly, and Bashir saw that it cost Yusuf to say it, because Yusuf had been, for four years, exactly the man who needed it loud, and was learning, slowly, painfully, in front of all of them, to need it true instead.

"Good." Narin pulled the first sheet to the top. "George Smith. 1872. Tell them, Bashir, you'll do it better than me."

He hadn't expected the handoff. She did that — gave you the thing you were best at and then watched to see if you'd take it greedily or hold it open. He held it open.

“George Smith was a banknote engraver,” Bashir said. “Working class. London. No university. He used to spend his lunch breaks at the British Museum looking at the tablets behind the glass, the ones nobody could read yet, and he taught himself cuneiform off them. Off the *glass*. The way you’d learn a language by reading the menu in a restaurant you can’t afford to eat in.” He felt his own grandmother in his mouth when he said it, the autodidact ache, the man who belonged everywhere they’d let him stand. “And one day in 1872 he’s working through a broken tablet from Nineveh, from Ashurbanipal’s library, and he’s reading along — and the line says a ship has come to rest on a mountain, and a man sends out a dove, and the dove finds no resting place and comes back.”

He stopped, because the next part deserved the stop.

“And Smith — the story goes — Smith stood up. In the reading room. And he started taking his clothes off.”

Frik made a sound, a short bark of a laugh that was half tic and half delight, and nobody minded it because it was exactly the right size for the thing.

“He was overcome,” Bashir said. “He’d found a flood. Older than the one in his Bible. With a dove in it. He ran around the room. They thought he’d lost his mind. He hadn’t. He’d just touched the oldest written wonder anybody had touched in a very long time, and the body does what the body does.” He looked at Frik when he said it, on purpose, gently, and Frik looked back, and something passed between them that did not need a word. *The body does what the body does*. “He gave a lecture about it that November. The Prime Minister came. Gladstone. To hear a banknote engraver read a poem older than Moses.”

“And then,” Narin said, picking it up, dry as the plain, “the newspaper that funded his dig back to Nineveh wanted a headline, so the find got sold as *proof of the Bible*. Which it wasn’t. And the man who actually read it spent his short life” — she didn’t soften this — “trying to say the more interesting thing over the noise of the simpler one. He died at thirty-six. Dysentery. On the way home from the field. The loud version outlived him by a hundred and fifty years.” She squared the printouts. “Now. The poem.”

She read it to them. Not from the laptop — from the printout, with her

finger moving under the wedges, translating live, and Bashir watched her do it and felt the specific envy of a man watching someone do, in a language he had to crawl in, the thing he could only fly in elsewhere. She read Utnapishtim telling Gilgamesh how the gods resolved to drown the world. How the god Ea, who could not break the oath of silence outright, whispered the warning *to a wall* — to a reed wall — so that the man on the other side of the wall would overhear it and could not later be said to have been *told*.

“That’s a lawyer’s god,” Yusuf said, and laughed, a real one, surprised out of him. “He found the loophole.”

“He found the loophole,” Narin agreed. “Tear down the house, the wall says. Build a boat. Abandon wealth, seek life. Take the seed of all living things aboard.” She moved her finger. “And the man builds it. Seven decks. A perfect cube, near enough — the dimensions are a riddle, very deliberate, the boat is *too* square to be a real boat, which is one of the ways you know you’re inside a poem and not a logbook.” She glanced up. “Hold that. The square boat. We’ll come back to it.”

Mira was watching Narin’s hands and Narin’s mouth both, and when Narin paused, Mira’s own hands moved — to Bashir, fast, *the boat shape*, two flat palms making a box, a question in her eyebrows.

“Different boat,” Bashir signed back, badly, and said it aloud for the room. “Mira wants the boats compared. They’re different. The ark in Genesis is a long boat, a ratio, three hundred by fifty by thirty cubits — that’s a *ship* shape, that floats. Utnapishtim’s is a cube. Atrahasis, the older one again, the one we read last night — his might be round. A coracle. There’s a tablet, found this century, that gives the recipe for a *round* ark, coiled rope and bitumen, like the boats they actually still made on these rivers into living memory.” He felt the wonder of it move up his arms. “Three floods. Three different boats. That’s not one blueprint photocopied three times. That’s three poets, a thousand years apart, telling the *same true frightening thing* — the water came, a man was warned, the seed survived — and each one building the boat his own way.”

“Which is exactly what I needed nobody to forget,” Narin said, and there was approval in it, brief, real, gone. “Keep going. The water comes.”

She read the water. The storm-gods harnessed. The dykes broken.

The land shattered like a pot. And then the part Bashir had been waiting for, because it was the part that did the work no graphic could do — the part where the gods themselves, the very gods who had sent the flood, cowered.

The gods were frightened by the deluge, Narin read, slowing. They drew back, they went up to the heaven of Anu. The gods crouched like dogs, crouched against the outer wall.

The room was quiet.

“They made the storm,” Yusuf said, “and then they were scared of it.”

“They’re not in control,” Narin said. “That’s the theology of it. The Mesopotamian gods are *inside* the weather, not above it. They’re hungry. They’re loud. They squabble and they regret and they cower. The goddess Belet-ili — the mother goddess, the one who made humankind — she cries out that she let it happen, she wails that her people have filled the sea like fish. The gods didn’t drown the world because the world was wicked. They drowned it because” — she checked the line, because she was Narin and she would not round it off — “in the older version, the real reason, the *human noise*. People multiplied and made too much noise and the head god couldn’t sleep.”

Frik, who had been still, said: “*Couldn’t sleep.*” Echolalia, riding it out, and then the choosing-the-end-of-it that he did only here: “That’s the *reason?*”

“That’s the reason,” Narin said, and she did not laugh at it and she did not let them laugh at it either, and Bashir saw why. Because the next thing she said put a floor under the whole morning.

“Now hold that god — the god who drowns the world to get some sleep, the gods who cower like dogs against the wall — and hold him there, and we’ll go to the other flood.” She set the Gilgamesh printout aside, gently, the way you’d set down something that had earned its keep, and she opened a worn paperback with a black cover, and Bashir saw it was a Bible, an old one, the Syriac-and-English she’d carried out of London under the printouts, and he understood that she was about to read her own scripture in a room of strangers and that this was the part she decided fresh every morning.

She read Genesis. The flood. And she read it as a *believer reads*

it, with the weight in the right places, and she read it as a scholar reads *it*, with her finger under the seams — and Bashir, who could read it in five tongues, sat very still, because watching someone do both of those at once, in one breath, without either one eating the other, was the rarest reading he knew, and he had been to a great many readings.

“Different reason,” she said, when she came to it. “Read it. The reason here is not noise. The reason here is *moral*. The earth was filled with violence. And it grieved God in his heart that he had made man.” She looked up. “Do you hear it? In the poem, the gods are annoyed. Here, God is *grieved*. The same flood — and they’ve put a soul in the engine. That is not a copy. That is an *argument*.”

She turned the page.

“And here,” she said. “Watch the boat get a number that the other boats don’t have. Genesis tells you to bring the animals in twos. And then — this is the part the loud man with the graphic always skips — it *also* says bring seven of some, the clean ones, seven pairs. Two different counts, side by side, in the same chapter.” She let that hang for the scholars in the room, which was all of them now. “There are two flood accounts here, stitched together. You can see the stitch. A reader from the south, a reader from the temple, woven into one. The tradition was already arguing with *itself* before it ever got written down. That’s not weakness in the text. That’s the text being *old* and *honest* about being old.”

“Two scribes,” Naila said. It was the first thing she’d said all morning. She’d been sitting against the cool wall with her knees up and her two notebooks shut on her lap and her eyes half-closed, doing the count under her breath, and now she opened her eyes. “Two scribes and you can see the join. Like a tablet copied by two hands and the second hand’s wedges sit deeper.” She wasn’t asking. She was placing it, snapping it into the lattice where it went, the pattern under the pattern. “It’s the same as the math. The seam shows. The seam’s the most honest part.”

“The seam’s the most honest part,” Narin repeated, and looked at Naila a beat longer than she’d looked at any of them, the look of one careful reader recognising another across a table, and then she moved on before it could become a thing, because she was kind.

“Now. The birds.”

This was the part Bashir had wanted since the step at dawn. He leaned in.

Narin laid the two printouts side by side, the wedges and the verses, and put a finger on each.

“Utnapishtim,” she said, “sends out a dove. The dove flies, finds no resting place, comes back. Then he sends a swallow. The swallow finds no resting place, comes back. Then he sends a raven. And the raven” — she paused — “does not come back. Because the raven has found the water gone down. So the man knows it’s safe.”

She moved her other finger.

“Noah sends out a raven first. The raven goes to and fro until the waters dry. Then he sends a dove. The dove finds no rest, comes back. He waits seven days. Sends the dove again. It comes back with an olive leaf in its beak. He waits seven more days. Sends it a third time. It does not return.”

She looked up at the room.

“Same idea,” she said. “Send a bird to read the world for you, because the bird can land where the man can’t. *Exactly* the same idea, a thousand years apart, on two sides of the same river-world. And” — the scalpel — “*different birds, in a different order, doing different things*. Dove, swallow, raven. Raven, dove, dove, dove. One of them carries an olive leaf — that’s Genesis only, that’s a new thing, that’s *hope on the wing*, and it’s not in the poem at all. The loud man would put both lists in a box and draw an equals sign. There is no equals sign. There’s a family resemblance. There’s a grandmother’s nose on a grandchild’s face.” She straightened. “If you want to feel how close two stories can be while being two stories — read the birds.”

Bashir found his throat had gone tight and he didn’t entirely know why, except that it was the leaf. The whole horror of the drowned world and the cowering gods and the human noise, and a poet a thousand years downstream of all of it had reached into the wreckage and given the bird a green leaf to carry back, a thing that grows, and Bashir thought that whoever did that had done it on *purpose*, had taken the old terrible flood and bent it, just slightly, toward the morning — and

he could not have explained it to anyone who hadn't read both, and that was the loneliness, and that was also the gift.

"And then," Narin said, "the part that ends the morning."

She read the end of the poem. The flood subsides. The boat grounds on the mountain — *Nimush*, she said, *a real peak, you can argue about which one, somewhere up toward the Zagros, not Ararat, a different mountain entirely, hold that too* — and Utnapishtim opens a window and lets out the birds and then he comes down and he makes a sacrifice. He pours out a libation. He sets up offering vessels and burns reed and cedar and myrtle.

And the gods, she read, smelled the savour. The gods smelled the sweet savour.

And the gods, she read, gathered like flies over the offering.

She set the printout down.

"Like flies," she said.

Nobody moved.

"They've been crouched against the wall like dogs," she said, "scared of the storm they made, *starving*, because nobody's been feeding them, because all the people who fed them are drowned. And the one man left alive lights a fire and the smell of meat goes up and the gods come down on it" — her hand made the smallest gesture, a descent, a swarming — "like flies on a carcass. That's the line. A thousand years before Genesis. The gods are *hungry*, and they need us, and when they smell the smoke they come down like flies."

She let it land all the way down.

"Now hear what Genesis does with the same picture," she said, and turned the page, and read it. Noah builds an altar. He takes of every clean beast and offers burnt offerings. *And the LORD smelled a sweet savour*. The same image — the smoke goes up, the smell reaches heaven. "Same furniture," Narin said softly. "The savour. The offering. The smell rising. The single survivor at the altar. And then watch the camera move. There are no flies. There is no swarm. There is no hungry god. There is one God who smells the offering and says in his heart that he will not curse the ground again for man's sake. The picture is inherited" — she touched the wedges, touched the verses

— “and the meaning is *overturned*. They took the hungry gods and they refused them. They kept the smoke and they threw away the flies.”

Bashir realised he was leaning so far forward his tea had gone cold in his hand.

“That,” Narin said, “is what it means to say Genesis has a genealogy. Not theft. Not a copy. A people in exile — *here*, by these rivers, in Babylon, six hundred years before Christ, sat in the capitol of the empire that had burned their temple and dragged them east — and they sat in the empire’s own library, with the empire’s own flood story open in front of them, the gods like flies and the noise and the cube boat — and they *answered it*. Line by line. Picture by picture. They took the most powerful story their conquerors had, the story Babylon told to say *this is how the world is*, and they rebuilt it to say *no*. *Not flies*. *Not noise*. *Not a god who can’t sleep*. *A God who grieves, and a covenant, and a leaf*.” She closed the black book. “They kept their soul by re-authoring the empire’s own myth. That’s the most extraordinary thing I know how to put in front of you. And it’s a thousand times braver than aliens.”

Frik said it then. He’d been holding it, Bashir could see, jaw working, the tic riding up under it, and when it came it came clean, the involuntary truth that he could not paint over and so never did:

“They wrote back.”

“They wrote back,” Narin said, and for the first time that morning she smiled, properly, at Frik, who had said in two words the thing she’d spent twenty years and a whole dawn trying to say.

Mira had her hands over her own heart, flat, and then she signed something to the room, slow enough that even Bashir caught all of it, and he said it aloud because that was the deal, that was always the deal, nobody got talked over here: “Mira says — what did they not say.” He frowned. “She means — in the answer. What did the exiles leave *out*, on purpose, that we can only see if we already know what they were answering.”

The room turned to her. Narin turned to her, and Bashir watched the Assyriologist actually stop, the way she had not stopped for the loud man or the alien man or any of them, and look at the deaf woman

who read the unsaid, and consider the question as a real question, the best one of the morning.

“That,” Narin said slowly, “is the right question. And it’s the next one.” She gathered the printouts, the wedges and the verses both, squared them under the tea-towel. “Because the flood is where they *kept* the picture and bent it. There’s another place — the very beginning, the creation, the waters and the deep — where they kept a single *word* and refused everything around it. Where Babylon’s god makes the world by *butchering* a goddess and splitting her body — and Genesis makes it by *speaking*.” She tucked the bundle under her arm. “Combat against word. That one’s not a family resemblance. That one’s a fight. We’ll do it tonight, in the cool, when the light’s gone flat and nobody’s eyes hurt.”

Outside, near the Beast, Bashir could see Jakobus through the doorway, doing some slow patient thing to the water bag that hung off the truck’s flank and wept its single bright drop into the dust, keeping itself cold the way it had kept itself cold across a different and farther desert. He had his back to them. He had been, Bashir was fairly sure, within earshot of the whole reading and had not come in, because the morning belonged to Narin and to the dead poets and to the people who lived here now, and he knew it, and so he stayed outside with the truck and the slow drip and let it.

Naila had her notebooks open again. She wasn’t running the sar. She was making two columns, the way she did, and at the top of one she’d written, in her square small hand, *flies*, and at the top of the other she’d written nothing yet, because the other column was the silence — the thing they’d left out — and you don’t fill a column like that until you know what it was answering.

“Tonight,” she said, to no one, to the count, to the lattice closing its next gap. “The water that gets divided.”

“Tonight,” Bashir agreed, and went to make new tea, the right way, with leaves, because somebody had to, and because the morning had earned it.

Chapter 14 — By Word, Not Combat

The light went flat the way Narin had promised it would.

Naila felt it before she saw it — the heat coming off its high white edge and slumping into something the skin could stand, the concrete giving its hoarded sun back to the room a degree at a time. Outside, the call to prayer wound up from somewhere across the rooftops, threaded the unfinished window-holes, and the diesel generator two doors down kept its low animal idle going underneath, and the two sounds did not agree and did not need to. She liked the hour. It had no glare in it. Glare was a kind of noise.

They'd dragged the plastic chairs into a loose ring around the camp lantern. Yusuf had found a second lantern somewhere — Yusuf found things — and set it on the floor, so the light came up from below and made everybody's faces strange and tall-shadowed, like figures pressed into a seal and rolled out across a tablet.

Narin had her laptop open on her knees, the British Museum photographs queued, but she hadn't turned it toward them yet. She was waiting. She had a teacher's instinct for the held breath.

"Tonight," she said, "I'm going to break a rule I made you keep this morning."

Bashir, cross-legged on a folded blanket, looked up. "You said *identical equals lie*."

"I did. And I meant it." She set the laptop aside on the floor, screen down, so the only thing on offer for the moment was her own face. "This one isn't a resemblance. This one's a fight. And I want you to

see the fight before I let you anywhere near the things people get wrong about it.”

Naila uncapped her pen. New page. She drew the line down the middle without thinking about it, the way her hand drew lines down the middle of things, and at the top of the left column she wrote *combat*. At the top of the right column she wrote nothing.

The right column was for what the fight was *for*. You don’t fill that one early.

“Enuma Elish,” Bashir said, and the words came out of him the way they always did when a language opened its own door — easier than English, smoother, his mouth glad of the work. “*When on high*. That’s the title, which isn’t a title, it’s just the first two words, because that’s how they named things. *Enūma eliš lā nabû šamāmū* — when the heavens above were not yet named.”

“Not yet *named*,” Narin repeated, and let it hang. “Hold that. We’ll need it later.”

Naila wrote *named* in the right column, faint, in pencil, because she wasn’t sure yet what it was answering.

“It’s Babylon’s creation poem,” Narin went on. “Seven tablets. Recited at the New Year festival, every spring, out loud, in the Esagila — Marduk’s temple, in the city of Babylon. Imagine that. Not a book on a shelf. A thing the king himself processes through the streets to hear, while the river comes up and the fields drink. It is *liturgy*. It is the city telling itself why the city gets to exist.”

“And why does the city get to exist?” Yusuf asked. He had his elbows on his knees. He’d gone quiet and forward in the lantern light, the way he did when a story had a shape he hadn’t expected, and Naila clocked it — Yusuf leaning in was its own data point, Yusuf who’d come into all this needing the bigness, the spacefarers, the secret kings. He leaned into the dust-version now the same way. She didn’t think he’d noticed yet that he was doing it.

“Because Marduk won a war,” Narin said.

She picked the laptop back up. Turned it. The first plate came up — not the poem itself, a relief, a thing of muscle and wing, a god striding

with the lightning gripped in his fist like a sheaf of reeds, and a great coiling horror underfoot, all jaw and serpent-loop.

“At the start there’s only water,” Narin said. “Two waters. Apsu — the fresh water, the sweet water, the deep that wells up under the ground. And Tiamat — the salt water, the sea. They mingle. From the mingling come the gods, generation on generation, and the young gods are *loud*. They dance, they make noise, they disturb the old quiet of the deep. Apsu wants to kill them all so he can sleep. The young gods kill him first. And Tiamat — the sea, the mother — rises to avenge her husband.”

The relief held the room. Frik had stopped tapping his knee, which for Frik was a kind of held breath of its own.

“She makes an army.” Narin’s voice didn’t perform it; she let the thing be enormous on its own. “Eleven monsters. Serpent-dragons, the scorpion-man, the bull-man, the great lion, demons with venom for blood. She puts a consort over them, a god named Kingu, and she gives Kingu the Tablet of Destinies — fastens it to his chest — and that’s the rule of the world made portable. And the young gods are terrified. The high gods, the wise ones, they go out one by one to face her and they come back white. Nobody can stand against the sea.”

“And Marduk says he’ll do it,” Bashir said quietly, because he knew the shape of it.

“Marduk says he’ll do it. For a price.” Narin’s mouth tightened, almost a smile, almost not. “He’s young. He’s the storm-god, the city-god of Babylon, which a few centuries before this was nobody’s idea of a capital. And he says: *I’ll fight your monster. But if I win, I’m in charge. Forever. My word fixes fate. You bow.* And they’re so frightened they agree. They throw a feast, they get drunk on the strong beer, they test his power by telling him to destroy a constellation and recreate it with a word — and he does — and they hand him everything.”

Naila wrote, in the left column, *power = won, not given*. Then she underlined *won* twice, because that was the whole hinge and she could already feel where the right column was going to swing against it.

“So he goes out to the sea,” Narin said. “And this is the part. This

is the engine of the whole thing.” She didn’t raise her voice. She lowered it. “He takes the four winds. He makes a net to catch her. He fills his body with flame. He rides the storm-chariot, and he rolls out the lightning, and when Tiamat opens her mouth to swallow him — he drives the evil wind in so she *can’t close it*. Her belly distends. And he shoots the arrow in through the open mouth and splits her heart.”

The generator coughed, two doors down, and steadied.

“Then he stands on her corpse,” Narin said, “and he splits her. Like a fish split for drying. He takes the top half and raises it up and makes the sky, and he sets a bar across it and posts a guard, and he tells the guard: *do not let her waters out*. He takes the bottom half and makes the earth. Her eyes become the sources of the two rivers — the Tigris, the Euphrates. Her breasts become the mountains. He bends her tail up into the sky to make the Milky Way. The whole world, the dome over your head and the ground under your feet, is the carved-open carcass of a murdered goddess, held apart by force, because if the force ever lets go the waters come back together and drown everything.”

Nobody spoke. Edith, on the far chair, had her camera in her lap, both hands folded over the body of it, not lifting it, and Naila saw her decide not to lift it, which was a thing Edith was learning to do in front of them like a man learning to set down a drink.

“Creation,” Narin said, “is what’s left over after a fight. The sky is a wound that won’t reopen because somebody’s standing on it.”

“Now.” She put the laptop down again. Her voice changed register — not less reverent, *more*, the way a hand gets more careful near the thing it loves. “I’m going to read you something. Bashir, you’ll know it before I’m three words in.”

“I already do,” Bashir said, and there was a thickness in it, because he heard the trap she was springing and it was a beautiful one.

“In the beginning,” Narin said, “God created the heavens and the earth. And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light.”

She let *Let there be* sit in the lantern-light.

“There’s the deep,” she said. “There’s the dark water at the start, no shape to it, waiting. Same furniture. Same problem the Babylonians were chewing on — what do you do about the formless water that was there before everything. And on the second day —” she found it from memory, no screen — “*And God said, Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters. And God made the firmament, and divided the waters which were under the firmament from the waters which were above the firmament.*”

She looked up.

“The dome,” she said. “Holding back the waters above from the waters below. The exact same cosmic plumbing. The waters of chaos, divided, held apart, a barrier set between them. It is, I promise you, the *same room*. Anyone who tells you the Hebrews didn’t know this poem, didn’t know this whole way of seeing the sky — they’re not being careful.”

Yusuf was nodding, slow, and Naila could see the old door in his face, the one he’d come in through — the *aha, it’s all connected, it was all one secret thing*. He was a half-second from saying it.

“So they copied it,” Yusuf said. Not triumphant. Almost mournful. “It’s just Babylon with the serial numbers filed off.”

And Narin smiled, and it was the warmest Naila had seen her, because Yusuf had walked exactly into the spot she’d dug.

“No,” she said. “Look at *how* the firmament gets made.”

She stood up. She couldn’t help it; she was a teacher and the thing wanted standing for. The lantern threw her shadow up the unfinished wall, huge and rough on the grey block.

“Marduk *butchers a god*,” she said. “He shoots the arrow into Tiamat’s open mouth and splits her body and shoves the halves apart with his hands and the dome is her carcass. Combat. Murder. Dismemberment. The sky is held up by an act of war and it stays up because a soldier’s posted to keep it up.”

She turned, found the page in the air.

“Genesis. *And God said, Let there be a firmament.* And there was. He *talks*. There’s no monster. There’s no sea-mother. There’s no rival to fight, because there’s no second power in the room to fight *with*. The deep isn’t a goddess. It’s just water. It’s just dark water with no will of its own, waiting to be told what to do — and it gets *told*, it doesn’t get *fought*, and it obeys, because the one doing the telling is the only one there. The waters get divided by a *sentence*.”

Naila’s pen had already moved. In the left column: *split by force*. In the right, where she’d been waiting all night to write something true: *divided by word*.

There it was. The lattice clicked its gap shut.

“That’s not filing off the serial numbers,” Narin said, and now her voice had grief in it as well as fire, and the grief was the part Mira was watching — Naila could see Mira’s eyes on Narin’s hands, on the set of her jaw, reading the thing Narin wasn’t saying yet. “That’s taking the conqueror’s own poem, the one his soldiers recited over your burning city, and bending every joint of it. They kept the furniture. The deep, the dome, the waters above and below — they kept all of it, because that’s the furniture *everyone* in that world had, that’s just what the sky was *made of* if you were a human being between the two rivers. But they changed the *verb*. Combat became speech. Theomachy became a single voice in the dark. War became a word.”

She sat back down. The shadow came down off the wall.

“And the people,” she said, quieter. “Tell them, Bashir. What are people for, in Marduk’s version.”

Bashir had been waiting too. He’d half-said this before, days ago, but he said it whole now, and Naila watched the language carry him.

“After Marduk wins,” he said, “the gods are tired. They’ve been doing the digging — the canals, the irrigation, the whole back-breaking apparatus of keeping Mesopotamia alive, because Mesopotamia does not feed you unless you *break your back* moving water around. And Marduk says, I’ll make a thing to take that off you. And they take Kingu — Tiamat’s general, the one who held the Tablet of Destinies, the loser, the traitor — and they cut his throat. And from his blood they make people.”

"To do the work," Yusuf said. Very low.

"To do the work," Bashir said. "So the gods don't have to dig. *Lullû* — a savage, a labourer. Made from the blood of a defeated rebel god, mixed with — in the older poem, Atrahasis, it's clay — mixed with clay, so that the rebel's blood carries the spark and the clay carries the body. You are dirt and a dead traitor's blood and your job is the irrigation roster. That's what a human being is. That's the *good* news in the poem — congratulations, the gods don't have to dig anymore, because now there's *you*."

He stopped. Frik had gone very still again and then he wasn't still — his shoulder jerked, his head went sideways and back, and the words came out of him before he could weigh them, clean and flat the way his true things came:

"*Slaves. Made to be slaves.*"

He blinked. Nobody laughed. Nobody ever laughed; the crew had unlearned that early. The blurt sat in the lantern-light, exactly right, the thing the poem said and would not soften.

"Slaves," Narin agreed, gently, like she was thanking him. "Made of clay to bear the gods' toil. That's the Mesopotamian answer to *why are we here*. You're here because somebody with more power than you got tired of digging."

She let it lie a moment.

"Now Genesis," she said. "*And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. In the image. Not as a labour-saving device. Not from a traitor's blood to spare the gods a sore back. In the image — the word they used for the statue of the king you'd set up in a province so everyone knew who ruled there. Every single human being, the king's standing-stone. Put down here to represent. Same dust — God forms him from the dust of the ground, the clay's still there, they kept the clay — but the clay gets the breath of the only god there is, and gets told to rule, not to dig.*"

She spread her hands.

"That's the argument. That's the whole, furious, brilliant argument a defeated people made with their captor's own toys. *You said we were made from a dead god's blood to spare the masters their labour. We*

say we were made in the image of the only Master, to stand for him over the whole earth. You can't make that argument unless you know Babylon's version cold. You have to love the enemy's poem to fight it that precisely."

Mira lifted her hands and signed something, slow and careful, and when nobody caught it she said it, in her own flat clear voice that the crew had stopped hearing as flat months ago: "They didn't run from the big story. They climbed inside it and turned it around."

"Yes," Narin said, and looked straight at her, full at her, the way people so rarely did. "Exactly that."

And then she did the thing Naila had been waiting for, the thing that was Narin's whole gift, the reason the win in this room was hers and would never be theirs to take: she turned the scalpel on her own side.

"And now," she said, "I'm going to disappoint the people who want this to be neater than it is. Because there's a version of what I just told you that's *too* clean, and the internet loves it, and it's wrong, and if you go out and repeat the wrong version you'll deserve every Assyriologist who corrects you."

She held up one finger.

"You'll hear that *tehom* — the Hebrew word for the deep, 'darkness on the face of the deep' — is just Tiamat with the vowels changed. That Genesis literally *borrowed the goddess's name*. It's all over the place. It sounds amazing. It's the kind of thing that makes you feel like you've cracked something." A breath. "It's not true. *Tehom* and *Tiamat* both come down from a common Semitic root — *t-h-m* — that just means the deep, the abyss, the primeval ocean. They're cousins. They share a great-grandmother. *Tehom* is not a loan of the *name* Tiamat; if the Hebrews had borrowed her name directly the word would have a different shape and it doesn't, it behaves like an ordinary inherited noun, no goddess attached. It's a cognate, not a theft. And the difference *matters*, because the whole point I just made you — that they stripped the personhood off the deep, that they turned a goddess into plain water — *only works* if *tehom* is a word for water and not a smuggled-in deity. The reverent reading and the careful reading are the same reading. The cheap version

breaks both.”

Second finger.

“And you’ll hear: *seven tablets, seven days*. The poem’s in seven tablets, creation’s in seven days, ooh.” She made the *ooh* gently, no cruelty in it. “It’s a coincidence people fall in love with. The seventh tablet of Enuma Elish isn’t a day of rest — it’s fifty hymns of praise piled on Marduk, his fifty names, the council exalting him. It’s nothing like a Sabbath. The poem isn’t even organised by days. You can want the parallel as hard as you like; it isn’t there. Hold the parts that are real *because* they’re real, and let the pretty fake ones go, or you hand the whole case to the first person who knows the texts.”

Naila wrote, in small letters in the margin between her two columns: *cousins, not theft. 7≠7*. She felt the same plain satisfaction she got from a balanced sum. The over-reach died the same way the aliens died — in the actual words, with the actual root, *t-h-m*, a thing you could go and check.

“So what’s left,” Yusuf said. He’d stopped leaning forward. He was sitting up now, and there was a kind of vertigo in his face, the man who’d come for the secret-spacefarers finding the floor of the real thing was further down and held more weight. “Strip the cheap stuff out. What’s left.”

Narin closed the laptop. The screen-glow went, and there was only the two lanterns, one high, one low.

“What’s left is bulletproof and it’s the only thing worth saying,” she said. “The Hebrew scriptures — the creation, the flood, Eden, the tower, the law-codes — are in deliberate conversation with older Mesopotamian literature. Older by a thousand years and more. And the channel’s not a mystery. It’s the Exile. Six hundred years before your calendar starts, Babylon takes Jerusalem apart and marches the educated class — the priests, the scribes, the people who *make texts* — to Babylon and keeps them there for two generations. They live in the city of Marduk. They hear Enuma Elish recited at the New Year while the river comes up. They go home, eventually, and they write — and what they write is shot through, on every page, with the poems of the people who conquered them, *answered*. Not

copied. Answered. That's not a fringe theory. That's the first week of any honest seminary. It has a genealogy, and the genealogy runs straight through the worst thing that ever happened to them."

She stopped. Let it be as big and as quiet as it was.

"That's the real thing," she said. "And it's harder to live with than either lie. It's harder than *the Bible fell out of the sky with no fingerprints on it*. And it's a thousand times harder than *aliens did it and it's all just myth anyway, who cares*. Because it asks you to hold two things at once: that this is a made thing, made by human beings at a specific desk in a specific catastrophe — *and* that what they made out of their captivity was a vision of the dignity of every human being that the people who wrote the alien comics couldn't dream up on their best day. Made of clay, yes. But made to *stand*, not to dig."

Outside, the call to prayer had ended; the generator alone now, and far off a dog, and once, the soft particular sound of Jakobus moving the Beast's water bag a hand's width along the rail so it could drip on dry ground instead of mud. He hadn't come in. The room was Narin's and he'd left it hers. Naila found she'd stopped resenting how the man arranged himself around the edges of rooms; he arranged himself the way she arranged the margins of a page, leaving the centre for the count.

She looked down at her two columns. *Combat* and *word*. *Force* and *speech*. *Made to dig* and *made to stand*. The left column full, the right column full now too, and across the bottom of the right one, the pencil thing she'd written hours ago, when Bashir first said it — *named* — *when the heavens were not yet named*.

Marduk *split* the world.

But before any of it — before sky, before earth — the very first verb in the Babylonian poem was the world being *named*. And Genesis ran the same verb the whole way through: God said, and called the light Day, and called the dark Night, *named* and *named* and *named*. Two civilisations, both reaching for the same intuition that to make a thing real you first had to say it.

The number sat clean. She liked it. She didn't say it; it wasn't hers to say.

Bashir had gone quiet on his blanket, and Naila recognised the quiet

— the polyglot's quiet, the one that meant a language was holding a thing he couldn't put in English without breaking it. He had his lips moving, soundless, working at a word.

"Bashir," Narin said. She'd seen it too. "Where've you gone."

He looked up, and there was a grin starting in him that had nothing of mockery and everything of love.

"There's a better one," he said. "There's a *joke*. Older than all of this. In a poem about a paradise-garden and a god who eats the wrong plants, there's a pun — and it's hiding under one of the most famous verses in your Bible, Narin, and it only works in *one* dead language, and the moment you translate it into Hebrew it dies, and nobody who reads it in English has ever heard it laugh." He shook his head, slow, the way you do at something that's lasted three thousand years and is still, somehow, funny. "The rib. The woman from the rib. Wait till you hear what *rib* used to mean."

Narin's eyebrows went up.

"Tomorrow," she said. "In the cool. When the light's gone flat."

"Tomorrow," Bashir agreed.

And Naila turned the page, and at the top of the fresh one, square and small, she wrote a single Sumerian sign she didn't yet understand, and left the column beside it empty, the way you do when you don't yet know what it's answering.

Chapter 15 — The Joke in the Dead Language

The cool came late.

All day the heat had sat on the safehouse like a hand pressing a lid, and Bashir had felt the word he wanted to say going soft in his mouth, the way a thing does when you carry it too long without setting it down. He'd carried it through the morning's tea, through Yusuf's phone calls to a man in Sulaymaniyah about a man in Dohuk, through the long flat hours when nobody moved and the lizard on the wall by the window did not move either. He'd carried it past noon, when Naila had her notebook open and was checking the same column of base-sixty numerals for the fourth time, not because she doubted them but because the checking was its own kind of rest. He'd held it the way you hold a coal you mean to plant in a fire later.

Now the light was going. It came in long and yellow under the awning Jakobus had rigged from the Beast's tarp, and the dust in it turned to gold, and somewhere below the citadel a man was calling people to prayer, and the call rose and the heat broke, and Bashir set the word down.

"Ninti," he said.

Narin looked up from the low table. She had a glass of black tea going cold beside her and a photocopy of a tablet under her hand, the lines of it furred and broken where the clay had chipped three thousand years before anyone thought to photograph it. She had spent the day gating them. *Not that text. You're not ready for that text. You'd read it like Sitchin read it.* She gated by instinct now, the way you'd flinch a child's hand off a stove. But she didn't gate

this. She watched him say the name and something in her face came halfway open, the same half-open Mira clocked from across the room and didn't mention.

"Go on then," Narin said.

—

He'd reached her in Aramaic, four days ago, at the museum gate. That was the thing nobody else on the crew quite understood, and he'd never tried to explain it because the explaining made it small. He'd had thirty languages by then and none of them a country. You learned to read a border guard's first word and answer in his mother tongue before he'd decided what you were, and the door that had been shut swung to a crack, and you went through the crack, and that was a life. Belong everywhere. Native nowhere. He'd said three words of her grandmother's language and watched a closed Iraqi Assyrian face decide he was not, after all, only one more foreigner come to dig her dead out of the ground for the camera.

It was the loneliest gift he owned. He could open any door and stand in no room.

But he could feel a joke that had been waiting three thousand years for someone to laugh, and tonight he was going to laugh at it with the right people, and that was a thing too.

—

"There's a poem," Bashir said. "Sumerian. *Enki and Ninhursag*. It's old — old the way the others are old, the way that stops meaning anything when you say the number. There's a paradise in it. A clean place. No sickness, the raven doesn't croak, the lion doesn't kill, the wolf doesn't snatch the lamb. A garden where nothing has gone wrong yet."

"Eden," Edith said, low. She had her camera in her lap and her hand on it, flat, the way you'd hold a dog by the collar. She did not raise it. Bashir clocked that she did not raise it and was grateful in a way he didn't have a word for in any of his languages, which was rare enough that he noticed.

"It's a paradise," Bashir said. "I won't say it's Eden. Narin will skin me." Narin's mouth moved. "But it's the same *furniture*. A garden,

a god, water that makes the place live, and then — a god who can't leave the plants alone."

"Enki," Narin said. "Eats them. Eats the eight plants of the garden. He wants to *know* them, what they are, so he eats them, one after another, and Ninhursag — she's the great mother goddess, the lady of the mountain — she curses him for it. She says she won't look on him with the eye of life until he dies. And he starts to die. Eight plants, eight sicknesses. He's dying organ by organ."

"And the foxes broker a deal," Bashir said, grinning now, "because in these poems there is always, *always*, a clever animal who fixes things —"

"There's a fox," Frik said. It came out of him sideways, fast, the involuntary echo, and then a small tic of the shoulder, and then his own voice, dry: "Sorry. There's a fox."

"There's a fox," Bashir agreed, easy, no weight on it, and Frik's shoulders came down a half-inch.

"She comes back," Narin said. "Ninhursag. She relents. She sits him down — and this is the part — she takes him in and she sets a healing goddess at each sick part of him. One goddess per pain. And she asks him, each time: *brother, what hurts you?* And he tells her. *My jaw hurts. My rib hurts. My mouth hurts.* And for each one she births a deity whose name is a pun on the part."

"This," Bashir said, and he could feel it coming up his throat now, the coal he'd planted, going to flame, "is where it lives. He says — Enki says — *my rib hurts me*. My rib. The Sumerian is *ti*." He said it carefully. "*Ti*. It means rib." He let it sit one beat. "And it means *life*. To live. To make live. *Ti* — same sound, same sign, both."

Naila's pencil had stopped. Bashir watched it stop.

"So the goddess she births to heal his rib," Bashir said, "the lady of the rib — her name is *Nin-ti*. Lady of the rib." He spread his hands. "And lady who makes live. *Nin* is lady. *Ti* is rib *and* life. The name is a joke. It's a *pun*. You can't choose between the two readings because the poet didn't choose — that's the whole point, that's why it's funny, that's why somebody three thousand years ago wrote it down and was pleased with himself. The lady of the rib is the lady of life. The same word. You hear them both at once or you don't hear it at all."

The lizard moved on the wall. Nobody else did.

“And now,” Bashir said, quieter, “say it in Hebrew.”

—

He turned to Narin when he said it. Because it wasn’t his to land. It sat under the most famous garden in her book, and she was the one who’d grown up with that garden, and he wasn’t going to be a clever foreigner who cracked her scripture open like a nut on the table for the band’s benefit. He’d watched her gate them all day. He gated himself now. He held it out to her on his open hand.

She didn’t take it for a moment. She looked at the photocopy under her palm and then at the dark coming on under the awning and then at him.

“You want me to say it,” she said.

“It’s yours,” Bashir said. “I only heard it. You *carry* it.”

Narin let out a breath. It wasn’t quite a laugh.

“The woman,” she said. “In Genesis. God puts the man to sleep and takes a *tsela’* — a rib, a side — and from it he builds the woman. And the man names her *Chavvah*. Eve.” She turned her cold glass a quarter-turn on the table. “And the text *tells* you why it named her that. It glosses its own joke, in case you missed it. *Because she was the mother of all living.*” She looked up. “Mother of all *living*. From a *rib*.”

Mira, who had been reading the whole room — Bashir’s hands, Narin’s quarter-turned glass, Edith’s flat palm on the camera — signed something to Yusuf, two slow shapes, badly, and Yusuf, who signed worse, mouthed it back to be sure, and then said it aloud so Mira could watch his lips do it: “Rib. Living.”

“Yeah,” Narin said, to Mira, looking at Mira when she said it, which most people forgot to do. “Rib and living. In Hebrew those are two completely different words. *Tsela’* and *chay*. They don’t sound alike, they don’t share a root, the pun is *dead*. It’s gone. So the Hebrew has to do it the hard way — it has to take the rib and the living and *put them next to each other* and say, look, look at this, the rib became the mother of all living, here is a connection.” She spread her own hands now, the way Bashir had. “It’s reaching for a joke it can’t make

anymore. The joke's in the other language. It got left behind in the other language, on the way over, and what came across into Hebrew is the *shape* of the joke with the laugh taken out."

For a while nobody said anything. The prayer-call below had stopped. The dust had stopped being gold and started being grey.

"That's the most beautiful thing I've ever heard," Yusuf said. His voice did a thing on it. He covered the thing by reaching for the teapot. "That's — sorry. Carry on."

—

Bashir had spent a long time learning when to let a silence work and when a silence was about to curdle. This one was working. He let it. Across from him Naila had bent back over her notebook, and she wasn't writing words, she was making the sign — the one she'd put at the top of a fresh page last night and left a blank column beside, not knowing what it answered. *Ti*. She was making it again and again, small, getting the wedges in the right order, the way she'd worried at the base-sixty numerals all day. Pattern. Not magic. Just a woman who found the truth of a thing by drawing it until her hand believed it.

"Okay," Edith said. Carefully. Hand still on the camera, still flat. "Help me, because I'm the one who's going to frame this and I don't want to frame it wrong." She looked at Narin. "Tell me what I'm *not* saying. Because I can already hear how the other lot would cut this." She did a voice. Not cruel. A trailer voice, slick, the streaming-doc voice they'd all started hearing in their sleep. "*The shocking pun hidden in Genesis. The ancient code the translators didn't want you to see. What were they covering up?*" She let it go. "Right? That's the cut. That's the version that gets eleven million views and a sequel."

"That's the version that's a *lie*," Narin said, and there was heat in it, and Bashir understood the heat. It wasn't the comparison that made her angry. It was the markup. "Nobody covered anything up. There's no code. There's no secret. The Sumerian poem is on a tablet in a museum, the Hebrew is in every house in the world, the dictionary entry for *ti* with both meanings is in a book a first-year student buys for forty pounds. It's the opposite of hidden. It's the most *read* book and one of the most studied poems on earth, and the connection isn't whispered — it's *taught*, it's in the footnotes, it's in the introductions. The scholars who worked this out a hundred and fifty years ago didn't

hide it. They *published* it. They wanted you to see it.” She tapped the photocopy. “The only people who need it to be a secret are the people selling you something.”

“What is it for, then,” Edith said. “If it’s not a smoking gun. What is it for.”

It was Jakobus’s question. Edith said it the way you handed back a tool. None of them had decided he led; he never led; but the question had got into all of them the same way his cayenne had got into the rice, a few grains, changing everything. *Not who. Not is-it-real. What is it for.*

Narin was quiet a moment.

“For me?” she said. “Or for them?”

“Both,” said Mira, watching her mouth.

—

“For them,” Narin said. “For the people who made the Sumerian poem. It’s *play*. That’s what kills me about the alien version, more than anything. They look at this — at people who invented writing, who ran the first cities, who did astronomy with their naked eyes and got it *right*, who balanced grain accounts in base sixty and counted to numbers that would take you all night — and the aliens-people look at that and they go: *no. Couldn’t be them. Must’ve been visitors. As if the men who could make a pun like Ninti couldn’t possibly have made a city.*”

She said it level. She’d promised herself, Bashir could tell, not to let it become a speech. She kept it level.

“And the joke proves them wrong better than any argument,” she said. “Because a pun is the most *human* thing there is. It’s not engineering. You don’t import it from the stars. A pun is somebody being *clever for the love of it*, somebody who knows their own language so well they can make it mean two things at once and trust you to catch both. That’s not a slave-race waiting for instructions. That’s a poet showing off. You don’t get a better proof of a civilisation than a joke it left for you, and the joke’s right there, and the alien version had to *not read it* to tell its story. That’s the tell. Every single time. They had to leave the clay unread.”

“Say more about that,” Yusuf said, and he wasn’t reaching for tea now. He’d gone still in the particular way he went still when the thing being said was the thing he’d needed, once, to be the other way round. He had needed the aliens, hard, in the years he didn’t talk about. The rabbit-hole had been a door out of a life he couldn’t stand. Bashir watched him hold the door open now and look at the bigger room behind it and not flinch.

“They had to leave it unread to make it shine,” Yusuf said, slowly, working it out as a man works out a sum he doesn’t like. “If you actually read the tablet it stops being a relic and starts being a *text*. Some bloke’s joke. And a joke isn’t worth much on a grey market. But *PROOF OF ALIENS*, a tablet nobody’s translated, a tablet that *can’t* be translated, that’s worth —” He stopped. He’d come at the network sideways, by accident, by following the money the way he always did, and now he’d arrived at it. “That’s the markup. The mystery is the markup. The minute someone reads it and it says *the lady of the rib is the lady of life*, the price collapses. So you keep it unread. You keep the question loud and the answer buried and the crate keeps moving.”

Nobody said anything. Below the citadel a generator coughed and caught.

“Right,” Yusuf said, to himself.

—

Frik had been bouncing his knee for a while, a small fast bounce, and his hand had come up to his collarbone twice and gone down. The room had gone serious and the serious was loud in him. Bashir saw it building, the way you see weather. They all saw it. Nobody moved to manage him, which was the kindness, the actual one — not pretending it wasn’t happening, not making him a problem to be solved, just leaving him room in the circle.

“They keep it unread,” Frik said, fast, an echo of Yusuf, and then his voice tried to climb on top of itself, “keep it unread, keep it — *the sar is the orbit*,” and the wrongness of it, the over-reach he’d punctured a dozen times before, came out of him whole and helpless, and his face did a thing, the way it did, because he hadn’t meant to throw the lie up, the lie had thrown itself, and the involuntary part was the worst part to live in — and then, lower, scraped out of him, the spike,

the rare one, the one that only came when the truth was too big to come politely: “It’s a *number*. It’s just a — it’s a fucking *number*.”

The word landed in the quiet. Nobody laughed. That was the rule and the rule held because it was true: the swear wasn’t a gag, it was the truth coming out the only door it could find, and the truth was that the 3,600 — the *sar*, the great number the aliens had made an orbit, a doom-planet, a clock counting down to the return of the gods — was a base-sixty numeral, sixty sixties, a sign a child of Ur could read, and the colossal effort it had taken to turn a number into a spaceship was the whole crime in one syllable, and Frik had said it, involuntary, exact.

“It’s just a number,” Narin agreed, gently, and Frik’s knee stopped, and his hand came down off his collarbone and stayed down. “You’re right. That’s all it ever was.”

“Sorry,” Frik said.

“Don’t be,” said Mira, who’d read the whole thing off his body before the words came and had her hand half-raised in something none of them had taught her, an apology she was offering to him for the room going so quiet around him.

—

It was full dark now. Someone had lit the lantern. Out past the awning, near the truck, Jakobus stood in the way he stood, shades up on his head though there was no sun, his clean hanky going over the wing mirror in slow passes, and the Beast’s canvas water bag sweating its slow cold beside him, and he was not in the conversation and never came into it, but his presence sat at the edge of the circle like the desert sits at the edge of a town, and once, when Frik’s voice had spiked, the slow passes of the hanky had not paused, which was its own kind of answer. *Carry on. The man’s fine. The man’s one of mine.* He looked at none of them. He hummed something, low, a tune none of them knew, keeping a time none of them could hear.

Bashir watched him for a moment through the dark, the man no camera could hold, and felt the old loneliness move in him, and then felt it settle, because the man out there belonged nowhere either and had made this — this circle of the written-off under a tarp on the wrong side of the world — out of exactly that not-belonging. You could make

a home out of having no country. Bashir was learning that. It was taking him a long time.

“Bashir.” Narin’s voice brought him back. She was looking at him oddly, kindly. “Where’ve *you* gone now.”

“Nowhere,” he said. Then, because it was true and the room had earned true things tonight: “Everywhere. Same problem.”

She nodded like she understood it, and maybe she did. She had two languages and one people and no safe country either. They were not so different, the two of them, the man with no nation and the woman whose nation kept being marched out of its own ground.

—

“There are more,” Bashir said, because he wanted to give them one more and then let the night close. “Eden threads. Not one-to-one — Narin will skin me again — not a *blueprint*. But the furniture keeps showing up in the rooms. Adapa.” He looked at Narin to take it.

“A man,” she said. “Offered the bread of life and the water of life by the gods, and he refuses it — because his own god warned him it was the bread of death, a misunderstanding, a kindness that betrays him — and so he loses immortality by a *mistake*. By getting it wrong. Not by sin. By misreading the situation.” Her mouth tilted. “Which, given what we’ve been saying about translation all night, I’ll let you enjoy.”

“And the plant,” Bashir said. “In Gilgamesh.”

“He finds it,” Narin said. “The plant that makes the old man young. At the bottom of the sea, he ties stones to his feet and goes down and brings it up, the one thing in all his grief that could undo death — and he sets it down on the bank to bathe, and a serpent comes up out of the water and eats it, and sheds its skin, and slips away renewed, and the man sits down and weeps. The snake gets the immortality. The snake. In a garden, by the water.” She held up a flat hand before anyone could leap. “It’s *not* the Genesis serpent. Don’t. It’s the same furniture in a different room. A motif. A snake, a plant, a lost forever — these are the pieces the whole world built its gardens out of, everyone working with the same handful of clay.”

“Same handful of clay,” Naila said, from her notebook, not looking up. It was the first thing she’d said in an hour. She’d made the sign

for *ti* maybe forty times by now and her hand believed it. “That’s the actual finding. That’s the pattern. Not *the same story*. The same *pieces*. Everyone in the room got the same Lego and built a different house, and you can tell whose house is whose by what they did with the pieces.” She looked up at last, found Narin. “And the question that’s left over — the real one, the one nobody’s answered — isn’t *which house is true*. It’s *who handed Genesis the Lego*. Where the pieces came from. How they got from a tablet in a Babylonian library into the hands of the people who wrote the garden in Hebrew.”

The lantern hissed. Narin had gone still, the particular stillness of a person who has been waiting all night for the others to walk themselves to the right door so she wouldn’t have to drag them there.

“Yes,” she said. “That.”

“You know,” Naila said. Not a question.

“I know where the older drafts were kept,” Narin said. “And I know who got marched there, in chains, and stood in front of them, and read them.” She drew the cold glass toward her and didn’t drink. Outside, Jakobus’s tune went on, low, marking a time none of them could hear. “There was a library,” Narin said. “It belonged to the people who’d just burned your city and taken your god’s house apart stone by stone and walked you a thousand miles to live in their capital. And in that library, in the language of the people who’d destroyed you, was the older version of the story of how the world began.”

She looked round the circle, at the written-off, at the man no camera could hold standing out in the dark.

“Tomorrow,” she said. “I’ll tell you what they did with it.”

Chapter 16 — The Enemy's Library

Morning in Erbil came in flat and white, the heat already a held breath by the time Mira came out under the awning. The others were arranging themselves on cushions and crates in the half-shade. She took the place she always took now, back to the wall, angle on every face. Naila sat to her left where she could see the hands; that had become a quiet agreement between them, never spoken, the best kind.

Narin came last, with a tray. Tea in the small waisted glasses, and beside it a slab of bread torn from a sheet the size of a tablecloth. She set the tray down and lowered herself onto a cushion and did not look at any of them for a moment, looking instead at the steam coming off the glass nearest her hand.

Through the gap in the awning Mira could see the truck, and the long shape of Jakobus beside it, doing the thing he did with the water bag — the canvas one that wept itself cool, sweating in the heat the way nothing here did, a desert trick on a desert he hadn't been born to. He wasn't watching them. He never watched them in a way you could catch. He was reading the lane.

"Last night," Narin said, and her hands found the glass and turned it, "Naila asked the right question. She said: who handed Genesis the Lego." A small movement at the mouth that wasn't quite a smile. "I have hated that metaphor all night and I can't replace it."

Naila signed something at Mira, fast and badly — *I'm sorry and good* tangled into one shape. Mira shook her head: *no, it's good*. Across the circle Bashir caught the exchange and translated it for himself silently, his lips moving, the way he couldn't help.

"So I'll answer it," Narin said. "And the answer is a city. And a march. And a library."

She started with the march, because that was where the people started.

She told it plainly. In the year the West likes to round to 586 before its own era, the armies of Babylon came up the Levantine coast and did to Jerusalem what Babylon did to cities that didn't pay. Mira watched the words on Narin's mouth and the words under them. *Came up. Did.* Narin was not performing grief. She was holding it at a distance you could only manage with a thing you'd lived around your whole life, the way you carry a body you have washed yourself.

The temple, Narin said, was taken apart. Not burned only — *taken apart*. The bronze pillars cut up for the metal. The vessels carried off as inventory. And the people — not all of them; the ones who mattered, the ones with words in their heads — the priests, the scribes, the skilled, the literate, the dangerous-because-they-remembered — were chained and walked east.

"A thousand kilometres," Narin said. "Give or take. To the heart of the empire. To the capital of the people who had just unmade your god's house with their hands."

Yusuf had gone very still. Mira knew the stillness. It was the stillness of a man recognising a road from the wrong side of it.

"And here is the thing nobody draws in the children's Bible," Narin said. "They didn't go to a camp. They weren't dumped in a desert to die. Babylon was *cosmopolitan*. The cleverest city on earth, then. They settled the exiles by a canal — there's a man, Ezekiel, who tells you the name, the Kebar, the *nār Kabari*, it's in the cuneiform too, it's a real waterway — and the skilled among them found their level. And a scribe is a scribe. A scribe with letters in two languages is a scribe anywhere."

She let that sit.

"They could go into the city," she said. "And the city had a library."

This was where Bashir came forward, because libraries were his. He didn't take it from her — Mira watched the handover, the small tilt of Narin's head that gave it to him, *go on, you know this part* — and he took it gently, the way you take a sleeping child off someone's lap.

"You have to understand what a Babylonian library was," Bashir said. "Not a building of scrolls that rot. Clay. Baked clay. Tens of thousands of tablets, shelved, *catalogued* — they had catalogues, they had the equivalent of a card index, they had a tablet that told you which tablets they had. A scribe's whole training was copying. You copied to learn the signs, you copied to keep the texts alive, you copied because that is what a library is — a machine for not forgetting."

"And the Hebrew scribes could read it," Naila said. Not a question. She had a stylus going on her knee, the cut reed, marking the clay tablet she'd been allowed, the soft grey one. Mira couldn't see what she was writing. It didn't matter. The writing was how Naila held still.

"Akkadian was the diplomatic language of the whole ancient Near East for centuries," Bashir said. "It was the French of its day, the English of its day. A trained Judean scribe, a man whose job was words — there is no reason on earth he couldn't read the tablets. Every reason he would *want* to. You are a person of the book in a city that invented the book. You are a writer in the largest library that has ever existed. Of course you went in."

He spread his hands.

"And there, in the language of the people who marched you here in chains, was the older draft of your own beginning."

Mira watched Narin while Bashir said it. Narin's face did a thing then — not a flinch, the opposite of a flinch, a settling, like a stone finding the bottom of a well.

"Tell them what was on the shelf," Narin said.

Bashir told them.

He told them about the flood — not the way the streaming-doc would tell it, with a dramatic chord and a dark water effect, but the way the clay told it. A council of gods. A man warned. A boat built, sealed

with bitumen, loaded with kin and craft and beasts. The rain. The waters. The boat grounding on a mountain. The birds sent out to test for land. The sacrifice when the man comes ashore, and the gods — Bashir's voice did something here, dropped — the gods crowding to the smell of the offering "like flies," because they'd flooded the world and forgotten they liked to be fed.

"A thousand years older than Genesis," Bashir said. "At least. Sitting on a shelf the exiles could walk up to."

"So they copied it," Edith said. She had her camera in her lap. The lens cap was on. Mira had clocked that the moment she sat down — the cap on, the strap looped twice round Edith's wrist so the thing couldn't lift itself to her eye by old habit. Edith was keeping her own hands honest.

"That," Narin said, "is exactly the wrong word. And it's the word people reach for, and it's why this whole conversation goes to ruin in the comments section." Her mouth quirked. She'd clearly read the comments section. "*Copied* is what the man who needs scripture to be a fraud says. *Copied* is the looting word. You took it, it was always theirs, you're a thief." She turned the glass a half-turn. "And it's wrong. Naila, tell them why it's wrong. You found it yourself, you don't need me."

Naila looked up from the clay. The whole circle waited, and didn't crowd, because they'd learned not to crowd.

"Because the houses are different," she said. "Same Lego." The faintest of grins. "Sorry. Same pieces, different houses. The flood story isn't *copied*, because if you copied it you'd get the *same one*, and you don't. The mountains are different — theirs is a mountain called Nimush, the Hebrew one is the mountains of Ararat, that's not a transcription error, that's a different mountain. The birds go out in a different order. The boat's a different shape. The number of days is different. The reason for the flood is *completely* different, and that's the whole — that's the whole tell."

"Say the reason," Narin said.

"In the old one," Naila said, "the gods flood the world because people are too *loud*. They're breeding, they're noisy, the gods can't sleep. It's a noise complaint. It's the upstairs neighbours calling the council on

the human race.” A few breaths around the circle, the laugh that isn’t quite a laugh. “And in Genesis the reason is *moral*. The world is full of violence, of *hamas*, and that’s why. Somebody took the same flood and changed *why God does it*. You don’t change the why by accident. You change the why because you have a different idea of what God is *for*.”

She looked down at her clay again, finished.

“That’s not copying,” she said, to the reed. “That’s arguing.”

Frik had been quiet the whole morning. He sat a little apart, as he always did when he was working hard at holding, his shoulder giving the soft repeated rise it gave. Now his head ticked once, twice, and the word came out of him sideways, not aimed at anyone:

“*Better.*”

Then, the involuntary completion, riding the same breath, surprising him as much as them: “*The arguing’s the good bit.*”

Narin looked at him. Something passed over her that Mira read clearly and that the others probably missed, because they were watching Frik to see if he was all right, which was the kind thing and the wrong thing. The thing that passed over Narin was *relief*. Frik had said the load-bearing sentence and he’d had no choice about it, which meant it was true the way only the things a person can’t stop are true.

“Yes,” Narin said quietly. “The arguing is the good bit. Hold that.”

She poured more tea. The morning had thickened; you could hear the bazaar starting up below the citadel, the metal-on-metal, a generator, a long way off a call.

“Now I’m going to do the thing I trust the fewest people on earth to do,” Narin said. “I’m going to take you to the second shelf. And I want you to watch how careful I am, because there’s a version of this conversation that turns my faith into a museum case, and I won’t have it, not in my own family’s house. So watch my hands.”

She put both hands flat on her knees, like a witness swearing in.

"The tower," she said. "Babel."

Mira felt the room change shape. Even Yusuf leaned in.

"Genesis eleven," Narin said. "The whole world had one language. They came to a plain in the land of Shinar — and Shinar is Sumer, that's not in dispute, that's just the Hebrew name for the place — and they said, come, let us build a city and a tower whose top is in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves, lest we be scattered. And God comes down to see it, and confounds the languages, and scatters them. And the place is called Babel, *because there the LORD confused — balal — the languages.*" She let the breath out. "And every Sunday-school child in the world is taught that the tower fell down. It doesn't. Read it. The tower doesn't fall. God just stops the building by breaking the words."

She looked at Bashir.

"Tell them what the writer was looking at."

Bashir's whole body had come awake. This was his country, the country of words.

"He was looking at a ziggurat," Bashir said. "A real one. Babylon had a great temple-tower, a stepped mountain of brick. It had a name — Etemenanki. It means, roughly, *the house of the foundation of heaven and earth*. House. Of the foundation. Of heaven and earth. A tower whose top is meant to reach the heavens. It is *literally named* the thing the Genesis tower is *for*." He laughed, short. "And the name of the city, Babylon — in the Babylonians' own language it's *Bāb-ilim*, *bāb-ili*, the gate of the gods. A holy name. A proud name. *The gate where heaven touches earth.*"

"And the Hebrew writer," Narin said, "takes *the gate of the gods* — that proud, sacred name — and says no. He hears *bāb-ili* and he answers with *balal*. Confusion. Babble." Her mouth was a thin line and there was a fierce light behind it. "He puns. He takes the conquering city's holiest word for itself and turns it into the sound a baby makes. The gate of the gods is just *noise*. That's not a man who got the story wrong. That's a man who got the story exactly right and *answered it*."

Bashir picked it up like a relay baton. "And it's in the building too. Genesis: *let us make bricks, and burn them thoroughly, and they had brick for stone, and bitumen for mortar.*" He looked round at them.

“Stop. Listen to that. Burnt brick. Bitumen for mortar. That is not how you build in Canaan. In the Levant you build with *stone*. You quarry it, you stack it, you mortar it with lime. Mud-brick maybe, sun-dried, but you don’t bake your bricks in kilns and you don’t seal a tower with tar — *because you don’t have the tar*.” He brought a hand down soft on his own knee. “Baked brick and bitumen mortar is the *Mesopotamian* method. It’s how you build in the alluvial plain where there’s no stone and the river gives you mud and the ground sweats asphalt. The Genesis writer doesn’t just *know about* Babylon. He knows how Babylon’s bricklayers worked. He’s describing a building technique that doesn’t belong in his own country.”

“Because,” Naila said, very quietly, the reed gone still on the clay, “he was *there*.”

The awning ticked in the heat. Outside, Jakobus’s tune started up, low, the same handful of notes he used when nothing was wrong. Mira couldn’t hear it, but she saw the others’ shoulders settle to it the way they always did, and she watched his free hand keep the time against his thigh, and she understood it was a metronome for a clock none of them could hear and most of them had stopped noticing they obeyed.

“This,” Narin said, “is the part where the comments section divides into two armies, and both of them are wrong.”

She held up one finger.

“Army one says: *see, it’s all stolen, the Bible is just Babylonian myth with the names changed, your faith is a forgery*.” Her voice didn’t rise. “And to that I say: you have understood nothing. A forger copies to fool you. These writers re-wrote to *argue with you*. They kept the flood and changed why God sends it. They kept the tower and turned the gate of the gods into babble. They sat in the largest library on earth, in chains, in the language of their conqueror, and they read the conqueror’s account of how the world began — and they wrote it back the way they believed it actually was, and every single change is a *theological claim*. That is the opposite of theft. That is the most defiant act of authorship I know of in the ancient world. They were a conquered people and they kept their soul by re-writing the empire’s own story until it said what they needed it to say. You don’t lose your faith over that. You should be on your knees about that.”

Mira watched the faithful crew member's face — she watched Narin's, because Narin was the faithful one in this room, the living heir to both the people who got marched and the language they got marched in, and Narin's face was doing the thing the mouth would never say aloud. Not pride. Pride was too small. It was the face of a woman defending a grave from people who'd come to either rob it or photograph it, and finding, to her surprise, that the people in front of her had come to neither.

Edith had not touched the camera. Mira clocked that too. Edith's hands were folded over the lens cap like she was keeping it warm.

Narin held up a second finger.

"Army two," she said, "is the sneerers' twin. The believer who's so frightened of the library that he pretends the library isn't there. *No, no, there's no connection, it's a coincidence, the floods are just both floods.*" She shook her head. "No. The connection is real. It's mainstream. It's been the consensus among people who actually read the tablets for a hundred and fifty years. Hiding from it doesn't protect the faith. It just hands the whole conversation to army one." She turned the empty glass. "The genealogy is real. Genesis has a family tree, and the older branches of it are sitting in a Babylonian library a thousand years before the Hebrew was written. That is not the threat army two thinks it is. It's the inheritance."

It was Yusuf who broke. Not loudly. He'd been leaning further and further forward, elbows on knees, and now he scrubbed both hands down his face and made a sound that was almost a laugh and entirely not.

"You know what I sold," he said. To his own hands. "Not directly. You understand, never directly, that's the whole — there's always a layer. But I moved the paper for crates I knew, I *knew*, came up out of the south. And the ones with the gods on, the ones some idiot stamped *Anunnaki* on in the catalogue copy — those moved at a premium. Because *aliens*. Because somebody'd seen a video. The school tablets, the ration lists, the ones that actually say something — 'so-and-so, your servant, received this much barley' — those were filler. Bulk. You priced them by the kilo." He looked up, and his eyes were wet and angry. "I had it exactly backwards. The whole world

has it exactly backwards. The *aliens* are the cheap part. The aliens are the markup and the smokescreen and the thing that makes sure nobody who matters reads what the crate actually contains. The *real* one — the one where a man in chains rewrites the gate of the gods into babble because he won't let the empire keep his God — that's the priceless one. And I'd have sold it for filler."

Nobody filled the silence. They'd learned that too. Mira watched Frik's shoulder rise and fall, and Frik held, this time. He held, and that holding was its own kind of speech.

Narin looked at Yusuf for a long moment. When she spoke it was without softness and that was the kindness of it.

"Yes," she said. "You had it backwards. So did the men who put my country's beginning in sacks." She didn't look at Edith when she said *sacks*, and the not-looking was louder than a look. "The grift needs the question loud and the answer cheap. *Were they aliens* keeps the lights on. *What did a conquered scribe do with the enemy's library* — that one nobody can put a price on, because the moment you understand it, you stop wanting to *own* the tablet and start wanting to *read* it. And a thing that's read can't be sold to one buyer in a dark room." Her jaw set. "That's why somebody, somewhere, would much rather you watched the alien documentary."

She said *somebody, somewhere* the way you set a thing down on a table and step back from it. Mira watched it land. Naila's reed had stopped. Bashir's lips had stopped moving. The shape of the sentence had a shape they all recognised now — the loud stories pushed up into the light, the quiet ones gone soft and missing — and none of them touched it. You didn't touch it. You let it sit on the table and you went on.

"There's one more," Narin said, after a while, when the tea was cold. "And then I'll have given you the whole shelf and you can decide what it's worth to you."

"The law," Bashir said, because he'd seen it coming.

"The law." Narin almost smiled. "Hammurabi. Everyone's heard of him. Eye for eye, tooth for tooth. There's a great black stone with his code carved on it — it's in the Louvre, it got carried off as loot in

antiquity, the looting is older than any of us — and it says, if a man puts out another man's eye, they shall put out his eye. The talion. The world's most famous brutal little rule." She tipped her head. "And it's older than Moses. By centuries. And it's in Exodus, almost word for word. *Eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot.*"

Bashir leaned in. "But read what Hammurabi *actually* says, all of it. The talion in Babylon is for *aristocrats*. If a noble blinds a noble, eye for eye. If a noble blinds a commoner, he pays *silver*. If a noble's house collapses and kills the owner's son" — Bashir's eyes went bright with the awfulness of it — "they execute *the builder's son*. The son. For the father's bad work. Vicarious punishment. The price of justice depends on whose eye it was and how rich you are."

"And Exodus," Narin said, "takes the same rule — and it's careful, this is a real scholarly argument, whether it's borrowed direct or whether they're both drinking from the same legal world of the ancient Near East, I'll say *shared legal world* and a careful person should — Exodus takes that rule and *universalises* it. One law for the rich man and the poor man. And it forbids the thing Hammurabi does — you do not put a son to death for his father, *a person dies for his own sin*. It edits the empire's law toward equality and away from punishing the innocent. Same furniture. Re-arranged to argue."

"*Better*," said Frik, again, helplessly, and this time it was almost a benediction.

Mira had been watching the truck on and off the whole morning, the way the light moved on the long shape beside it. Now Jakobus came toward the awning, unhurried, the always-clean hanky going over the back of his neck, and he didn't come *in*. He stopped at the edge of the shade, where the gold light gave way, and he looked at the tray and the cold glasses and the cut reed in Naila's hand and the slab of bread no one had finished, and he said something — Mira read it off his mouth, the courtesy handful he'd taught himself, *good, this is good* in the local words, badly, with respect — and then he said the other thing, the thing he said, that wasn't a question because he never asked it as a question.

She read it off his lips and gave it to the room in sign so Narin would have it whole, hands slow and plain:

What's it for.

Not *who built it*. Not *is it true*. The made thing in his hand was a story now, not a tablet, and the question came down on it the same way it came down on everything — flat, patient, refusing every reading but the working one.

Jakobus didn't wait for the answer. He never did. He touched two fingers to the brim of nothing and went back to the lane, and the tune went with him.

The crew turned, all of them, to Narin.

Because that was the question, wasn't it. Not whose Lego, not which house, not even who handed it over in chains by the Kebar canal. They'd done all that. They knew, now, *what was on the shelf* and *what the exiles did with it* and that the doing wasn't theft and wasn't surrender but the third thing, the unnamed brave thing — survival by authorship, keeping your soul by re-writing the empire until it said your God instead of its own.

But *what is it for*. What is a story *for*, to the people who carry it home from the place that conquered them. Why do you bother to re-write the flood when you're a slave by a foreign canal and your temple is rubble and your God's house is inventory in someone else's storeroom. What does that get you. What does it *do*.

Mira watched Narin's face, and saw that this was the one Narin couldn't read off the clay — that no decipherer, no scholar, no man with a working eye for a made thing could read this answer off the object, because it didn't live in the object. It lived in the people who still said the words. And there was only one person in the awning who could give it.

Narin set down the cold glass. She looked at her uncle's house, and the lane, and the man no camera could hold standing in the white light beyond the shade.

"Tomorrow," she said, and stopped, and corrected herself, because there was no more tomorrow to hide behind. She looked at them.

"No," she said. "Now."

Chapter 17 — What Is It For

The kettle had gone cold. Yusuf noticed it the way you notice a thing your hands have been pretending to do — turning the little glass in its saucer, the tea inside it the colour of old brick, untouched. He'd poured it twenty minutes ago. Or an hour. The morning had stopped behaving like a thing with edges.

Narin had said *now*, and then she hadn't said anything else for a while, and nobody pushed her, because you don't push the person standing at the top of a stair they've been climbing their whole life. She'd sat back down. Mira had moved the sugar bowl out of the sun so it wouldn't sweat. Bashir had put his pen down. Even Frik had gone quiet, which for Frik was its own kind of effort, the small machine of him idling, ticking — a click of the tongue, a roll of one shoulder, contained.

Out beyond the awning's edge the white light stood on the lane like a poured thing, and in it, near the Beast, Jakobus was doing something with the water bag. The canvas one. He'd hung it off the wing mirror that morning and it had been weeping all day, that slow desert sweat the man swore by — *wet canvas drinks the wind, makes its own cold* — and you could see, even from here, the dark patch on the dust beneath it where it had been spending itself drop by drop to keep the water inside cool enough to be a kindness. He had his sleeves rolled. He wasn't looking in at them. He never looked in when the talk turned to the clay. It wasn't his to look at, and he knew it, and Yusuf had watched him *practise* not-looking the way other men practise not-flinching.

"He should hear this," Yusuf said. He hadn't planned to.

Narin's eyes came up.

"It's his question," Yusuf said. "*What is it for.* He's the one who keeps asking it." He felt the heat of his own face. "I just mean — it feels wrong, him out there."

Mira's hands moved. Bashir, without looking, voiced it under his breath, the habit they'd all fallen into so she was never the only one who'd missed a thing: *He stays out for a reason.*

"He stays out so the doors aren't his," Narin said. She said it gently. "If I want him, I go to him. That's the deal. He told me on the first night. He said —" she turned the cold glass once "— he said, *I open the road, you say where it goes.* So." She set the glass down. "This one doesn't go to him. He already knows that. Look at him."

Yusuf looked.

The man wasn't waiting to be invited. That was the thing the surveillance vans never managed to capture, the thing the network's clean-handed people would put in a file under *no clear read* — that Jakobus standing apart wasn't a man excluded. It was a man on guard at a door he'd decided, on purpose, not to walk through. He had no business with what a story meant to the people who said it. He'd told them as much, days ago, squatting in front of VA 243's photograph with that cayenne tin balanced on his knee: *I can tell you what a made thing is for. I can't tell you what it means to pray to.*

"All right," Yusuf said, and sat back, and let the tea go cold for good.

Narin began the way she'd begun everything — sideways, through somebody else's hands.

"In 1872," she said, "a man named George Smith was in the basement of the British Museum, where some of you have been," and she nodded at the memory of the cold room, the steel shelving, the cradle of grey foam, "going through the tablets that came out of Nineveh. Ashurbanipal's library. Smith taught himself the script. He'd been a banknote engraver — he had the eye for tiny marks. And he's reading along, fragment by fragment, and he hits a line about a ship grounding on a mountain. A man sends out a dove. The dove comes back. He sends a raven. The raven doesn't."

Bashir's head had tipped. Yusuf watched the language-part of him

lean toward it like a plant toward a window.

“And the story goes,” Narin said, “that George Smith stood up in that basement and started taking his clothes off.”

Frik laughed — a single bright bark of it, surprised out of him.

“It’s probably exaggerated,” Narin said, allowing herself the smallest smile. “He got excited. He ran around the room. He was the first person in two and a half thousand years to read that flood, in the language it was written in, and to understand what he was holding. He gave a lecture. The Prime Minister came. People wept. They thought — some of them — that he’d *proved* the Bible. Found the flood in the dirt.”

She let that sit.

“He hadn’t found the flood in the Bible,” she said. “He’d found one that was older.”

The awning held very still. Out on the lane the water bag wept.

“A thousand years older, at least,” Narin said. “The version Smith read is woven into Gilgamesh, and the flood that’s *inside* Gilgamesh is older than that again — Atrahasis, the one we’ve been living in all week. A man warned by his god. A boat sealed with pitch. The waters. The birds. The grounding on a mountain. The sacrifice when it’s over, and the gods gathering over the smoke like —” she paused, and her mouth did something complicated “— Smith translated it himself: *the gods gathered like flies over the offering*. Because they were starving. Because the flood had killed the people who fed them and they’d nearly starved themselves out of pure rage.”

“That’s not in Genesis,” Naila said. It was the first she’d spoken in an hour. She’d been writing — not words, Yusuf saw, but the *shape* of something, columns, a ledger drawn in pencil on the back of a permit form. “The flies. The starving. None of that’s in Genesis.”

“No.”

“Because Genesis took it out.”

“Because Genesis,” Narin said, “*argued* with it.”

This was the place Yusuf had been afraid of all week without naming it.

He could name it now. Sitting under a borrowed awning in the Erbil heat, with the citadel up on its mound behind them holding seven thousand years of people who'd never once needed a spaceship to be remarkable — he could finally name what had been hollow in him since the night the rabbit-hole had opened under his ordinary life and let him fall, gratefully, out of it.

He'd needed the aliens to be real.

Not the way a child needs a story. The way a drowning man needs the thing his hand closes on to be a rope and not a snake. His life before this — the logistics desk, the manifests, the crates with the wrong paperwork that he'd learned not to look inside, the slow knowledge that he'd been a clean pair of hands on a dirty river — that life had been a corridor with no doors. And then the videos, the diagrams, Nibiru's long ellipse, the gold mines, the gods who came down and made us in a lab, and oh, the *relief* of it. Because if that were true, then nothing was small. Then the universe had bothered. Then he, Yusuf, who had spent his good years carrying other men's loot down to the sea, was not an accident in a corridor but a designed thing, wanted, on purpose, by someone who'd crossed the dark to make him.

That was the whole engine of it. He understood that now, watching the water bag weep. The alien story flattered you. It said: *you were wanted*.

And the real one didn't.

"Atrahasis," Narin said, "doesn't start with a flood. It starts with a strike."

She'd turned to a tablet line in her notebook, the transliteration in her own neat hand, and Bashir's lips were already moving over it before she read it.

"The gods used to do the labour themselves," she said. "The lesser gods — the Igigi. Digging the rivers. Hauling the baskets of earth. The Tigris and the Euphrates, dug by hand, by gods, for three thousand six hundred years —" she looked at Naila "— a *sar*, yes, a number, a big round base-sixty number, not an orbit of anything —"

"*The sar is the orbit—*" Frik said, and then his whole face folded with the effort of catching it, and he got the rest out himself, fast, dragging it back by the collar, "*—is a numeral. It's a numeral. Sixty squared. It's a numeral.*" He pressed two fingers hard to his sternum. "Sorry. It's a numeral."

"It's a numeral," Naila agreed, mild, and tapped her pencil twice on her column of sixties, and that was the whole of it — no fuss, no one looking at him, the thing said and corrected and let go, and Frik breathed out.

"For three thousand six hundred years they hauled the baskets," Narin went on, as if nothing had snagged, because to her nothing had. "And then they'd had enough. They burned their tools. They surrounded the house of the chief god in the middle of the night with torches. A strike. A mutiny in heaven. And the gods up in the assembly are *frightened* — that's the astonishing thing, the gods are scared of the work stopping — and they hold a council, and someone says: we'll make a replacement. A thing to carry the baskets so we don't have to."

She turned the page.

"They kill a god to do it. A god who has — the text says — *planning*, intelligence, *ēmu*. They kill him, and they mix his blood and his mind into clay, and the womb-goddess pinches off fourteen pieces, and they're left to ripen, and out come people. Made of dead-god's-blood and river-mud. And the very first thing the new people are *for* —"

"To carry the baskets," Yusuf said. His voice came out rougher than he meant.

"To carry the baskets," Narin said. "To bear the gods' toil. So the gods could rest." She looked at him, and there was no cruelty in it at all, none, only a terrible level kindness, the kindness of a person handing you the true weight of a thing because the false one was breaking your back worse. "That's what we were made for, in the oldest story this part of the world ever told about itself. Not to be loved. Not to be wanted. To *work*, so that someone higher up didn't have to."

The lane was quiet. The bag wept.

“And it gets worse,” Narin said softly, “or better, depending. Because the people multiply, and they’re loud, and the noise of all that human labour and life keeps the chief god awake. So he sends plagues. Then a drought. Then the famine — and there are lines, broken lines, that are almost too much to read, about mothers, about what hunger does in a city. And when none of it quiets us, he sends the flood. Not because we’d sinned. There’s no sin in it. We were just — *too many*. Too loud. An infestation in the made world. He floods us the way you’d fumigate a house.”

She closed the notebook.

“That,” she said, “is the story Sitchin found. The clay. The made workers. The dead god’s blood. The rebellion of the ones who were tired of digging. He found the real, ancient, gorgeous, *brutal* thing — and he kept the whole skeleton of it. He just couldn’t bear what it was *for*. So he swapped the gods for astronauts, and the baskets of earth for gold mines, and the clay for a splice in a lab. He took the bleakest, bravest answer a working people ever gave to the question *why does my back hurt and why do I serve and why will I die* — and he turned it into a flattering bedtime story about being special.”

Yusuf had to look away from her. He looked at the citadel.

He thought about the manifests. He thought about a crate he’d signed off on in 2004 with a customs stamp that wasn’t real and a Sumerian word inside it he hadn’t known then and knew now. He thought about the corridor with no doors and how the alien story had felt like a door and how it had really been a mirror, all along, just a mirror, angled up at the stars so he wouldn’t have to see his own hands in it.

“It’s smaller,” he said. He hadn’t meant to speak. “The real one. It makes us — smaller.”

Narin didn’t rush to comfort him.

It was Bashir who spoke, and Bashir spoke to the clay, the way he always did when the human thing was too near to say to a face.

“There’s a pun,” Bashir said.

Everyone turned.

“In another piece of it — the Enki and Ninhursag one, the garden, Enki eats the plants he shouldn’t, and he gets sick, eight parts of him, eight organs, and the goddess heals each one, and she makes a little goddess for each cure. And for the rib —” his hands had come up, holding the air “— the Sumerian word for rib is *ti*. And the word for *to make live* is also *ti*. So the goddess of the rib is *Nin-ti*. Lady of the Rib. And Lady-Who-Makes-Live. The same word. You can’t tell them apart. It’s a joke, it’s a real joke, in Sumerian, four thousand years ago, a healer’s joke about how the bone and the life are the same sound —”

He stopped. His eyes were very bright.

“And it’s only in Sumerian,” he said. “You translate it into Hebrew and the pun dies, the bone and the life come apart, you can’t keep them in one word anymore. But it leaves a *fossil*. The woman made from the man’s rib. The woman who’s the mother of all living. The rib, and the making-alive, in the same person — that’s a Sumerian pun that fell into Hebrew and couldn’t bring its own joke with it, so the joke turned into a story instead.” He laughed, helpless with it. “Eve. *Hawwah*. Mother of all living. Made from a rib. It’s a four-thousand-year-old pun you can still feel under the floorboards if you know both tongues. *That’s* a decode. That’s what a real one feels like. Not a star chart. A joke that outlived the language it was funny in.”

Frik made a sound — not a tic this time, Yusuf thought, just a sound a person makes — and put his hand over his mouth.

Mira had been watching all their faces, turning, the way she did, reading the room the way the rest of them read the page. Now her hands started, and this time it was Narin, oddly — Narin who’d been picking up the badly-learned signs all week — who began to voice it, and then stopped, because the sign was one she didn’t have. Mira slowed it. Spelled it. Yusuf caught the shapes but not the meaning.

Bashir caught it. “She says,” he said carefully, watching Mira’s face to be corrected, “*so the man who needed it to be aliens* —” Mira nodded, kept going “— *was reaching for the thing the story already had*. The wonder. He just reached past it. Because the real one —”

Mira finished it herself, slowly, so they’d all be inside the same beat: a sign Yusuf did know, that they’d all learned the first day, the open hand turned to the heart and out again — *give* — and then she

touched her own chest, and then she pointed, gently, deliberately, at Yusuf.

The real one asks more of you.

Nobody had told her to look at him. She'd just read it off his face, the way she read everything, the thing his mouth wouldn't say — that the let-go was happening right now, under the awning, in the cold tea and the weeping bag, and that it hurt exactly as much as losing a religion, because in a way it was one.

Yusuf put the back of his wrist to his eyes and made a noise that was meant to be a laugh.

"It's a better story," he said, into his wrist. "Isn't it. It's the better one. I just —" He breathed. "I just liked being wanted."

"I know," Narin said. And then, very quietly, because she was the only one of them who'd earned the right to: "Everybody does. That's the whole engine of it. That's why it sells."

She let him have a minute. They all did. Edith — who hadn't lifted the camera in two days, who had it in the bag at her feet with the lens cap on, on purpose, a discipline she wore now like a healed bone — reached over and put her hand flat on the table near Yusuf's, not on it, near it, and left it there.

Then Naila said, into the quiet, in her flat clear voice that never decorated anything: "But that's not the answer to his question."

Heads turned.

"Whose," Bashir said.

"Jakobus's. *What is it for.*" Naila tapped the ledger she'd been drawing, the columns of sixties. "We just answered what the *Babylonian* one was for. We were made to carry baskets so the gods could sleep. Fine. That's clear. That's in the clay, you can read it off the object. But Narin —" she turned, the whole of her attention swinging round like a beam "— you said *now*. When he asked. You said it was the one you couldn't read off the clay. So that wasn't the question." She frowned, working it. "The question is what the *re-written* one is for. The one the exiles made. Why bother. You're a slave by a canal,

your temple's rubble, your God's furniture is somebody's inventory — Yusuf knows about inventory —" a small dry beat that startled a wet laugh out of him "— and you take the empire's bleakest story about being mud-slaves, and you don't just keep it and you don't just throw it away, you *re-write* it, line by line, you change why the flood comes and you change what we're made of and you change what we're *for*. That's a colossal amount of work. To do, in chains. For nothing you can sell. *What is it for.*"

She set the pencil down.

"That one's not on the object," she said. "I checked. I read the whole shape of it three times. It's not in the clay and it's not in the Hebrew either, not as a sentence. It's only in the people who still say it." She looked at Narin, and her voice didn't soften, because Naila's voice didn't, but something in her face opened a half-inch, which from Naila was an embrace. "So it's yours. You're the only one here who carries it home from the place that conquered them."

Mira was already watching Narin's hands, Narin's mouth, Narin's eyes — reading her before she spoke, the way you read weather coming over a ridge.

And Yusuf, who had just put down the heaviest thing he'd ever carried, found he was leaning in for the next one.

Narin was quiet a long moment. When she spoke it wasn't to any of them, not at first. She was looking out at the lane, at the white light, at the man in it who would never ask her this and would never be able to answer it, who could squat in front of any made thing on the earth and tell you what it was *for* — a basket, a boat, a battery-jar with the wrong wiring, a king kneeling before his god in a little carved seal — and who'd stopped, deliberately, at the one door he couldn't open, and stood his guard there in the heat so it could stay hers.

"The Babylonian flood," Narin said slowly, "comes because we're noise. Because we're too many and too loud and the god can't sleep. We're vermin, and he fumigates."

She turned back to them.

"And the exiles, sitting in that library, *reading that* — in the city that had just done to them exactly what the god did to those people, drowned them, scattered them, smoked them out of their own house

— they took the same flood, and they made one change that changes everything.” She wasn’t lecturing. Her voice had gone very low and even. “In their version, the flood doesn’t come because we’re loud. It comes because we’re *cruel*. Because the earth was *filled with violence*. They put a *reason* in it. A moral reason. They said: the universe is not a landlord with a noise complaint. It’s a court. And then — this is the part —” and here, just here, her hand pressed flat to the table, the same gesture Mira had made, *give* “— they wrote in a promise. The bow in the cloud. *Never again*. The god who flooded the world *binds himself*. Puts down his weapon. Hangs it in the sky where everyone can see it, and swears off. The Babylonian gods never swear off anything. They just regret it over the smoke, like flies.”

She breathed.

“That’s what it’s for,” she said. “That’s what a conquered slave by a foreign canal gets out of re-writing the empire’s own myth in the empire’s own language. You take their story that says *you are mud, made to serve, and your suffering is just noise* — and you re-author it until it says *you are made in the image, not the labour; your suffering is seen, not ignored; and even the one who could drown you has bound himself never to again*. You don’t win your freedom that way. You don’t get your temple back. You get to keep your *soul*. You get to walk into exile still able to tell your children that the world has a floor under it. That’s worth more than the temple. The temple they can take. *That* they can’t carry off in a crate.”

Edith’s hand had closed, very gently, over Yusuf’s.

“It’s not proof of anything,” Narin said, level, the scalpel never far. “I’m not telling you the bow is real or the flood happened or any of it. I’m a scholar; I can tell you when the texts were written and how and from what. I can’t tell you what’s true the way you mean true. That’s not the clay’s job and it’s not mine.” She looked at each of them. “But you asked what it’s *for*. And what a story is for, to the people who carry it home from the place that broke them — that I can tell you. Because my people did exactly this, in exactly that city, and we’re still here, saying the words, after the empire that conquered us turned to dust and got sold off in pieces.” A breath. “Twice. Sold off twice.”

The 2003 of it hung there, unspoken and entire, and nobody touched

it.

Out on the lane, the man near the truck reached up and unhooked the water bag from the wing mirror, weighed it in his hand, found it cool, and brought it to his mouth. Drank. Hung it back to keep weeping. He did not look in at them. He didn't need to. He'd asked the only question he had to ask, days ago, and then he'd gone and stood where it could be answered by the right person, and waited, and now it had been, and he couldn't have read a word of it off the clay if he'd stared at it for a hundred years.

Yusuf wiped his face properly this time, with the heel of his hand, and laughed, and it came out clean.

"So the better door," he said. "The human one."

"Bigger room," Naila said, not looking up from her ledger.

Bashir was already turning his pen over, already reaching for the next line of clay, hungry — and through the awning's edge, in the lane, a car they didn't recognise slowed at the top of the rise, idled, and did not come down.

Edith saw it first. Her hand left Yusuf's and went, by old reflex, toward the bag at her feet — and then stopped, and stayed empty, open, ready to ask before it took anything at all.

Chapter 18 — The Wink

Edith had photographed a hundred cars that did not come down a road. She knew the grammar of it. A car that meant to arrive committed to the descent; a car that meant to *watch* paused at the lip of the slope, where it could see the whole awning and the truck and the lane in one frame, where it could leave faster than it came.

This one paused.

She did not lift the camera. That was the discipline now, the thing she had been building rib by rib all month — the hand going to the bag by reflex and then *stopping*, lying open and empty on her own knee. A month ago she'd have had the long lens on the windscreen before she'd finished thinking about it, would have had the plate, the driver's silhouette, the second man's elbow on the door. A month ago she'd have called that *witnessing*. She'd called a lot of things witnessing.

"Don't," she said, very quietly, to nobody, and meant *me*.

Yusuf had stopped laughing. He read money, and money read like a man, and the man in the passenger seat of a car that idled at the top of a rise in the Nineveh plain in the long gold of the afternoon was the kind of man Yusuf had once arranged hotels for. He knew the shoulders. He knew the way a man sat when the work was somebody else's hands but the watching was his.

"That's a look-and-go," Yusuf said. "Somebody's confirming a location."

Narin did not turn around. She was rolling the tablet — the school-text, the one with the beer rations and the line about *Dubsiga, your servant* that Bashir had laughed out loud at three days ago — back

into its acid-free tissue with the unbothered hands of a woman who had spent twenty years putting fragile things back into boxes while the world did its worst around her.

“Then it is confirmed,” she said. “Now we move it before they decide they are confident.”

Out on the lane the man at the truck did not look up. He was crouched at the front wheel with the cayenne tin balanced on his knee and a strip of inner tube in his teeth, doing something to a valve that he had decided was more urgent than the car at the top of the rise. He had, in fact, decided this with the precise timing of a man who had clocked the car before any of them, and had then chosen — visibly, lazily, in full view — to look at a valve instead. He hung the weeping water bag back on the mirror. The wet canvas caught the light. From the rise it would read as *peasant; truck; nothing*. That was, Edith understood, the entire point.

The thing she had learned to call *the win* did not look like a win.

It looked like a school gymnasium in the lower town of Erbil with bad fluorescent light and a folding table and four people from the Directorate of Antiquities of the Kurdistan Region — two women, two men, one of them not yet thirty and visibly the smartest person in any room he ever entered — and a list. The list was the win. The list was forty-one inventory numbers, and against thirty of them somebody had handwritten a provenance and a museum and a date, and against eleven of them somebody had written *EN ROUTE / RECOVERED / VERIFY*.

Narin’s crew — and it was, by now, plainly *Narin’s* crew, the way a thing becomes someone’s not by claiming it but by being the one who knows what it’s for — had handed over a notebook, a card of microSD, and a single afternoon’s worth of reading that turned a crate the network had been moving as *Sumerian astronomical archive (UN-TRANSLATED)* — *significant* into a crate that the verify-column now described, in dry Kurdish bureaucratic shorthand, as *administrative; barley; lexical; school exercise*.

That was the whole murder. Not a gunfight. A reclassification.

“You understand what you have done,” the young one said, the smart

one, in English, because Bashir had switched them into English so the foreigners could follow and then immediately regretted the courtesy because it cost the man some of his music. “You have made it worthless.”

“We have made it *cheap*,” Narin said. “Which is the only thing that has ever protected anything in this country. The expensive things leave. The cheap things stay home and get read by students.”

Edith had her camera on the table, lens-down, both hands flat on either side of it like a woman keeping a lid on a pot. She had asked. She had asked the young man and the two women and the older man, in turn, through Bashir, in three languages, the same flat question: *may I photograph the list, not your faces, only the list, and only if it helps and never if it hurts*. The older woman had looked at her for a long time. The older woman had been in Mosul in 2014 when the network’s predecessors had filmed themselves taking sledgehammers to the museum there for a different streaming audience, and she knew exactly what a camera was for, and she had said: *the numbers. Not the room*.

So Edith shot the numbers and not the room. Forty-one of them, in dry light, no faces, no flag, no folding table, no anguish. A document. It was the best photograph she had taken in nine years and she would never sell it and that was, she had begun to suspect, the same fact.

The streaming-doc people heard about the reclassification on a Tuesday.

Yusuf heard about *them* hearing about it, because Yusuf still had two numbers in his phone from the wrong years and one of them texted him a single line — *the Mesopotamia ep is going dark, segment 4 cut, you anywhere near this?* — and Yusuf sat very still under the awning for about a minute and then put the phone face-down on the cloth and pressed his palm on top of it like Edith pressing her lens to the table, like the whole crew had become a set of people who knew what to do with the things in their hands now, which was mostly to leave them where they were.

“Segment four,” he said. “That’s the gold one.”

Naila looked up from her ledger. She had been doing what she did,

which was the only honest kind of arithmetic in the whole business — converting the network's grey-market price-sheet into base-ten and then watching the numbers refuse to be astronomy. "The gold-mining one," she said. "The visitors-came-for-the-gold one." Her mouth did a small flat thing that was, on Naila, a grin. "It's the same gold every time. African gold, anunnaki gold. It's always the gold, with these people. They cannot imagine someone coming a very long way for anything but gold, because gold is the only reason *they* would come."

"That," said Bashir, delighted, pen in the air, "is the most savage sentence anyone has said this entire month and you said it about *accountancy*."

"It is accountancy," Naila said. "The myth is the markup. I've shown you the spreadsheet."

She had. Twice. The seam of the whole thing, laid out in a column: a tablet read as *school text* sells for the price of a school text; the *same tablet* photographed badly, lit blue, captioned *DECODE THE ANUNNAKI STAR MAP THEY DON'T WANT YOU TO SEE*, and then *never actually translated*, sells for forty times that — and, crucially, gets read by no one who would ever notice it says *Dubsiga, your servant, two measures of barley*. The woo was not a side-effect. The woo was the *packaging*. Keep the question loud, keep the tablet untranslated, keep it moving. A translated tablet is just a tablet. A *mystery* is a commodity.

"So the doc dies because the tablet got read," Yusuf said. He took his hand off the phone. He looked, Edith thought, like a man who had walked a long way to a door he was sure led outside, and opened it, and found the actual sky on the other side, bigger than the painted one he'd been heading for, and was still standing in the doorway adjusting his eyes.

"Segment four dies," Narin corrected, gently, because she corrected everyone gently and absolutely, "because southern Iraq filed an injunction about chain-of-custody and the production company's lawyers looked at the inventory and decided the *story* was now a liability instead of an asset. The tablet did not kill it. *The provenance* killed it. People keep wanting the magic to be the reading." She tapped the rolled tissue bundle. "The reading is wonderful. But the

thing that saved this object is paperwork.”

It was Mira who saw the second thing, the larger thing, the thing none of their mouths had said.

She had been watching Narin’s face for three days — not the tablets, *the face*, the way Narin’s face did one thing when she talked about the Flood and a completely different thing when she talked about the Exile, the way a particular stillness came over the lower half of her face whenever the conversation got near the genealogy, near the awful and beautiful fact at the centre of everything: that the oldest stories in the Bible her people had carried out of Nineveh and Babylon, the Flood and the garden and the tower, were in conversation with stories a thousand years older, written down on the very clay they were now arguing over, and that the *route* of that conversation ran straight through the Babylonian Exile — through the conquest, through the deportation, through the worst thing that ever happened to her people’s ancestors becoming the soil in which the words took their final root.

Mira had read it on her without a word being said. And now she signed it, badly, lovingly, her hands finding the shapes the crew had been teaching each other all month — *you. don’t. say. it. out loud* — and pointed two fingers gently at Narin, and waited.

The crew went quiet. They had learned, finally, this month, to go quiet *for* Mira and not *around* her — to let her finish, to not talk over the slow careful sentence with three faster ones, because the entire month she had been talked over by everyone including herself and the worst of it was how normal it had felt, how *expected*, and then one afternoon Bashir had simply stopped mid-word with his hand still up and turned to watch her hands and said *go on, finish*, and something had shifted in the room that nobody narrated.

Narin watched the hands. Mira repeated it. *You read the clay out loud all day. The genealogy. You don’t read that one out loud.*

Bashir started to translate it and Narin lifted one finger — *I have it* — because of course she had it, because she read faces too, everyone in her family read faces, you did not survive a minority on the Nineveh plain without reading faces, and she sat with it for a moment under

the awning with the kettle ticking and the diesel-and-dust smell and the man outside doing nothing to a valve.

“No,” she said at last. “I don’t read that one out loud.”

She turned the rolled tissue over once in her hands.

“Because the West has only ever known two ways to hold this,” she said. “One: *the Bible is true and unique and dropped out of the sky, and these older clay versions are demonic counterfeits or coincidence.* Two: *the Bible has older sources, therefore the Bible is a fraud, a plagiarism, a fairy tale for the gullible, and we clever people have caught it out.* And both of those are the same insult wearing different hats. Both of them think the only thing a story can do is *be true or be stolen.*” Her face did the thing Mira had been watching for three days. “My people did a third thing. My people *did the third thing for a living.*”

She set the bundle down.

“Genesis knows the older stories. It is not hiding it. It is *arguing* with them. The Babylonians say the world was made when a god split a goddess’s corpse like a fish — combat, blood, the strong god butchers the chaos and props the sky on her ribs. And the Hebrew writer takes that whole world of furniture, the *tehom*, the deep, the cognate of her very name, and builds a creation where there is no fight at all. No corpse. No butchery. A *word*. ‘Let there be.’ The Babylonians say humans were kneaded out of clay and a murdered god’s blood to *carry the gods’ baskets* — made to toil, made to die, slaves with a divine spark for a back. And the Hebrew writer keeps the clay — keeps the dust, *you are dust* — and changes the *one thing that matters*. Not slaves. *Image*. The same clay. A completely different verdict on what the clay is *for*.”

The kettle ticked.

“That is not theft,” Narin said. “That is the bravest thing a conquered people ever did. They were marched a thousand miles into the empire that destroyed them, sat down in the shadow of its ziggurats and its myths and its priests, and instead of breaking, they took the empire’s own creation story and rewrote it into an argument *against* the empire. *You* say we are slaves of the gods? We are the image of God. *You* say the world is a battlefield? The world is a sentence, spoken

on purpose, called good. They out-wrote Babylon *in Babylon*. With Babylon's own bricks." She looked at her own hands. "How could I read that out loud as if it were a *catch*? As if I had *gotten one over* on my own grandmother? It is the most sophisticated act of survival in human literature and the West keeps trying to make it into either a magic trick or a forgery, because the West cannot conceive of a third thing, which is a *people refusing to die by taking the worst thing that ever happened to them and turning it into scripture.*"

Nobody touched it. They had learned that too.

After a while Frik — who had been very still, who had a tic going in his left shoulder that the crew no longer pretended not to see and no longer made into a problem — said, in the flat blurted voice that came when something was too true to be sat on:

"They didn't lose."

Everyone looked at him.

"The Babylonians," Frik said, and his hand jumped once, and he let it. "Conquered them. Burned the temple. *Won.*" The shoulder again. "But we don't read *Enuma Elish* on Sunday. They read—" and here the echolalia caught Narin's own word and threw it back, helplessly, exactly, "*—image. Image. Image.*"

It was the truest thing said under the awning all month and it had come out sideways, the way the truest things came out of Frik, the involuntary verdict that nobody could un-say or paint over, and Narin looked at him with the particular respect she gave the tablets.

"Yes," she said. "That is exactly it. The empire turned to dust. The argument with the empire is still being read in a thousand languages this morning." She almost smiled. "That is the joke at the bottom of everything. Nobody intended it. But it's there."

So where, then, was the hole. The Why Files always had a hole, and Bashir — who loved holes, who had spent a whole career living in the gaps between languages where the puns lived — went looking for it, because a story that closes is a story you don't trust.

"All right," he said. "Then what's still open. Genuinely. Not woo. Not aliens — the aliens are dead, we killed them in the clay, *nibiru* is

Jupiter and the *sar* is a number and poor Mr. Dubsiga got his desk turned into a starship. Not that. What's the thing we *honestly don't know*."

Narin thought about it properly. That was the other thing about her — she did not pretend to certainties she didn't have, which was the rarest quality in anyone the crew had met since the Beast first rolled north.

"The *how*," she said. "We know the Hebrew primeval history is in dialogue with Mesopotamian literature. That's not a guess, that's a library. We know the Flood, the garden, the tower, the great long-lived ancestors, the *clay*, all have older cousins in the cuneiform. We know the Exile is the great pressure-cooker where so much of it got finalised. That much is mainstream, bulletproof, you can read the tablets yourself, George Smith stood up in 1872 and read a Babylonian flood off a broken tablet to a room full of Victorians who very nearly fainted, it is *done*."

"But," said Yusuf.

"But the *exact mechanism*. The wiring. *Who* sat *where*, with *which* tablet, *when*, hearing it told *how*, and decided to keep the dust and change the verdict. Whether a Judean scribe read Akkadian in a Babylonian school, or whether it came down through generations of oral telling, or some braid of both that we will never untangle because the looms are gone. *That* we do not have. The fact of the genealogy — solid. The blood-vessels of it — gone." She spread her hands. "The connections are real and the details are mostly lost. That is the honest position. Anybody who tells you they know the precise channel is selling you something. And anybody who tells you the channel isn't *there* hasn't read the tablets."

"That's the hole," Bashir said, satisfied, settling back.

"That's the hole," Narin agreed. "And it is a *good* hole. It is a hole you can spend your life in and come out richer. It is not a hole you fill with a spaceship."

The car at the top of the rise had gone, at some point. Edith hadn't seen it leave and was glad, in a new way, not to have a photograph of its leaving.

There was a different thing she did have, though it was not on any card and never would be, because she'd had the lens at her hip when it happened and had — deliberately, with a small ache that she understood now to be the correct ache — not raised it.

Out on the lane, the man from the truck had gone, an hour ago, up the slope to where Narin's uncle had set a second awning by the wall, a low stretched square of canvas the colour of weak tea, and the two of them had sat down on a pair of plastic chairs that did not match, and the uncle had made tea in the small loud way of a man who has made tea ten thousand times, and they had passed *one glass*. One small clear glass of orange tea, back and forth, the way the man had once passed a cup in a place none of them had been, the way the uncle passed it to anyone he decided was *people*. They had not talked much. The man did not have the words; the uncle did not have the man's. They had sat in the long gold light at the edge of the Nineveh plain, two men who could not read a single sign off the clay, passing one glass, while the people who *could* read it argued under the lower awning about how the world had taught itself to write.

Edith had watched it for a full minute through nothing but her own eyes. It was the most photographable thing she had seen in nine years and she had let it go through her and out the other side and kept it the only place a thing like that survives, which is not a card. The network's people, wherever they'd been parked with their good glass, had never gotten a frame of him either. Three weeks of watching and the man had never once been still in the open with his face up at the right moment. The light loved him and the lens never landed.

When he came back down the slope he had the cayenne tin out and a small fold of the always-clean hanky pressed to a nick on his thumb from the valve, and he didn't come in under the awning — he stopped at the edge, in the lane, where the story's *meaning* couldn't reach him and he didn't want it to.

"We can run them to Erbil at first light," he said. To Narin. Only to Narin. *The locals own the win and the win is hers*. "The crate goes with your directorate. We're just the truck." A beat. "*Spas*," he said, in Kurdish, badly, the courtesy handful, and the uncle behind him barked a laugh at the accent and said something back that made even Narin smile.

Then he went to check the water bag again, though it did not need checking, and the camera did not follow him, because the camera belonged to the crew, and the crew were under the awning, where the last of the light was going amber on the rolled white bundle of a four-thousand-year-old worksheet about barley.

Narin picked it up. She held it the way you hold the thing itself and not the price of the thing.

“Roll the tape,” Bashir said, because someone had to, and they were all a little drunk on tea and survival.

“There’s no tape,” Naila said, not looking up. “There never was a tape. There was clay.” She closed her ledger. “Which is better. Tape rots in fifty years. We’ve still got the homework of a man who was bad at fractions in 1700 BC.”

And the question hung there in the amber light, unanswered, allowed to stay unanswered — not *were they aliens*, that was dead and buried in the original language, but the bigger one, the one with the room in it: *what were they for, the princely offspring, the made-from-clay, and who taught Genesis to bake its bricks the Babylonian way, and whose hand* — somewhere, off every lens, in some quiet office where the loud tablets got promoted and the quiet ones disappeared — *had been deciding for years which of these stories the world was allowed to hear at all.*

Nobody answered. That was the whole art of it.

Out past the awning, southern of here, beyond the checkpoints and the longing and the line on the map, the real cradle lay in the dusk — Ur, Uruk, Eridu, the mounds where writing was born — in the hands of the people who lived there now.

Narin set the bundle down and reached for the kettle.

“Tea,” she said. “And then I’ll show you the one with the joke in it. It only works in Sumerian.”

Chapter 19 — The Line in the Clay

The last room in the archive did not announce itself. It had no number on the door, only a strip of masking tape with a hand-written shelf code, and a key that Huda turned twice because the lock was old and the building older.

Inside: a long table under fluorescent tubes, two of which had given up. Steel shelving down both walls. The smell Naila had been chasing the whole trip — baked earth, dust, the faint chemical sweetness of consolidant — concentrated here into something almost edible. She breathed it in through her mouth so she could taste it.

“Storage,” Huda said. “The boring word for it. Things that are not on display and may never be. Things waiting for someone with time.”

“And we are the someone with time,” Omar said, already moving, already touching the edge of a shelf and then not touching it because Huda had looked at him.

“You are the someone with permission,” Huda corrected. “For three hours.”

Mira had her notebook out before she had a chair. Lens stood in the doorway with the camera at his hip, not raised. He had not raised it much in days now, and nobody had asked him to. Naila had noticed. She noticed the camera the way she noticed weather — a pressure that came and went.

Huda crossed to a shelf and pulled, with both hands and great care, a shallow tray. She set it on the table on a square of grey foam.

“This,” she said, “is not in any catalogue you have read.”

The streaming crew, four cities and three weeks ago, had ended their Anunnaki segment standing under Room 55's lights, and the host had said the line they all said: *the truth is written in stone, if only they'd let us read it*. He had meant it as a flourish. Naila had carried it around like a pebble in a shoe ever since, because it was so nearly true and so completely wrong. The truth was written. Nobody was hiding it. It was simply written in a language that took eleven years to learn to read with your eyes and longer to read, as she did, with the pads of her fingers across the back of a museum photograph because the front was too precious to press.

The official version was clean and Naila respected it the way she respected a good lock. There was no twelfth planet. *Nibiru* meant *crossing-point* and the crossing-point was Jupiter, the largest light that wandered, visible most clear nights to anyone with the patience to look up. The Anunnaki were *the princely offspring* — gods, the children of An, the sky — and they sat on thrones in the seals, not in cockpits. The famous “solar system” on VA 243 was a star-cluster and a dedication to a man named Dubsiga, *may his god protect him*, the ancient equivalent of a brass plate by a door. The 3,600 that Sitchin had spent a lifetime building into an orbit was a *šar*, a numeral, base-sixty doing what base-sixty had always done. All of it was demolished, properly, by people who loved the texts. Naila revered the demolition. She had read it twice.

What she could not stop thinking about was what the demolition stopped at.

It stopped at *the aliens aren't real*, dusted its hands, and walked out of the room. And on its way out it walked straight past the stranger thing, the thing sitting here in a tray on grey foam, which was that the most-read book on the planet had a grandfather in this language, and the grandfather was older by a thousand years.

The tablet was a fragment. Less than half. The break ran on a diagonal, top-right to bottom-left, the clay shearing where it had wanted to shear, and Naila felt the old pull to apologise to it.

"Atrahasis," Huda said. "Or a piece of a school-copy of it. A student's hand, I think. Look at the wedges."

Mira leaned in. "They're—"

"Crowded. Yes. The line-spacing collapses at the right margin every time. He ran out of room and would not start a new line." Huda's mouth did something dry. "A boy who could not plan ahead. Three thousand seven hundred years ago, in Nippur or near it, and he could not plan ahead, and his teacher made him copy this anyway."

Naila put her fingertips just above the surface, not on it, the way you hold your hand near a fire to find the edge of its heat.

"May I read?"

Huda set a photograph beside the tray — a raking-light image, the wedges thrown into hard shadow — and slid it to her. "Read the photograph. Touch the photograph."

Naila read the photograph with her fingers.

The wedges resolved under the pads the way they always did — first as texture, then as rhythm, then, with a lurch she never got used to, as *voice*. Someone had pressed these. A reed stylus, the triangular tip, the wrist-turn for the diagonal Winkelhaken. She could feel where the boy had pressed too hard near the start of a line, fresh and confident, and where he had gone shallow at the end, tired, the clay drying, the light going.

"It's the making," she said. The room had gone quiet around her in the way rooms did when she read aloud, and she didn't notice, which was its own kind of mercy. "Nintu — the womb-goddess — she's. They've killed a god. For the blood." Her finger stopped. "𒀭𒊩𒌆𒍪am. Clay. They mix the clay with the blood and the e𒀭𒊩𒌆𒍪mu—" she said the word the way it was, with the doubled consonant sitting in the throat — "the ghost. The spirit. So that the dead god is *in* the clay, so the new thing will have a—" she searched, and the searching was the only thing on her face — "a drum. A heartbeat. *uppu*. So that there will be a drumbeat in the flesh, and the living will hear it, and remember they are made of someone who died."

Nobody said anything. The fluorescent tube that worked buzzed.

"To do the work," Omar said quietly. "The gods are tired of digging the canals. So they make us. To carry it."

"To carry it," Naila agreed. "And to die, so the gods don't have to. The drum is the ghost. The ghost is the death already inside the clay." She lifted her fingers off the photograph and looked at her own hand as if it had told her something. "That's the wage. You get to be a person. The price is you carry a dead god and you end."

Mira had her own photograph out now, from her own folder, and she laid it on the table next to Huda's. The same raking light. Different museum, different ink-stamp in the corner. A different language.

"Genesis 2," she said. "*wayyîṣer YHWH elohîm et-ha'adam afar min-ha'adamah*. God formed the man, dust from the ground. *adam* from *adamah*. The man from the soil. And then he breathes." She tapped the photo. "*nišmat ṣayyîm*. The breath of life. So that the dust will live."

She put the two photographs side by side and did not say anything else, because the point made itself and Mira had learned, late and at cost, that the worst thing you could do to a point that made itself was explain it.

Clay and a breath. Clay and a ghost. The man from the *adamah*. The thing from the *ṣayyîm*. A thousand years and four hundred miles and a marched, defeated hill-tribe sitting in the libraries of the people who had marched them, finding the older draft of their own beginning written in the enemy's hand, and carrying it home, and keeping what they could use and changing what they could not bear.

"Here's the part nobody put on the television," Mira said. "It isn't theft. Nobody copied anybody. Look what's *gone*." Her finger moved between the two. "In Atrahasis the man is made because the gods are sick of working and they need a slave that dies so they can rest. In Genesis the man is made and put in a garden and told to *tend* it, and the dying comes later, as a wound, as a thing that went wrong. Same clay. They threw out the slavery. They kept the dust and the breath and they threw out the part where you exist to dig somebody else's canal forever."

"That," said Huda, "is the most interesting sentence anyone has said

in this room in a year.”

This was the potato, and Naila felt it land in her chest the way the heat had landed in her sinuses. The easy story — *aliens made us to mine gold* — was easy because it was whole. It had a beginning and a planet and a motive and a slick host under good lights. It survived precisely because nothing in it had ever broken.

The real thing was a fragment. The real thing was less than half a tablet, sheared on the diagonal, copied by a boy who could not plan ahead. The line that ran from the *ʾġam* to the *adamah* — the actual, traceable, mainstream-scholarship line, the genealogy of the most-read book on Earth — did not run through stone. It ran through loss. It ran through fire and flood and looting and a school-tablet that survived because someone happened to throw it on a rubbish heap that happened to bake instead of rot. For every line Naila could read with her fingers there were ten she could not, because they were gone, dust gone back to dust, no breath in them.

The truth was not hidden. That was the host’s lie, the comforting one. The truth was *partial*, and partial was harder, because partial meant you had to be honest about the gap and you could not fill it with a planet.

“How much is missing,” Lens asked. It was the first thing he’d said. He still had not raised the camera.

Huda looked at the fragment for a long moment.

“From this tablet? Half.” She gestured, a small flat motion that took in the shelves, the building, the country, the century. “From the whole? We don’t know what we don’t have. That is the true answer and nobody likes it. We find a new line every decade that rewrites a sentence everyone was sure of. There could be a tablet in a basement in a city I cannot name that ends this argument forever, and it has been there for ninety years under a wrong label, and the man who could read it is dead, and his student went to America.” The dryness again, thinner now. “Or it was sold in 2003 for the price of a car.”

It was Huda who found the hand.

She had been quiet while they argued, the way she had been quiet all trip, watching them be loud about her ancestors' genius with the patience of a woman who knew it was *hers* to be loud about and was choosing, for reasons of her own, to let them have the noise. Now she pulled the lamp closer, the one with the bend in its neck, and angled it low across the broken edge of the fragment, almost flat to the surface.

"Come here. Not you—" as Omar surged — "you. The one who reads with her hands. You'll see it best."

Naila came.

In the raking light, along the very bottom of the surviving clay, below the last full line, were three wedges. Cramped. A name-sized cluster, the size a person makes when they want to be remembered but don't have room and aren't sure they're allowed.

"A colophon," Huda said. "The scribe signs his work. Date, name, sometimes a prayer. Most of it's broken off — it ran into the part that's gone." Her finger hovered, the nail just clear of the surface, the way Naila's did, the same instinct in a different woman. "But this survives. *Ip-pu*. Part of a name. And 𐤀 e. The start of 𐤀e𐤀ru — *the young one*. The junior. The student."

"His name's broken," Mira said.

"His name's broken," Huda agreed. "Forever, probably. I will never know what to call him. But I know he was a boy who could not plan ahead, who pressed too hard at the start of a line and ran shallow at the end, who copied the story of why we die and signed it *the young one* because his teacher made him." She straightened. Something had gone very still and very private in her face, and Naila looked away from it because she had been taught, finally, by these people, that some faces are not for reading. "He is not in any catalogue. He has no number. He is the hand. I am going to mark the hand."

She took a pencil — a soft pencil, archival — and on the foam beside the tray, not on the clay, never on the clay, she wrote a small bracket and a question mark and a single word in Arabic, and Naila did not ask what it said, and Huda did not offer, and that was correct.

Lens raised the camera. Once. He did not photograph the tablet.

He photographed the seam.

Because that was the thing none of them had said, the thing that was sitting on the table in two photographs and one broken tray, and it was Naila, in the end, who saw it the way Lens had already framed it.

There was a join. Not in the clay — the clay was sheared and would never be whole. The join was in the air above the table, between Huda's photograph and Mira's, between the *ẓāḥam* and the *adamah*, between the boy who signed himself *the young one* and the marched tribe that carried his grandfather's story home and threw out the slavery and kept the dust. You could see it. The myth and the history were lying side by side under one tired fluorescent tube, and the line between them was right there, visible, a hand's breadth of foam and a thousand years.

Visible. And not closed.

The seam ran straight off the edge of the surviving clay and into the part that was gone, where the boy's full name was, where the line went next, where the rest of the answer waited under a wrong label in a basement in a city Huda could not name — or didn't.

"What were they *for*," Omar said softly, the question that was always coming, the only honest one left. "The Anunnaki. The princely offspring. Not the planet — that's dead. The *idea*. What's it for."

Huda picked up the bracketed foam and held it a moment, the unnamed hand cradled in graphite.

"Ask him," she said, and set it down beside the break.

Outside, the call to prayer started up over Nasiriyah, and the fragment sat in its light, signed and unfinished, and nobody reached to close the gap, because the gap was the whole point, and it was hers.

Chapter 20 — Inheritance

The tea came in glasses too hot to hold, which was the point. You waited. You let the steam do its work on the back of your hand and you waited, and while you waited the man who'd poured it watched the street the way everyone in Baghdad watched the street — not afraid, just literate, reading the traffic for grammar Mira couldn't parse.

They were on a balcony above Mutanabbi Street, the booksellers' street, where the Friday market had spilled paper across the pavement until the road itself looked typeset. Below them a boy was selling Qur'ans and pirated calculus textbooks off the same blanket. A man in a wheelchair sold dictionaries. Somebody had laid out a run of water-stained Agatha Christies in English, spines up, like fish on ice.

"You know she wrote here," Omar said. He had his feet on the railing and a glass balanced on his knee in a way that made Lens, two chairs down, physically unable to relax. "Christie. *Murder in Mesopotamia*. Her husband dug at Ur. She washed the pottery. Mallowan. She used to clean three-thousand-year-old ivory with her face cream."

"That's apocryphal," Mira said.

"It's *true* apocryphal. There's a difference." He tipped his head back. "Everybody who comes here writes the place down and takes it home. That's the whole — that's the entire racket, isn't it. You come, you look, you leave with a book."

Below, the boy folded a Qur'an in newspaper for a buyer, handling it with two hands, the way you'd lift something asleep.

Here is the part that is true, and that nobody disputes, and that you can check tonight against a library catalogue without leaving your chair.

The stories travelled. Not metaphorically — physically, on baked clay and in human memory, down trade roads and exile roads, from a flooded southern marsh into a hill kingdom that would one day be marched, in chains, back down those same roads into Babylon. The Flood narrative of *Gilgamesh* Tablet XI sits in the British Museum, K.3375, and it is older than the Flood narrative in Genesis by something on the order of a thousand years. This is not a fringe reading. It is in the standard commentaries. Hermann Gunkel wrote it down before the First World War. It is taught, in seminaries, to people who go on to preach the text with their whole hearts and lose nothing in the trade.

A man builds a boat. He seals it with pitch. He sends out birds to test the water — a dove, a swallow, a raven. The waters fall. He makes a sacrifice on a mountain, and the gods, or God, smell the savour and are moved.

That is two stories. It is also, in the bones, one story, twice.

The official account of how this happened is sober and well-evidenced and beautiful: a small people, defeated, deported, sat for two generations in the libraries of the empire that had broken them, and found there the older drafts of their own beginnings — and did not throw them away. They *answered* them. They took the council of squabbling gods and made it one God. They took the flood sent because humanity was *noisy* and made it a flood sent because humanity was *cruel*. They argued with the source. You can hear the argument if you read the two side by side, and the argument is the inheritance.

So. That is the official story, and it is correct, and the crew had spent five chapters loving it.

“I keep getting stuck on the verb,” Mira said.

Omar waited. He’d learned to wait; it had taken him eleven months and Naila standing on his foot twice.

"Inherit. We say a culture *inherits* a story like it's a watch in a drawer. Like it just — sits there, and then it's yours, and you wind it." She turned her glass a quarter-turn on the rail, lining the seam up with the railing's edge without deciding to. "But you can't inherit a watch you have to rebuild from someone else's blueprint in a language you only half speak while the previous owner is standing in the room telling you you've got it wrong."

"That's most inheritances," Omar said. "You should meet my uncles."

"It's not ownership. That's the — that's the thing I can't make come out clean." She frowned at the street. "Sitchin owned it. That's what people loved. He gave you a thing you could *hold*. The gods came down, they mined the gold, they made us out of apes to swing the picks, and here's the seal that proves it, here's the planet, here's the orbit — it's *yours*, you possess it now, you know the secret. Ownership feels like understanding. It's the cheapest version of understanding there is and it feels exactly like the real one."

"*Twelve planets*," came Hecklefish's voice from the laptop propped in the chair between them, screen turned to the shade. "*He counted twelve planets in a four-thousand-year-old picture the size of a postage stamp and one of them was a man named Dubsiga and the genre's been running on it for fifty years. I'd be embarrassed. I'm a fish. I have no skull. I'd still be embarrassed.*"

"He's not wrong," Mira said, "and he should still shut up."

"*The seal's a dedication. 'To Dubsiga, from his servant, may he be well.' It's a get-well card. They turned a get-well card into a solar system.*" The fish paused. "*It's almost beautiful. He wanted it so bad.*"

That last part Mira let stand, because it was the only honest thing the heckle had ever said.

The hole, the real one, the one the debunk leaves open because it isn't *its* hole to close:

Everyone agrees the alien reading is dead. Sumerologists agree, Assyriologists agree, the dictionary agrees — *nibiru* is "crossing-place," it's Jupiter at its station, you can see it from a roof in Nasiriyah on a

clear night without a spaceship in sight; *Anunnaki* is “the princely offspring,” gods on thrones, not pilots in cockpits; the three-thousand-six-hundred is a base-sixty number, the same arithmetic that still cuts your hour into minutes. Killed in the clay. The crew had watched it die. It was a clean death.

But here is what the clean death does not tell you. It does not tell you *why the stories moved at all*.

Because they didn’t have to. A defeated people, dragged to the centre of the world that defeated them, could have refused the library. Could have sat in Babylon and held their own small story shut like a fist and called the rest blasphemy. Plenty of conquered peoples did exactly that and the stories died with them in a single generation, unrecorded, and we will never know what was lost because losing it was the whole event.

These ones didn’t refuse. They *read the enemy’s books*. They took the noise-flood and the boat and the birds and the savour-of-the-sacrifice and they carried it home and built it into the holiest thing they had, and they did it so well that three thousand years later a man in a wheelchair on Mutanabbi Street could sell that exact story, the flood and the boat and the dove, folded in newspaper, to a buyer who handled it like something asleep.

The transmission is the hole. Not *whether* — *why*. Nobody in any of the standard commentaries can tell you why a beaten people inherits its conqueror’s draft instead of burning it. That is not a settled question. That is not even a scholar’s question, really. It’s the question under all of it, and the field is honest enough to leave it open.

The crew had spent the whole journey thinking the prize was the texts.

The prize was the verb.

Huda found them an hour later, climbing the balcony stairs with a folder under her arm and dust on her good shoes. She refused the tea, then took it, then held it without drinking the way the local always did — the tea was an excuse, not a beverage.

“My student,” she said, without preamble, because preamble was for people with time, “is teaching her own students this week. First-years.

Sumerian sign-list. *Ah, engur, abzu.*" She set the folder on the table. "I sat at the back. I have not sat at the back of a room in twenty years. It was unbearable. She got the determinative for *deity* wrong twice and I did not correct her and I aged a decade."

"She got it wrong, or the textbook got it wrong?" Omar asked.

"The textbook is German and forty years old and assumes you already know what it is teaching you." Huda's mouth did the thing that was almost a smile. "She corrected the textbook. In front of the class. Then she got it wrong again. Both, in the same hour. That is what teaching is."

Mira watched the folder, not Huda — she always watched the made thing first, it was where her eye went, it was how she was built. Photocopies. A first-year's handout, the signs printed large, the wedges drawn fat and patient so a sixteen-year-old's hand could find them.

"Can I ask something rude," Mira said.

"You will regardless."

"Does it bother you that we're here. Not — Archer. Us. People who'll leave. People who'll write it down and take it home." She made herself look up. "We came for the same thing the streaming crews come for. The story. We're — better behaved. But we're the same shape. We come, we look, we leave with a book."

Huda set the tea down. Down on the street the booksellers were starting to pack, folding the blankets up over the spines, the road going back to being a road.

"You think the question is whether you own it," she said.

"I think I just realised that's the wrong question and I don't know the right one yet."

"No." Huda picked up the first-year's handout, the fat patient wedges, and turned it so Mira could see. "Nobody owns this. *I* don't own this. I have given my whole life to it and it is not mine. It was not the scribes' — they copied what was already old. It was not Babylon's; Babylon found it in the south and carried it north. The Hebrews did not own it; they argued with it, and you do not argue with what you own, you argue with what was given to you that you did not ask for." She set the handout down between them, very lightly, the way the man

below had folded the Qur'an. "Ownership is the alien story. *Mine, the secret, I possess it now.* That is Sitchin's whole gift and it is why people loved him and I will not laugh at them for it because it is a real hunger and he fed it with sawdust."

"Sawdust," the fish said, with deep satisfaction. "*Write that down.*"

"What's the right question, then," Mira said.

Huda looked at her for a long moment, and Mira braced for the answer, because it was Huda's to give — it had always been Huda's to give, the whole way, that was the only law that had never bent — and Mira had finally learned to sit still inside the gap and not reach for it.

Huda gave it.

"Not *who owns it. Who is in the room when it is passed.*" She tapped the handout. "My student is in the room. Her students are in the room. You four are in the room, today, on this balcony, with the wrong tea, asking rude questions. That is all anyone has ever been. The scribe was a witness. The exile was a witness. The man who wrote Genesis was a witness to something a thousand years older that he did not own and could not have owned and would not have wanted to own — he wanted to *answer* it. To be in the room and say *no, not noise — cruelty. Not many gods — one. Here is what I would change.*" She drank her tea, finally, all of it, fast. "You inherit a story the way you inherit a language. Not by owning a word. By being trusted to be in the room when it is said, and to say it again, a little wrong, to someone younger, who will correct you, and get it wrong themselves."

Omar had gone very still, which for Omar was a kind of shout.

"We're not owners," he said.

"You were never going to be owners. You're not equipped." Huda almost smiled again. "You're witnesses. It is a smaller job than the streaming people think they are doing. It is the only job there has ever been."

The booksellers were gone by the time they came down, the road bare and grey and ordinary, the way the floor of Room 55 was ordinary under the glass, the way a roof in Nasiriyah was ordinary under Jupiter. Mira stood on the empty pavement where the spines had

been laid out like fish on ice and felt the shape of the thing settle without closing.

They had walked in through the alien door. *Were the gods aliens.* The grandest, gaudiest door the genre had ever built, and they'd loved the people who built it, and they'd watched the answer die honest in the clay: no. Killed clean. The crossing-place is Jupiter. The seal is a get-well card. The princely offspring sit on thrones.

And they'd come out the far side into the bigger room, and the bigger room was this: an empty street where the oldest story we can read had just been sold, folded in newspaper, by a man who did not own it to a buyer who did not own it, in a city that had been carrying it longer than anyone had been writing it down. A first-year, this week, getting the sign for *god* wrong, twice, in front of a teacher who let her.

The why was still open. Why does a beaten people read its conqueror's books. Why does anyone carry the older draft home instead of burning it. Huda had not closed it. Nobody had closed it. It sat there on the empty pavement, the size of the whole road, and it was not theirs to close, and Mira found she could stand inside it now without flinching, which was the only thing the journey had actually taught her.

"What were they *for*," Omar said quietly. "The Anunnaki. That was the whole question, the start. What were they for."

Lens lowered the camera. He'd been shooting the empty street, the blankets gone, and now he let it hang.

"They were for being in the room," he said, "when it got passed."

Up the stairs behind them, a glass clinked. Huda, going back to her students. The road, going back to being a road. And somewhere south, the river that all of it had come up from, running the way it had run before anyone could read, carrying nothing it owned, downstream, toward the sea.

Chapter 21 — The Restoration

The light at Ur comes up the colour of the brick it falls on, so that for the first hour of morning you cannot tell where the ziggurat ends and the day begins. Edith had been told this by three different people and had not believed any of them. Now she stood on the lowest of the great staircases with the camera dead in her hands and believed it completely, and did not raise the lens, because there are things the lens makes smaller by trying.

She raised it anyway. It was the job.

Through the viewfinder the staircase climbed in three flights toward a platform that no longer held the shrine it was built to hold — the shrine was four thousand years gone, the god with it — and the brick went up in courses laid by men whose names were pressed, some of them, into the very bricks under her feet. *For Nanna, his king, Ur-Nammu, king of Ur, king of Sumer and Akkad, the one who built the temple of Nanna.* Huda had read it to her yesterday off a brick the size of a paving stone, running two fingers along the wedges the way a person reads a face they have known a long time, and the reading had taken eight seconds, and Edith had spent the afternoon thinking about the eight seconds.

“You’re shooting the steps again,” Omar said, behind her, not moving, which for Omar was a kind of event.

“I’m shooting the joins.”

“That’s the steps.”

“It’s where two days of work meet,” Edith said. “Whoever laid the

lower course went home, and somebody else came back the next morning and started where he stopped. You can see the seam.” She lowered the camera. “I like seams.”

The official story, the one the foundation’s people would have filmed here if they’d gotten the permit — and they had tried; Archer had tried three times, charmingly, with letters on heavy paper — was simple and shining and had been told ten thousand times. *They could not have built this. Look at the scale. Look at the precision of the brick. Look at the alignment to the cardinal points, the casing, the engineering of the core. A Bronze Age people, mud-hut people, slave people — they were given this. Someone came down and showed them how.*

It is a beautiful story. It has been believed, in one dress or another, by clever people and kind people, by your uncle and possibly by you at two in the morning, and the camera does not sneer at it, because the camera has stood under the thing and felt the want it answers — the want to make the impossible make sense by handing it up to the sky.

So play it straight. The ziggurat at Ur is one of the best-preserved in Iraq. Its lowest stage was reconstructed in the twentieth century on the ancient core, and the core itself is genuine third-millennium-BCE work: a solid mass of mud-brick faced with a skin of kiln-fired brick set in bitumen, the whole thing pierced with weep-holes so the rain could drain and the mass not burst. Ur-Nammu raised it; his son Shulgi finished it; the Neo-Babylonians under Nabonidus rebuilt the upper stages a millennium and a half later, and Nabonidus left an inscription complaining, essentially, that the old kings had not built high enough.

Now the potato.

Go and make a brick.

Not buy one. Make one, the way they made these — the facing brick, the fired kind. You need clay, and the clay must be cleaned of stone, and you need a temper to keep it from cracking as it dries, chaff or sand in the right proportion, and you need a mould, and you need to know the proportion of water by feel because no one will write it down

for you, and you need to dry the green brick *slowly*, out of the direct sun or it skins over and the inside stays wet and it splits, and then you need a kiln, which means you need fuel, and southern Mesopotamia has no forest, so the fuel is reeds and dung and whatever you can float down the river, and you need to know the firing curve — too fast and it shatters, too cool and it stays mud — and the temperature you are reaching for is north of nine hundred degrees, held, in a structure you also had to build, and you are doing this not once but several million times, because the ziggurat at Ur, by conservative count, swallowed brick in the millions, each one a small accomplishment of chemistry that a literate scribe somewhere logged into a ledger of grain paid to the workmen who made them, by name, with their rations.

It is so much harder than a spaceship. That is the secret nobody tells you. The spaceship is easy. The spaceship lets you off. The brick is the thing that costs.

Huda came up the steps at nine with eleven students behind her and a roll of cloth under her arm, and Edith began, quietly, to work.

The students were from the university at Nasiriyah, four women and seven men, the youngest maybe nineteen, all of them in the bad shoes of people who walk a long way to learn things. Two carried a folding table. One carried a box of the small acid-free trays the conservators use, and in the trays, packed in foam, were tablets — not the famous ones, not the Flood, nothing from behind the glass in London, but local finds, administrative clay, the receipts and contracts and schoolboy exercises that are the true literature of the place: nine hundred and ninety percent of all cuneiform ever excavated is somebody's accounts.

Edith photographed the box being set on the table. She photographed a girl's hands lifting a tablet free of the foam — the careful two-handed lift, the way you'd lift a sleeping animal. She photographed the tablet itself, a palm-sized thing the colour of weak tea, and the wedges across it, and she did not know what they said and that was the point of the frame: *here is the thing, and here is the not-knowing, and over there is the woman who knows.*

"Receipt for barley," Huda said, reading over the girl's shoulder without taking it from her. "Two gur, given out by a man called Lu-Nanna,

to a man whose name is broken, in the third year of —” she tilted it to the light ” — Ibbi-Sin. Witnessed. Sealed.” She looked up at Edith. “Thirty-eight hundred years ago a man counted his barley and somebody wrote it down so no one could cheat him. You want the gods who came down from the sky? *That’s* them. The men who invented the receipt. The first people on Earth who decided a thing should be *written so it could not be lied about later.*” A dry beat. “Try doing that with a campfire and a memory.”

Naila had come up without anyone hearing her and was crouched at the table now, one finger hovering over a second tablet, not touching. “May I?”

“You’ll read it with your hands,” Huda said. It was not a question. The two women had taken each other’s measure on the first day and arrived at something that was not friendship and was better than friendship for the work — a mutual refusal to perform. “Go on. Tell me what it is before you turn it over.”

Naila set two fingertips on the clay and closed her eyes, and Edith lifted the camera and then did not press the shutter, because there is a frame you do not take, and this was one — the woman who reads the dead language with her skin, reading, with the woman who owns the language watching to see if she’s right.

“School text,” Naila said. “It’s a list. It’s — repetitions. Someone practising the same sign.” Her finger moved. “Over and over. A child.”

“A child,” Huda agreed. “Learning to write the sign for *king*. Badly. Look —” she turned it for the camera now, deliberately, giving Edith the shot ” — see how the third one runs downhill? He was tired. He was four thousand years ago and he was tired and he wanted to go outside.” She set it down with great gentleness. “This is what they took from us. Not the gold. Not the spaceships. *Him*. The bored child learning to write. They looked at this —” she lifted her chin at the ziggurat going up gold behind them ” — and they could not let it be the bored child’s people who built it, so they gave it to aliens, and the aliens were a kindness to themselves, you understand, because if aliens built it then nobody has to feel the size of what they erased.”

Omar, very quietly, in Arabic, said something Edith did not catch, and Huda answered him in Arabic, and the students laughed, and Edith

did not ask for the translation because some of the room is not yours.

Here is the hole, and it is small and it is hard as a kiln-brick and you can check it tonight.

The skeptics won. They were *right*. There is no Planet Nibiru; the word means *crossing-place* and it is Jupiter, and you can watch it cross tonight if the sky is clear; the seal called VA 243 that the genre swears is a map of the solar system is a dedication, in plain cuneiform, to a man called Dubsiga; the Anunnaki are *the princely offspring*, divine functionaries, and they no more flew here in ships than the receipt for barley did. The clay killed the aliens. That part is over, and the people who killed it were doing honest work.

But go and read the *museum label*. Go and read the documentary, the good one, the responsible BBC-voiced one that debunks Sitchin properly. It says: *Sitchin was wrong. Nibiru is Jupiter. The end*. And then it stops. And in stopping, it walks the reader straight back out the door past the actual treasure without turning the lights on it — because the documentary, too, finds it easier to win the argument it was having than to face the stranger one underneath: that the people whose receipts these are, whose tired child these are, also wrote the older draft of the Flood, of the man made from clay, of the garden — and that draft is on tablets a thousand years older than the Hebrew one, and the Hebrew one *knows it*, answers it, argues with it, line by line. The debunkers closed the file marked ALIENS so neatly that nobody checked the much larger file underneath, the one marked GENESIS, the one with the most-read book on Earth inside it and a Mesopotamian return address.

That gap — between how completely the alien story was closed and how completely the real story was left lying in the foam, unread, on a table at the foot of a ziggurat — that is the hole. It is not a maybe about spaceships. There are no spaceships. It is a question about who was allowed to be the author of the human beginning.

“Why,” Huda said — and she was not asking Edith, she was reading the broken receipt again, turning it, *what is this for* — “do you think they wrote the man being made from clay? Their man. The one in *Atrahasis*, a thousand years before anybody’s Adam.”

Mira, who had been silent on the lower step the whole hour, looked up. “To explain why we work,” she said. “The gods are tired of digging the canals. So they kill one of their own and mix his blood with clay and make us, to carry the load.” A pause. “We’re made to do the labour the gods got tired of.”

“Yes,” said Huda. “And in Genesis?”

“He’s made to keep a garden,” Mira said slowly. “Same clay. Same breath. But he’s — given the work as a gift first. Then it becomes a punishment. It’s the same story arguing with itself.”

Huda looked at her for a long moment, and something passed across her face that Edith caught and held in the frame forever: not surprise that the outsider had read it — they had all read it — but a flicker of permission given. *You may say that. You read it right.* And then she took it back into her own hands where it belonged. “Close,” she said. “But the Hebrew writer is not copying. He’s *answering*. He grew up in our libraries — his grandfathers were marched down to Babylon, they sat by the canals their conquerors made them dig, and they read our story of why men dig canals, and they said: *no. Not for tired gods. Not as slaves to the labour. For a covenant. For a God who walks in the cool of the day and calls you by name.*” She set the tablet down. “It’s the most defiant thing in the whole Bible and nobody reads it that way, because to read it that way you have to admit our story came first, and that admission has been very hard for a great many people for a very long time.”

Nobody said anything. The fish, who had been suspiciously quiet, surfaced. “*So you’re telling me,*” it said, “*the slickest plagiarism case in human history is actually the Bronze Age’s most savage subtweet.*”

“I’m telling you,” Huda said, not missing a beat, “it’s a son arguing with his father about what a man is for. You can decide which one is right. That part was never mine to hand out.”

She unrolled the cloth at the end of it, on the platform, with the day full and white now and the brick gone from gold to bone. There was no microphone. There was no foundation, no logo, no donor wall. There was a woman and her students and a table of receipts at the top of the oldest school in the world, and Huda said a few words in Arabic

that Edith did not record because Naila, beside her, shook her head once — *not this* — and Edith lowered the camera and held it against her chest and let the words go out over the desert untaken, which was the only true thing the camera did all day.

Then the students each took up a tablet, the bored child's, the cheated farmer's, and carried them — not to a crate bound for a foundation's climate-controlled vault in a city that is not this one, but to a van bound for their own museum at Nasiriyah, fifteen kilometres up the road, where the labels would be in Arabic first.

Jakobus was at the bottom of the steps when they came down, where he had been the whole time, in the shade, having mended the van's failing door-latch with a strip of brass and a screwdriver while the others were up top, so that the tablets would not be jostled on the road. He handed the keys to the eldest student — a serious young man named Karim who would, Huda said, outlive all of them in the work — and said something short, and the young man laughed, and Jakobus stepped back.

He was always stepping back. It was the whole of him. He had read the latch and the road and the foam and the weight, and he had handed the rest — the meaning, the moment, the why — to the people whose meaning it was, and now he leaned on the van and watched them load their own past into their own vehicle to take to their own house, and his face had nothing on it but the small satisfaction of a door that would not bang open at speed.

Edith took one last frame. Not the ziggurat. The open van, the brass latch catching the light, eleven young people of Ur lifting the clay their ancestors fired, and at the edge, going out of frame, the backs of the crew, walking away.

Up the road, in Baghdad, Archer was on a phone he kept calm, learning that the permit would not come, that the narrative had a custodian now and her name was on the labels, and that the story he had wanted to *take* had instead been *handed* — over his head, past his money, into the only hands that were ever going to keep it.

The van pulled out. The dust came up the colour of the brick.

Whether the bored child knew he was building the foundation of every beginning we'd ever tell about ourselves — that one stays on the table.

Read it with your hands. Decide.

Chapter 22 — Real / Debated / Invented

The reading room of the British Library smells of paper and old coffee. Mira has a desk by the window, the kind they let you keep for a week if you fill in the right form, and on it she has built a small city of books and printouts and one battered legal pad. The pad is the point. Everything in this chapter came off that pad, eventually, so we may as well do you the courtesy of showing you the pad.

She has drawn three columns. She drew them on the first day in Baghdad and she has redrawn them, in airports and basements and the back of Jakobus's van, perhaps forty times since. The headings never change.

REAL. DEBATED. INVENTED.

It is the most honest thing in the book, and the least dramatic, which is why it lives at the back where you go only if you cared enough to keep turning. Welcome. You cared. Sit down.

Here is the column marked **REAL**, and we are going to be boring about it on purpose, because the whole machine only works if you can check it.

The Flood Tablet exists. It is **K.3375**, the eleventh tablet of the standard Babylonian *Gilgamesh*, and you can stand in front of it in Room 55 of the British Museum, where George Smith read it in 1872 and got so excited he reportedly began undressing in the gallery. The flood, the ark, the door sealed with pitch, the birds sent out, the bird that does not return, the sacrifice the gods crowd around “like flies”

— it is all there, in Akkadian, on baked clay, and it is older than the Hebrew of Genesis by the better part of a thousand years. That is not fringe. That is the placard. You can photograph the placard.

The *Atrahasis* epic is real, and in it humankind is fashioned from clay mixed with the blood of a slain god, made to carry the gods' labour so the gods can rest — *to bear the toil*, the verb does the work — and then made mortal because they got too loud. That is **British Museum tablets** copied by a scribe named Ipiq-Aya, who signed and dated his work, which means a specific man's specific hand is the reason you can read it. Real.

The *Enuma Elish* is real, and Tiamat is real, and the Hebrew word *tehom* — “the deep” over which the spirit moves in Genesis 1:2 — is a genuine cognate of *tiamat*, the same old Semitic root for the salt-water deep. Real, and not a copy; the dossier is very firm on the difference, and so is Huda, who out-firmed us all. A shared root is not a photocopy. Two languages remembering the same ocean.

The Babylonian Exile is real. In 587 BCE the Babylonians took Jerusalem apart and walked a defeated hill-tribe's scribal and priestly class down to the very city whose libraries held the older drafts. That deportation, that proximity, that catastrophe-that-became-a-workshop — real, and dated, and in 2 Kings if you want it in the scripture's own voice.

And the demolition of the alien story is real, which we put in the **REAL** column with love and not with a sneer, because being right is allowed to feel good as long as it doesn't make you cruel. *Nibiru* means “crossing-point” and the crossing-point it most often names is Jupiter, which you can see tonight if the sky is clear and you are willing to wait for it; it is never, in any tablet, the home planet of the Anunnaki. *Anunnaki* means, roughly, “the princely offspring” — the seed of the prince, the high god's children. The 3,600 is *šar*, an ordinary base-sixty numeral, the same arithmetic that gave us sixty minutes and a circle of three hundred and sixty degrees, misread as an orbit by a man who wanted an orbit. And the famous “solar-system seal,” **VA 243** in Berlin, is a dedication. There is a man's name on it. The man is called Dubsiga. The “sun in the centre” is a star symbol of a kind that appears on hundreds of seals, and the count of the dots does not match the count of the planets, which is the sort of thing you only notice if you bother to count, and Mira bothered to count.

“You always count,” Hecklefish says, from the column he is not supposed to be in. “It’s your whole thing. Three columns and a fish. Put me in REAL.”

We will get to you.

The middle column is the hard one. **DEBATED** is where honesty lives, because anyone can be certain in the first column and anyone can be playful in the third, but the middle column is where you have to say *we don’t fully know* and mean it without flinching toward woo.

The *fact* of dialogue between the Hebrew primeval history and older Mesopotamian literature is not debated. The *mechanism* is. How, exactly, did the flood story travel? Through the exile, most scholars agree — but how much earlier, through what trade, through which scribal schools, in whose mouth across how many borrowings before anyone wrote a word of it down? That is genuinely open. Reasonable, credentialed people disagree, in journals, with footnotes, and not one of them needs a spaceship to disagree.

Whether the *Atrahasis* “noise” — the clamour of humankind that wakes the irritated god — is the same theological nerve as the corruption that brings Genesis’s flood, or only a family resemblance, is debated. The dossier marks it with the little open-circle symbol Mira uses for *this is real scholarship arguing, leave the door open*. She drew a lot of open circles in the middle column. She is proud of that. So are we.

Whether the Eden serpent owes anything to older Mesopotamian motifs, or is its own Hebrew thing — debated. Whether Babel is a satire of a specific ziggurat or of the whole imperial impulse — debated. Naila spent two days in the middle column over a single line break in a Sumerian dispute poem, and at the end of it said, with the flat satisfaction of a woman who has just refused to overstate her case, “I think it’s *probably* this. But I won’t write *is*.” That sentence is the entire ethic of the middle column. *Probably this. I won’t write is.*

There is a subtler thing in **DEBATED**, and Huda put it there herself, which is why it gets to stay.

We came to Iraq following the *transmission*. We wanted the genealogy of Genesis, the clean line from clay to scripture, the chain you

could hold up and rattle. And Huda Abbas sat us down in her office in Nasiriyah, under the dead air-conditioner, with the tea going cold, and said the thing that goes in the middle column and stays there.

“You want a chain,” she said. “A then B then C. The tidy descent. I understand. It is a good story and most of it is even true.” She turned a sherd over in her fingers the way Jakobus turns a thing he’s reading. “But people did not pass these stories like a relay baton. They lived next to each other for centuries. They traded, intermarried, were conquered and conquered back, told the stories badly in second languages, forgot the names and kept the shape. *Transmission* is your clean word for a thing that was never clean.” She set the sherd down. “Write that it happened. You may not write *exactly how*. Nobody may. The man on your screen who says he knows exactly how the aliens did it — he and the man who says he knows exactly how the exile worked are closer cousins than either would like.”

Mira wrote it in the middle column. She wrote it in Huda’s words, not her own, which is the only reason it earned its place.

The third column is short and you already know what’s in it.

INVENTED. Us. The chase. Mira’s hyperlexia is a real wiring and Mira is not a real person; we built her to *be* the way a certain kind of mind reads a room nobody let it stop watching. Omar moves the way ADHD moves and Omar is invented; we gave him the questions because somebody has to be allowed to ask the rude one out loud. Naila reads cuneiform with her fingers, which real epigraphers have genuinely learned to do — the wedges have depth, you can feel a damaged sign your eyes would skip — and Naila herself is a fiction stitched from that real skill and a late diagnosis and a fierce loyalty we wanted in the room. LENS is invented, and the cost LENS sees in every frame is not.

The funding-foundation race is invented in its particulars and bone-true in its premise: there are people, right now, with real money, who want the *objects* and the *narrative* more than they want the truth, and the looting of Iraqi heritage during and after 2003 is, regrettably, the realest thing in this book. Dr. Simon Archer is invented. The belief that history is a possession of the powerful is not, and Archer’s worst hour — when he stood in the museum and understood that the

genius he'd been packaging belonged to the woman correcting his Akkadian — we invented that too, but only because we have watched real people have it.

Huda Abbas is invented. We want to be very careful here, at the back, where you came to check. Dr. Huda Abbas is not a real Assyriologist. But Iraqi Assyriologists are real, and they are extraordinary, and they have spent careers reclaiming their ancestors' genius from a Western imagination that turned the inventors of the city and the written word into the extras in a film about spacemen. We made Huda so that the book would have someone to out-read the crew on the thing that matters — because in real life that someone exists, in real offices, in Nasiriyah and Baghdad and Mosul, and we owed it to them to put their authority where it belongs: above ours. If Huda reads as wiser than the visiting band, that is not a flourish. That is the correction. The clever outsiders did not crack the natives' mystery. The native was never confused. She was waiting for the camera to point the right way.

Jakobus is invented, and Jakobus is the road, and the things Jakobus reads — the press of a stylus, the way a forged tablet bakes wrong, the weight that tells him a cylinder seal is old — those readings are real craft, and he hands every meaning to someone else, because the man who reads the made thing is not the man who gets to say what it's *for*.

So. The tools are on the desk now. You can pull every item in the first column yourself. The tablets have numbers; we gave you the numbers. The placards are public. The journals are in any university library and a great many of them are free online, and we put the better ones in the sources that follow this chapter, which is the part nobody reads and the part that makes it not a campfire story but a thing you can break if it deserves breaking.

That is the offer. Go and break it. We mean that as the highest compliment a book of this kind can pay you. *Check us.*

Mira finishes the pad. She holds it up to the window light to see if the three columns balance, which is a thing she does, weighing the honest middle against the certain edges, and she says the thing she said to Huda's voicemail the night the museum let the case stay

where it was.

“The maybe’s in the middle column.”

It is. It always was. Not in the first column, where the aliens never were — they died in the clay, cleanly, with the dots that don’t match counted out one by one. Not in the third column, where we admit we made you a band of misfits to walk you in. The maybe lives in the middle, in the open circles, in *how* a drowned story crossed a border in a defeated man’s memory and surfaced a thousand years later in the most-read book on Earth. Nobody knows the exact how. The people who tell you they know the exact how are selling you something, and the something has a planet’s name on it, and the planet is Jupiter, and you can see it tonight.

What were the Anunnaki *for*? They were for carrying the work the gods would not. The princely offspring, made of clay and a dead god’s blood, made to labour and then to die. A conquered people read that, and recognised themselves in it, and carried it home, and made it theirs — which is the only thing anyone has ever done with a story worth keeping.

“And the fish?” Hecklefish says. “What column does the fish go in?”

You go in all three, obviously. You’re real enough to heckle. You’re debated by everyone who insists a fish can’t talk. And you were invented to make sure nobody in here ever got to preach.

He considers this.

“Best column,” he says. “The maybe one.”

Yours now. We checked our work. Go check it back.

The pad goes in the bag. The light goes off the desk. The numbers are at the back.

SOURCES ☒

With thanks

This book was written in the spirit of a curiosity I learned from someone else: the discipline of taking the official story seriously, telling it straight and with real respect, finding the one honest place it does not quite close — and then trusting the reader to decide.

With genuine thanks to AJ Gentile, whose work lit that way of looking for me. The stories here are my own, the people invented or freshly drawn; what I borrowed is only the *posture* — eyes open, sneer off, wonder intact. I am grateful for it, and I hope I have done it honour.

And a quieter thanks to the keepers of the clay — the decipherers who proved, under seal, that the dead script could be read; the scholars who showed, without ever once sneering at anyone's faith, that the first chapters of the most-read book on Earth have a Mesopotamian genealogy; and the Assyrian, Iraqi, and Kurdish people who are the living heirs of the place where writing began. The wonder in this book is *theirs*. So is the achievement the genre tried to hand to the sky. I have tried to hand it back.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor